

THE LAST CHIEF

The True Story of a Truly Great Man – From Lineage to Legacy

By David Gabriel

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This book is dedicated to
Diana and Heather Bison,
perhaps the two most courageous
members of the Bison family,
who know and love Chief
better than all
of us.

The Last Chief

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PREFACE

Books written about the lives of great and famous people are endless. We call them biographies. Many of these men and women are worthy of the books that chronicle their lives. Some, not so much. Abraham Lincoln has been written about more than any other American, and most of us share the same fascination with this remarkable man. Virginia Hall has only one biography. She is probably the most courageous woman I have ever studied. Somehow, I believe she deserves much more than one biography, but Virginia Hall would not have agreed. The title of her only biography? “A Woman of No Importance.”

Most of the best books about great people help us “see” and “hear” them. When the story is well told, we “connect” with them. And after we finish these biographies, we walk away with some distinct impressions. We somehow feel as if we were “there” with those who led admirable and successful lives. We “witness” outstanding focus, drive, talent, decisions, and achievements. And although we also see mistakes or poor decisions (proving they are human, after all), we often conclude that those mistakes are rare and don’t really define the person we’ve come to know.

This biography is not about a man who changed the world. It is not about a man who changed the country, or even a state, a region, or a city. It is not about a man who started a movement. It is about a man who changed another man – me, and many others who lived within his sphere of influence. It is about a man who is simply different than other men. This man made a difference wherever he went, and left others with a lasting impression.

I worked with him for a good part of 27 years. Whatever I accomplished came from his training, teaching, example, and care for me. And while it might defy the imagination, I never saw him make a mistake (and never heard of one, for that matter). And this seemingly “near perfect” man served in a career that required many, many tough decisions every single day. Some of the things he did were so amazing that they rise to the ridiculous. Ridiculous, but true.

I connected with him. My admiration for him grew with every passing year. Every time I thought he could not possibly rise higher in my estimation, he would indeed rise even further.

As I researched and wrote this “mini” biography, one amazing fact repeatedly came to mind. While I didn’t realize it when it was happening so often in the past, I see it now very clearly. Virtually every

time I worked with the man I call “Chief” on difficult or dangerous assignments, I was mesmerized by his actions...by him. I sheepishly must now admit that back then, I watched him in awe when I should have been entirely focused on our task at hand. He never noticed my “tunnel vision” admiration. If he had, he would have lovingly put his “symbolic” arm around me and told me to keep my head (and my eyes) in the game. But he never did. He never noticed my divided focus.

After we retired, I realized that very few people merit a biography in the way that he does. Come with me as I tell you the story of his life. What I write is absolutely true. And while you may be tempted, please don’t doubt the veracity of these pages. He was life itself to me and to many others. Or, should I say, he was larger than life.

DG

AUTHOR'S NOTES TO THE READER

Richard Allan Bison was almost always called “Rich” by family and friends. I call him “Chief.” The explanation for this name follows a bit further into our story. As a police officer, he was without rival. He was simply the greatest all-around cop I’ve ever seen or heard of. There didn’t seem to be anything he couldn’t do really well. But without doubt his greatest strength, his one unrivaled skill, was leadership. I have been around leaders for over 50 years. I’ve read and studied the exploits of most of the world’s great leaders. I can say without hyperbole that Chief was among the best – in some ways the best, at least on the particular stage he occupied. He certainly was the best that I’ve ever personally seen, and that includes my three years in the army and 27 years at the police department. But before we dig deeper into his story, a note on leadership is needed.

I have been a leader for over 35 years, but I was not born a leader. I’ve spent years learning leadership. But leadership for Chief is so very different. He was born to lead, and although he never really sought leadership, he often found himself in those very positions. His innate ability to lead was far greater than mine. In fact, I don’t belong on the same pages with him. So bear with me as I try to “disappear,” and bring Chief to the eyes and ears of your mind and heart.

As you will soon see, Chief lived more than just an above average life. The categories in his remarkable life include adventures, escapades, near crazy exploits, significant risks as a boy, teen and man, and an outstanding career over his 30 years as a combat soldier and police officer. Often when I spoke to him about his amazing accomplishments, he would simply shrug – either verbally or with body language. But Chief’s life, to be sure, also included tragedy, heartbreak, and...war. Combat. His ability and determination to bounce back from difficulties and keep moving forward all of his life have been astounding and rare. This includes recovery from major health problems and several serious surgeries at the age of 77. Even as I write this section of his story, he is working hard to recover. I pray he never stops.

As I researched this brief biography and as the chapters of Chief’s life came together, it occurred to me that writing in chronological order (as in a typical police report) comes across as rather ordinary. The very last description of his life is average or ordinary. As a result, chapter one does not begin at the beginning. It actually begins about seven years after our first meeting, when I watched Chief in action during a police disaster. There, he was truly at his best.

It is also important to point out that some conversations in this book are in quotes, though not many. In virtually all dialogue with quotes, either Chief or I was part of the conversation and there is a clear memory of what was said. I have carefully avoided what is often referred to as “fictionalized additions,” or “reconstructed dialogue.” These fanciful conversations are often added to non-fiction books to bring the story to life. They also add to the books total content and improve drama and flow. The problem with these “additions” is an absence of sources, verification, and objectivity. I told Chief from the start that I would not include “reconstructed dialogue” because I wished the book to be a truly honest account of the highlights of his life. Almost like a memoir or written tribute. Chief agreed.

Last note: As I take you back to visit the story of Chief’s life, I often use the past tense. But sometimes I use the present tense as well. In some paragraphs, I use both. The reason: Chief is still alive. But even if he wasn’t, I would often use the present tense, because he has always been larger than life to me.

And as the finest example of the best of American Indians, he is the Chief. And, I believe, perhaps...
The Last Chief.

CHAPTER 1

DISASTER

March 16, 1988 – Burbank Trailer Park

As detectives, Chief and I were not exactly “partners” because most Burbank detective office units did not work in two-person teams. But we did become “unofficial” partners – in large part because I needed the help, and because Chief wanted it that way. He sometimes called me “partner.” I could not have been more thrilled. And on one seemingly normal day, a true disaster came our way.

Chief was a senior police detective, and I was a newer detective with about six months in my new position. We worked in the Juvenile Bureau of the Burbank Police Department. When we heard the field emergency alert tone, we were both in our offices: “Explosion at the trailer park, one officer injured, roll code three!” Of course, that call was directed to our marked patrol units. But Chief yelled “Let’s go,” and we ran downstairs to our unmarked (detective) car. Talk about a wild ride...

I have never been in a car that was driven faster in my life. At least not within the confines of city streets. Chief, as always, was the driver and I rode “shotgun.” We never discussed the driving configuration. Since Chief was my mentor, and because he was older (and for other reasons that will come to light), it was always understood that he would drive. I learned one of Chief’s “secrets” 45 years later about the driving setup. Chief confessed during our interviews in 2025 that he didn’t function well in the passenger seat...of any car. He certainly was never comfortable and on top of things in the passenger seat of our police vehicle. Somehow, he thought I never knew that, even though it was obvious.

Among all the things Chief could do well, handling a car was near the top. I have never seen a better driver in my life. He drove a car the way an Indian warrior could ride a horse bareback in a chaotic battle. He was a better driver than me, even though I had been to three pursuit driving schools. In the last school, I was trained as a police driving instructor. And yet he was better. Sheesh.

As he drove us furiously to the trailer park, I asked Chief what experience he had with explosives when he was in the army. He starts listing them: LAWS rockets (m72 LAW anti-tank weapon), C-4 explosives, and on and on. My amazement and admiration of him soared even higher (with apparently no limit).

When we arrived at Burbank’s only trailer park, we found Officer Gabriel Alvarez lying completely prone on the ground outside one particular trailer. The injured Alvarez held his right arm high

in the air, and we could see a belt around his wrist that served as a tourniquet. What we didn't initially see were most of the parts of his right hand. Blood was on the ground beside him. But more startling were parts of his right hand and fingers, which were scattered in the form of flesh and bone on the ground around him. We also saw rookie officer McDonald standing next to him.

Although a patrol sergeant arrived and was "in charge" of the scene, there was a very quick transfer of leadership when Chief and I arrived. As I focused one eye on Alvarez and one eye on Chief, I realized that I had a front row seat to watch Chief effortlessly take on the leadership of one great big mess.

At about this time, Juvenile Detective Doyle Holm arrived at the scene to offer help. Although Doyle was not really made to be a cop (he was just too nice), he was entirely unflappable. He was the essence of calm, all the time. I watched Doyle begin to pick up pieces of the injured officer's hand that were scattered all over the ground and place them in a handkerchief. I wasn't sure why, since it didn't seem possible for surgeons to reattach all those pieces like some jigsaw puzzle. But being a rookie detective, I said nothing.

We learned that the teenage boy who lived in the trailer in question was fond of using CO2 cartridges to construct funny little bombs. His permissive mother didn't like her son's peculiar hobby and called Burbank Police when she noticed one of his "toys" sitting on a shelf in the living room. When Officers Alvarez and McDonald arrived, the boy wasn't in the trailer. His mother pointed out the device to the officers, and Officer Alvarez recklessly picked it up with his right hand. Immediately the mother warned Alvarez that it could be dangerous and should not be touched. Rookie Officer McDonald also warned Alvarez to be careful with the device. Alvarez chuckled and made some questioning remark about the silliness of a simple CO2 canister being dangerous.

Alvarez then walked outside of the trailer's front door with the device still in his right hand, and the device exploded. Officer McDonald went outside, used her radio to report the incident, and requested help. With Alvarez in a completely prone position on his back, McDonald used a belt to make a tourniquet on Alvarez' right arm to stem the flow of blood and directed him to keep his arm straight up in the air.

When we arrived, Chief calmly went to work managing the entire scene. And the patrol sergeant let him. Chief seemingly did several things at once. He quickly learned from patrol what had

occurred, and directed fellow officers and detectives to tape off the crime scene, block off all traffic in and out, ensure paramedics were rolling, establish a clear pathway for the paramedics to reach Alvarez, clear the trailer of possible remaining people, arrange for evidence technicians to respond, find the teenager who made these “toys,” and have our communications center ask the Sheriff’s Department to assist us with their bomb unit. It was truly a whirlwind, but a logical, carefully assessed whirlwind (remember, when you think impossible, with Chief seemingly all things are possible).

The Los Angeles Sheriff’s Department bomb squad arrived and Chief briefed them and offered assistance while the trailer and surrounding areas were checked for more explosive materials. Some were found, and from a distance away, the Sheriff’s bomb squad prepared to destroy the explosive materials at the scene with special apparatus. I could not see Chief at this point, but I heard his unmistakable voice yell the pre-detonation warning: “Fire in the Hole!” That warning was followed by a single, very loud explosion. That was the first time I learned something that Chief already knew: bomb squads don’t generally transport dangerous substances. They usually dispose of them by exploding them on site.

As we drove back to the station after the trailer park calamity, I remember trying to process all that had occurred – including the fact that Officer Alvarez’ career was over. But for Chief, this incident was truly not all that challenging. Years later I realized why this wasn’t a huge challenge to Chief after I had been a patrol sergeant (supervisor) for a few months. When we arrived at the scene, Chief actually started from a relatively static rather than dynamic position. Things were not moving and changing rapidly. The teenager was found near the trailer, so there was no extended hunt for suspects. All the involved parties were known to us so there was no “who done it” feature to deal with. Paramedics arrived shortly after we did, and Officer Alvarez became their primary responsibility. And the Sheriff’s Department handled all the remaining problems associated with explosive materials. But while managing this scene was fairly simple for Chief, I don’t believe many other supervisors would have handled it so smoothly and so quickly because of the serious injuries to a brother officer. It shook many of us to the core to see a fellow officer with most of his hand blown off. Chief had handled many critical situations involving badly injured fellow soldiers in Vietnam. This situation simply highlighted the effortless way he led others in a situation of semi-chaos. I do remember everyone else at the scene (including me) with that “what do I do next” look on our faces (including patrol sergeant Kight). But that look was not on Chief’s face.

Chief's abilities were seemingly endless, especially in leadership and overall competence. Yet despite those skills, he was a man of true humility. His father Allan was a remarkable man, but a humble man who rarely spoke of himself and his experiences. Wasn't it obvious to Chief that he was better than everyone else? Maybe. But if he was consciously aware of his superior talents, he never spoke about them, never acted like it, and he never "pushed it." I spoke with him about this very thing during the interviews for this book. His response? "Well David, I didn't mind making decisions..." He didn't mind? He was made to make decisions. And he never once did or said anything to me that made me feel inferior to him in any way. But truth be told, I was inferior to him...in virtually every way.

One more very important part about Chief that served to make him a whole man. He loves people. He is what I call a "large-souled" man. He enjoys working with others. He loves teamwork and the ways effective teamwork make the job so much better. He never chastised anyone for honest mistakes or a lack of understanding and experience. Chief is the ultimate team player (and team leader). He inspired confidence in those he led because his high level of competence was evident to all. He treated almost everyone with true kindness and respect. But woe to you if you were lazy, cocky, unprofessional, selfish, mean, or careless. Chief usually liked to leave those kinds of cops with some type of "lesson," as we will see later. I see Chief as a whole man made up of three primary parts: leadership, competence, and a love for others. While there are surely more elements that comprise the man I call Chief, those three are essential and unmistakable.

CHAPTER 2

FIRST GLANCE

Saturday, July 12, 1980 – Firearms Training Day, Burbank Police Range

But the story of Officer Alvarez and the explosion is still in my future. I saw Chief for the very first time on Saturday, July 12, 1980 (about seven years before Alvarez had his hand blown off). I had just graduated from the police academy, and several of us Burbank rookies were required to attend a “real” firearms course conducted by the Burbank Police Department. Our trainer? Chief, of course. Our department lacked a qualified civilian rangemaster at that time, and as an army combat weapons expert, Chief got the call.

This was an eight-hour range training day. Chief was IMPRESSIVE in every way. Just a hair under six feet tall, 190 pounds, little apparent body fat, with thick black hair as one would expect to see with an Indian. “I have no intention of disrespecting the police academy,” says Chief, “but try to forget what they taught you about shooting a gun and pay close attention. I’m gonna teach you all you need to know. By the end of the day, I’ll give you the skills you’ll need with a firearm.” And even though Chief was a master teacher with weapons, he never spoke down to us. He treated all of us rookies as if we were respected veterans. This was my first great training day. I asked a fellow rookie (who had been a reserve with the department for a few years) who this Rich Bison was. His answer? Rich is simply the best. At what, I asked. His answer: Everything. The only question in my mind? Were all the cops at this department like Rich Bison? That answer was coming very, very soon. And I did learn a great deal more about handling and accurately shooting my revolver than I had at the police academy.

CHAPTER 3

WHERE IT ALL BEGAN

1947- Burbank

Now let's go all the way back in Chief's life to see what he became, why, and how.

Chief was born in Burbank on October 15, 1947. While that particular fact is mundane, nothing else you're about to read is ordinary in any way.

Chief started wearing glasses in the third grade and always needed them from that point on. Kinda puzzling, don't you think? Somehow that fact never "blinded" others from seeing his incredible, natural skills a leader. This guy came out of the womb ready to lead – a truly "born" leader. But somehow wearing glasses doesn't seem to fit. He attended Jefferson Elementary School, Muir Junior High School, and Burbank High School – all in the city of Burbank. And wearing glasses didn't slow him down a bit.

Chief's inherent courage and desire for adventure led to his first escapade away from his Burbank home. This event was one of the many adventures that I never knew about until I began my interviews with him long after retirement.

Note: Back in the 1970s, Chief's mother told Diana (Chief's wife) that Chief was a leader almost from birth. That fact was apparent to anyone who was around him from the start.

Adventure Number One – The Train Trip

At about 11 years old (either 5th or 6th grade), Chief and a friend "hopped a freight train" (stowed away) leaving Los Angeles and heading north. But they mistakenly thought that trains stopped in each city. When the train did not stop, Chief and his friend were nearly panic stricken. Somehow, even at 11 years old, I can't imagine Chief being panic stricken about anything. The train eventually stopped in Santa Clarita, about 22 miles north of Burbank. They walked to a police station and Chief called his dad. Chief explained the problem and asked his dad to pick him up. Allan said, "Yes, I'll be there in due time." Allan picked up the two boys later that day. Although he did not raise his voice or reprimand Chief, he did "question his intelligence." Allan Bison never raised his voice or used profanity.

Adventure Number Two – Traveling in Germany

During his summer break between 7th and 8th grades, at 13 years of age, Chief received permission from his parents to fly to Germany and visit his brother Tom who was serving in the U.S Army and stationed in that European country. Chief's brother Tom was nine years older – quite an age gap.

A tour group from America was going to Germany in June, so Chief started his summer break early, joined them, and left at the beginning of June. When asked by his parents if he was nervous about making the trip alone, he said, "What's there to be afraid of?" Right. That's right. Nothing.

Note: From 13 years on, Chief essentially raised himself (as long as he stayed out of trouble). His father Allan made any necessary decisions about Chief's upbringing, and mother Martha allowed Allan this privilege (although she sometimes thought Chief was too young for some of these escapades – imagine that). They never asked Chief about his grades, his work hours, or his other activities. They trusted his judgment even at a young age. And his parents were fine with this trip to Germany - obviously because they saw the adult leadership qualities in their young son (or perhaps they were just plain crazy, too).

Chief arrived in Germany and spent 10 days with brother Tom. But then the real adventure for Chief began. He spent the next several weeks touring southern Germany alone on a bicycle! One question is certainly begged from this audacious adventure: where did he sleep all those nights? According to Chief, every member of the tour group was allowed to travel about on their own. As we will see so often later in his life, he met and befriended a stranger who was delighted to shower favors on this remarkable young American Indian. Who was this particular German stranger? The town "Forest Meister" (something like our game wardens) who invited Chief to eat at this German family's home and spend the night there. All of this at 13!

Porcupine Hunt

At about the same age (13 or 14 years old), Chief spent some of his summers in Utah at Lake Panguitch (a Paiute Indian word meaning "big fish"). Chief's uncle knew the owner (Joe) of a fishing establishment at this lake, and Chief would work at the boat dock helping commercial fishermen. One day some of the guys he befriended invited him to a "porcupine hunt" later that night. Although Chief didn't know what this particular adventure was all about, he couldn't resist the mystery of it all.

That evening, thinking this porcupine thing was a game or a joke, Chief learned differently. They really were hunting porcupines! It seems that this particular part of the county was overrun with porcupines, and “culling the herd” was not only legal, but needed. As I interviewed Chief about this strange hunt I had never heard of, I asked how the porcupines were killed (guessing with bows and arrows or small caliber firearms). Chief’s answer: baseball bats! Chief insisted that it was all quite humane because one single blow to the head from the bat instantly killed the critter. Every time I thought I had heard all of Chief’s surprises, he provided one more.

Electrocuted?

Another day, another surprise from his past. While working at the same lake in Utah at about the same age, Chief noticed a light bulb that was out at the end of the boat dock. Chief grabbed a ladder and prepared to replace the bulb. But when he grabbed the bad bulb, there was a blast of electrical current and Chief was electrocuted! He was literally knocked unconscious, flipped around and thrown backwards into the lake! While still unconscious and in the water, Joe (the owner) had heard the noise and came running. Joe fished Chief out of the lake, turned him on his side, and Chief began choking and spitting up water. And Chief was fine...no medical care needed. None. Of course not.

School, or. . .

Chief attended John Muir Junior High School in Burbank (the same school I worked at for three years as a School Resource Officer many years later). Chief applied himself to his schoolwork and earned good grades in junior high school.

The Change

But something happened in the interim between junior and senior high school. Chief “traded” good grades for average grades, along with plenty of drinking, fighting, hunting, fishing, and working. This is one of two regrets Chief described to me about his life. The other? Deciding after his military service to quit college after only a few classes.

Note: the significance of these two “regrets” can be found in a guiding life principle that became a mantra for Chief all of his adult life. “If you’re going to start something, do it right and finish it.” At Burbank High School, Chief was too busy (you remember...drinking, fighting, fishing, hunting, and working) to pay much attention to his schoolwork. He never did his homework, and he still managed to graduate. He was either really smart in school or he charmed the teachers (or both).

Chief did play on his high school's tennis team...for a while, anyway. He played, that is, until his tennis coach smelled alcohol on his breath when he arrived at class and kicked him off the team! Interestingly, that coach really liked Chief, just like everyone else. But he only gave the young warrior one bite of the tennis apple. No second chances.

Although Chief never made a reference to his high school teachers, I firmly believe that they loved him and marveled at whatever it was that made him different. As we will see throughout his life, virtually everyone loved him. He was...endearing, in the best sense.

During his high school days, Chief began working at Jack-in-the-Box in Burbank. It wasn't long before he was promoted to Assistant Manager...at the ripe old age of 17! It seems that just about everyone noticed his natural leadership and people skills very quickly.

While Chief did a bunch of fishing, drinking, and fighting, he was not afraid of hard work. But he was about to learn a valuable lesson: drinking and working can make a painful combination. Chief had a great high school friend named Tony. Tony's dad was a very hard-working Italian American man who still spoke with an Italian accent. Besides his regular job, Tony's dad did gardening on weekends. One of his gardening accounts was a mansion just north of Malibu owned by the actor Raymond Burr. Tony, his dad, and other workers went to Burr's house to work every Saturday, and Chief was invited to join the workmen the next Saturday. But when the car's horn honked in front of Chief's house early that Saturday morning, Chief was still asleep. Unwisely, Chief and Tony had been out drinking the night before and the sound of the horn served as adequate notification of the terrible hangover that would go with him. Chief hurriedly climbed in the car without his packed lunch or water, and arrived with the carload for work with the same hangover.

Tony's dad was a monster worker, who no doubt had not been drinking the night before. When the guys stopped for lunch, Chief sat, watched the others eating, and went hungry. His huge thirst was only slightly relieved by warm hose water. Food and cold water were the perfect remedy for his ills...and he got neither. Tony's dad wasn't happy with either Chief or Tony. Right then and there, Chief made himself a promise: no more drinking the night before physical work. It does seem that even this great young warrior had a few lessons to learn.

After graduating high school, Chief announced his new plan: he and a friend were going to drive to Alaska for the summer. Father Allan brought a 1951 Studebaker to his attention, and Chief

bought the pickup truck with the Jack-in-the Box money he had saved. His father gave him use of a gas station credit card for the trip, telling his son to “be safe.” Chief loved his father for that gesture. He was deeply touched. And Chief and his friend then prepared to drive to Alaska! But there was just one more thing that occurred before that first mile. With Chief, there was always more. A local Burbank newspaper reporter heard about this impending trip and interviewed him for the paper! That article even mentioned the name of Chief’s truck: “Brown Rhino.” In a follow-up article, the newspaper shows a photo of Chief’s broken-down truck with the word “Busted” written in large letters on the back.

Adventure Number Three - North to Alaska

Chief and his friend (Bob, who turned out to be a poor companion) took three to four months exploring Alaska in that pickup truck. Hundreds of miles into the drive on the “AlCan” highway, the truck’s transmission died. While waiting for a transmission replacement via rail, Chief was eating at a small restaurant connected to a hotel. As he ate his soup, Chief told the owner that he was a short order cook (from his Jack-in-the-Box days). She hired him as a cook, and Chief cooked by day and slept on the hotel’s dance hall floor at night. The two travelers stayed at that hotel and did all the cooking.

Welcome to Canada

One night, after a few drinks, Chief announces his wish to shoot a wolf. The next day Chief and some new friends begin a wolf hunt – with Chief carrying his shotgun. Before he can bag his prey, the Royal Canadian Mounted Police arrive and Chief gets arrested! His new friends are not arrested because only Chief is in possession of a gun.

Apparently, the RCMP didn’t appreciate Americans wandering around their country with loaded firearms. Fortunately, the Mounties develop a quick but solid appreciation for this teenage warrior from California who demonstrated honesty and respectfulness. Chief was told that normal policy in a case like this meant confiscation of all property and then deportation – and since he was a minor, a parent would have to pick him up at the border. They allow Chief to report to their office the next day to receive the final word on his sentence.

Chief called his father and remembers only that apparently his dad was not coming to Canada to retrieve him. The next day, Chief arrives at the RCMP station and gets a first class chewing out by the Mounties. And then it happens...again. The people skills and charm of this unique Sioux

warrior save him once again. The Mounties hand him an envelope that Chief is sure will spell his doom. Inside, however, is \$40 - a gift to Chief from a collection of the Mounties! Somehow, without realizing it at the time, Chief had made friends with the arresting officers.

On the way back from Canada, Chief was very low on funds. They stopped in Washington and painted a house to raise more cash (some young guys would steal – Chief worked). After catching fish over the next few days, Chief decided he wanted a bear skin – a real bear skin. Armed with his bow and arrows, Chief sighted a brown bear near a stream. He let one arrow fly and hit the bear on the hip bone...and the arrow bounced out! The bear stood up and used one paw to flip a nearby log completely over. One look at real “bear power” and Chief wisely took off running, dropping all of his remaining arrows on the ground in his haste to avoid the bear’s anger. Chief was courageous, but not stupid. The next morning Chief returned to the same spot to retrieve his arrows. The bear had stepped on, and broken, all but two of those arrows.

While in Washington state, Chief dropped off his companion (Bob) with family and, still low on funds, found work on a good-sized fishing boat with about 20 men.

After Chief’s excellent Alaska adventure, he returned home and began working for a painter from about 1965 to 1967. But America was now involved in a pseudo war in a faraway place called Vietnam. Most Americans had never heard of it and those that had couldn’t find it on a map. Chief’s boyhood days were about to end, but his leadership skills would soon be displayed on a much larger stage.

But before we take a peek at Chief’s remarkable combat experience, it’s necessary to set the family table. Chief’s father and Sioux Indian background both went a long way in making Richard “Chief” Bison the man he would become.

CHAPTER 4

CHIEF'S DAD, THE ULTIMATE LINEAGE

Fort Apache, Arizona – Burbank, California

Note: Chief told me as much as possible about his father, Allan Bison. Information about Allan is limited because he never spoke about himself (unless asked direct questions), because he was a quiet man, and because no recordings exist of conversations with him. What follows are Chief's reflections about his father - a man he greatly admired. Chief's mother, Martha Bison, will be discussed a bit less for two reasons. First, Chief always sees himself as Indian based on his father's heritage, and Martha was not of Indian heritage. Secondly, Allan handled most of the child-raising functions, probably because the Bison family had two sons and no daughters. Although Martha sometimes expressed concerns, she allowed Allan to lead in that part of Bison family life.

Chief's father Allan was mostly Sioux Indian and part Scottish. He was born at Fort Apache in Arizona, but spent most of his life in Burbank. He was soft spoken and virtually never talked about himself. But he did have a "presence." While Allan Bison fished often, he almost never hunted. And Chief acquired this same lifelong love of fishing.

Allan attended Burbank High School, and as a highly accomplished diver, he won all of his competitive events. His name came up for possible tryouts on the US Olympic team.

Allan worked at the Burbank Airport as a manager, and later as an OSHA investigator. While working at the Burbank Airport, Allan Bison did a bit more than oversee operations. As a younger man, he apparently made an awfully good impression on others. One of the "others" was perhaps the most famous female pilot in the early years of aviation. Allan Bison flew with Amelia Earhart! She respected Allan so much that she gave him a beautiful wood-cabinet radio as a gift (that has since been lost). Everyone simply loved Allan Bison.

Raising Chief

As father, Allan made most of the child raising decisions in Chief's life. Allan obviously noticed Chief's sound judgment and leadership skills early on and sought to teach him independence. One example of that involved fishing – a love of the Bisons. Allan initially would not let Chief go fishing with his older brother Tom – he wanted Chief to learn by himself. He wanted Chief to be truly independent.

Diana's View of Allan Bison

According to Chief's wife Diana Bison, Allan Bison was "bigger than life." He was "a mountain of a man...a real presence." Alan usually kept his thoughts to himself – he never spoke badly about anyone else. His kindness and humility endeared everyone to him. Even though he was a quiet man, Allan was in some ways the life of a party or community dance.

Allan and his wife Martha absolutely loved Diana from the very first moment, treating her as if she were their own daughter. Once, when Chief and Diana had a real argument, Martha took Diana's side and was absolutely furious at her own son! This occurred just before their wedding. Martha asked Diana: "Are you sure (about marrying Chief), honey? You might want to think about this." Martha didn't think her own son was treating Diana well enough!

Allan was a truly humble man. The humility he demonstrated was no doubt inherited by Chief, who almost never talked about his own life story either. And what a story was lost when Allan became sick one day, and then comatose, overnight. He would never recover.

CHAPTER 5

INDIAN HERITAGE

December 29, 1890 – Wounded Knee, South Dakota, Pine Ridge Indian Reservation

Chief's Indian background is Lakota Sioux. His grandfather was called Little Bison, and he escaped the massacre at Wounded Knee at a young age. Chief's great grandfather was Spotted Elk (called Chief Big Foot by some), a true chief who was left to die in the snow with pneumonia at Wounded Knee in 1890. Only a small handful of Indians escaped the Wounded Knee massacre.

Spotted Elk was the Chief of the Miniconjou ("Planters by the River") Sioux when the massacre occurred at Wounded Knee. Chief Spotted Elk was a half brother of Chief Sitting Bull. Crazy Horse was a nephew of Spotted Elk.

Chief always felt ONLY Indian all his life, even though his mother was German and not of Indian heritage. After retirement, Chief and Diana took a trip to Fort Apache in Arizona. Diana's research revealed much about his lineage. "Little Bison" (Chief's grandfather) was a chief and entrepreneur. He was educated by a Texas rancher. Little Bison worked for the government as an Indian agent. The name "Little Bison" eventually became simply "Bison."

When Chief first trained me in 1980, I asked him many questions about the American Indians of today. Chief disagreed with Indians who "stayed on the reservation and did nothing but drink and cash their government checks." He also never used the "politically correct" term "Native American." It was always simply "Indian." And his favorite sports team, all of his life, was the Washington Redskins. When they recently gave up that name and became the Commanders, he was heartbroken and would no longer watch their games.

Indian Traits?

Among many remarkable things I noticed about Chief, I was always amazed by his keen sense of direction – a skill that must certainly be a result of his heritage. Chief has never been lost. Not in the military, army survival training, Vietnam, police work...never. Anywhere. I also never knew him to be cold (chilly). When we were detectives, Chief always wore a short-sleeved dress shirt. He said the long-sleeved shirts were too warm. Sometimes I think he must have been married in a short-sleeved dress shirt! One day in an Arizona campground just after Christmas, I was visiting with Chief at seven in the morning while he was fishing. It was 33 degrees outside, and I noticed

icicles forming on his fishing line. I was bundled up and still freezing. Chief wore only a thin jacket and a pair of shorts. I asked him if he wasn't cold. He replied, "No...I've never been cold in my life." The more I was with him, the more average I realized I was - certainly in comparison to him.

"Chief" of the Tribe

A bit of research tells us some important things about how a man became chief of an Indian tribe – and specifically for the Indian nation known as Lakota Sioux. Sioux chiefs were typically chosen based on a combination of factors, including demonstrated wisdom, bravery, leadership qualities, and influence within their community, rather than through formal elections or hereditary succession. The most relevant point here is the idea of merit. While blood lines and hereditary succession may have played some role in the choice of a chief, merit, competence, and skills played more significant roles. Indian chiefs, above all, must be truly respected by those they lead. And, just as importantly, they must have real influence over those in their tribe. Considering these points and the subject of this biography, we will see several "dots" nicely connected when Richard "Chief" Bison goes to war a bit further down the road.

CHAPTER 6

U.S. ARMY AND VIETNAM

1967-1968 – Southeast Asia

Chief joined the U.S. Army in March 1967 at 19 years old, with the full realization that our country was engaged in a nasty war in Vietnam. The important point here is this: Chief volunteered – he was not drafted. During the 10-year war in Vietnam, this was not the most common way to find yourself fighting in that Southeast Asian country.

Chief received basic training at Fort Lewis, Washington and his AIT (advanced individual training) at Fort Gordon, Georgia. It was at Fort Gordon that Chief endured survival training in the swamps that tested a soldier's ability to think, solve field problems, persevere, and arrive at a pre-selected destination over a two-day period alone. Chief did not wish to talk about this training during these interviews, but I can remember something he told me back in 1980 about this survival training that has never left my mind. Chief not only survived the final two-day test, but he performed this rigorous ordeal with little of the effort needed by other trainees. And unlike some others, he never became lost and he needed no help from the instructors.

Chief arrived in Vietnam in 1967 as one of many “replacements” for the 9th infantry division, and they were essentially given responsibility for the entire delta. Chief was assigned to a weapons platoon, and he (and his platoon) carried m60 machine guns, 50 caliber machine guns, mortars, and m72 LAWS rockets. After about one month, everyone in the platoon realized that Chief really “knew his stuff.” (**Note:** in war, the most frequently identified characteristic for great leaders was “knowing your stuff.” This simply meant that the leader was highly competent, skilled in the toughest aspects of war, calm, and trustworthy in leading men in combat. They understood terrain, the enemy's tactics, how to effectively handle a team with the weapons at hand, and, perhaps the toughest aspect of all. They knew how to properly balance achieving the mission while still taking care of their men).

After carrying a machine gun for about one week, Chief began “pulling point” (the lead soldier walking in front of a squad or platoon – highly dangerous). After a month, his sergeant realized that Chief could read a map, among other things, and he was promoted to specialist E-4 and served as a squad leader.

While serving as an E-4 squad leader, he was involved in a huge battle and Chief called in air strikes. They later came across an enemy tunnel that was normally investigated by “tunnel rats” (soldiers with some training and/or experience dealing with tunnels). But in this case, Chief wasn’t comfortable ordering one of his guys into a dangerous tunnel unless he was willing to go himself. And since this tunnel had to be checked out, Chief went in. After entering, Chief found an enemy footlocker. He backed up a bit and opened the locker. Inside he found papers and two flags: one Chinese communist flag and one Soviet Russian flag with hammer and sickle. He gave most of the contents to the platoon sergeant, but Chief received permission to keep the flags. The word about the flags got around to almost everyone, and Chief put them in his footlocker back at his temporary digs. When he later checked his footlocker, Chief saw that it had been forcibly opened and the flags had been stolen. Perhaps because of the insanity of war, or because he treasured those flags, Chief was furious. And he still is. While discussing this incident, Chief made it quite plain that had he found him, he would have beaten the devil out of the guy who stole those flags. He also made it very clear that he still feels the same way. It appears that whoever stole those flags would be better off hiding than confessing.

Born to Lead

After only four months in Vietnam, he was “field promoted” by the captain to sergeant E-5 when the regular squad leader was injured. During frequent absences of the platoon leader (lieutenant or senior sergeant), Chief took over as platoon leader at only 19 years of age. Although a lieutenant usually led a platoon of men along with a sergeant first class (E-7), the chaotic nature of war often did not allow for the consistent flow of this command structure.

The U.S. Army in Vietnam experienced a great deal of racial tension, and Chief’s unit was no different. This “problem within a problem” made things “very difficult and scary.” In our interviews of his Vietnam experiences, Chief often brought up the many problems of racial strife. Although Chief had never really been around African American men before the army, his best radioman was a black young man named Freddie. Chief grew very, very close to Freddie – he respected him and trusted him. Freddie never left Chief’s side – ever. Freddie and Chief thought alike and Freddie could anticipate Chief’s moves as the leader.

One night Chief’s platoon was pinned down in a large rice paddy (about three football fields square). Unbeknownst to Chief, a piece of shrapnel had hit Freddie in the femoral artery. When the sun came up the next morning after many hours, Chief discovered – to his shock and sorrow

– that Freddie was dead. This incident was difficult for the great Sioux warrior to describe in our interviews for a couple of reasons: he was very close to Freddie, and, as their leader, he keenly felt a profound responsibility for every man in his platoon.

One aspect about Chief that always puzzled (and amazed) me was Chief's eyesight. For a truly superior Sioux Indian, his vision was poor. He began wearing glasses in the third grade, a fact that never seemed to "fit" with the image of a talented Indian that was nearly "Superman" (wait...didn't Clark Kent wear glasses too?). Chief's fellow soldiers and superiors recognized early on that this was one warrior with superb, innate leadership skills. And they weren't put off by a great leader simply because he wore glasses. In the army, only service-issued frames were allowed for glasses – thick black plastic. The Vietnam climate is almost invariably very hot and humid, and all the guys in his unit wore a green towel around their necks to wipe the constantly dripping sweat. Chief was forced to use his towel to wipe his glasses as well.

Those who have never been involved in combat think that soldiers "aim" their rifles at clearly identified human targets, operating almost as if they were at a rifle range. But real combat is often very different. Combat is better described as chaotic moments of confusion involving men experiencing charges of adrenaline. The phrase "the fog of war" is often used to describe this havoc. Chief saw combat in seemingly simple terms: put more firepower on the enemy than they put on you. And this enemy (usually called "Charlie" by Americans in Vietnam) was often not clearly visible to American troops – at least not at the beginning of a fire fight. Like most American military units, Chief's platoon had only a general idea of the enemy's location (even if they were firing at Chief's guys).

The Birth of "Chief"

When Chief first trained me as a patrol officer in November 1980, I asked him then about his experiences in Vietnam. I also asked him to tell me about the soldiers he led. Chief showed me a Zippo lighter with the following words etched on one side: "To 'Chief' from the guys in (platoon), 9th US infantry." His guys called him "Chief" when they realized two things: he was a Sioux Indian, and HE KNEW HIS STUFF. They gladly followed him and christened him "Chief." I loved that name, especially since he deserved the lofty title.

(**Note:** some confusion occurred at the police department when I called him "Chief" in the years to follow, because the head of our police department served as "Chief" of Police, and everyone called him "Chief." On more than one occasion, I realized that my "Chief" was the man who fit the title more importantly).

TET – January 30, 1968

The TET offensive in Vietnam occurred in January 1968 – and Chief was in that battle. According to Chief, that fight was “hell on earth.” He was later given a leather vest (by Diana and one-time partner Frank Turner), and the back of the garment has the Vietnam campaign ribbon with the words “I Survived TET.” Research tells us that the TET offensive by the communists was the most brutal and significant battle of the entire Vietnam war. Just wondering what the TET battle was like for Chief makes me shudder...and wonder if I would have been man enough to handle it.

Leeches

During one particular field patrol, Chief was stuck (pinned down) in a rice paddy for many hours. By the time medical evacuation arrived, leeches had badly infected his right leg. Doctors wanted to amputate the leg, but Chief adamantly refused. (**Note:** this creates a real dilemma. In civilian hospitals, a patient and/or his family have the right to refuse any medical treatment. But this was a military medical facility during a time of war, and Chief was outranked by the medical staff. In this case the doctors relented, but we can only speculate about the verbal war that might have ensued between a stubborn Sioux warrior and the medical team). During his first week in a field hospital, French nurses that dressed like nuns cared for him and most likely saved his leg. Doctors then reversed course and allowed for further treatment instead of amputation. Chief was transferred to an army hospital (possibly “camp bearcat”) and stayed there for another week. He healed sufficiently and eventually returned to field duty.

Helicopter Crash - Twice

Chief described a strange type of patrol flight called “eagle flights.” Soldiers like Chief and his platoon rode in helicopters in search of the enemy. But “eagle flights” sound as if the soldiers on board were looking for the enemy using binoculars. Not so. In fact, the flights were designed to draw enemy fire! Once that happened, the pilot would look for an adequate landing zone and the soldiers would emerge from the chopper and try to find the same enemy that had just tried to kill them. On one such flight, two helicopters were involved. Chief and his guys were on the second (following) helicopter when the lead helicopter took fire. Then Chief’s helicopter was hit by an RPG (rocket propelled grenade) which killed the pilot and injured the co-pilot. Chief was very fortunate that his helicopter was not very high off the ground because it went straight down and made a “gentle” crash landing. Chief and his guys bailed out and immediately noticed three things: the smell of jet-type fuel (used in the choppers), rotating front and rear blades, and a chopper engine that was revving very high. The soldiers ran to a rice paddy and took light small arms fire. Just then Chief felt a “whack” on the face, and although he ignored it, one of his guys yelled, “Chief, you’re

hit!" Blood covered his face and he was treated by a field medic. Chief was hit by either a piece of shrapnel or a bullet, which slid across his face and hit the metal ring that holds the straps of his helmet. A very close call, but fortunately not a serious injury.

During his longest stint in the field, Chief was out for 35 consecutive days in a battalion-size operation. When the time came to pull this large unit out of the field, not enough chinook helicopters were initially available for the size of the force. They cleared an LZ (landing zone), and helicopters finally landed and began filling up with soldiers. Chief's helicopter began taking rounds on the side and bottom while about 20-30 feet off the ground. Down it went and Chief experienced his second "mild" helicopter crash! Everyone bailed out, but Chief was not evacuated until the next day.

During field patrols, Chief and his men went without some things we would consider essential. Very little can be carried by soldiers on a week-long patrol. Food, water, ammo, weapons, and some first aid supplies made up the basic requirements. Toilet paper and toothpaste were not considered essential. Like many other guys, Chief's teeth took an awful beating without proper care. He sometimes used a string of thread from his uniform to floss his teeth.

Along with a bronze star, Chief was awarded the army commendation medal with V for valor. He also spent over 200 hours in helicopters, enough to qualify for an air medal (which he never received).

The Final Chapter of War

On a day away from the chaos of combat, Chief found himself playing cards and drinking beer with several other sergeants. He remembered that a "Sergeant Lopez" was part of the group. Lopez mentioned that he only had three weeks to go before the insanity of the war was behind him (most guys did one-year tours). He mentioned that he was concerned about escaping injury or death with such a short time left.

A very short time later, Chief was in the field with his guys and had occasion to see Sergeant Lopez one last time just after a firefight. Some other men were carrying Lopez away in a poncho...he was dead. The sight of the lifeless body of Lopez stayed with Chief. Too long, perhaps.

Chief qualified for an "early out," a phrase used to describe a ticket out of Vietnam seven days before the one-year minimum requirement was up (a real break, don't you think?). Not exactly special, but most guys were happy to take it and avoid the chance of serious injury or death in their final week. As a soldier's tenure in Vietnam grew shorter and shorter, he often grew more and more

concerned (scared) about survival. When his one-year tour was almost over, a soldier used the word “short” to describe how little time he had left in country. But when Chief had only one week to go, he was greeted by a very unpleasant surprise. His platoon was suddenly ordered from base camp back out for one more mission even though he had qualified for the early out. An impending gloom covered him like thick fog. The thought of Sergeant Lopez came back to his mind once again.

Chief walked into his First Sergeant’s temporary office and said, “Can I speak to you, Top?” First sergeants in the army are usually called “Top” (top sergeant). The first sergeant replied, “Sure, Chief, come on in. You want a belt?” Chief said that he did, and Top poured a whiskey for both of them. “What’s on your mind, Chief?” And Chief, all of 20 years old, said, “I don’t think I can do this (referring to the upcoming mission). I don’t think I can do it. I’m very afraid right now. I’m so short...I know from the briefing that this mission is not going to be easy.” Top replied, “I know, I know. Chief, if I had a replacement, I would replace you and send you to Saigon and back to the states right now. But I don’t. You’ll do your job...I don’t have any doubt. You’ll lead your men.”

And while Chief virtually always followed orders, he couldn’t shake the feeling that this mission would ultimately be the tipping point – that one last chance of fate when something beyond his control would flick him into the next life.

The next day Chief and his platoon ride in helicopters and land, taking some initial fire as they head out on foot for the area designated in the briefing. The gunfire ceases, and they are not able to ascertain where the enemy fire came from. One thought is too difficult to shake from his mind: seven days to go...just seven days and I’m done with this insanity. At this point, Chief’s “walking line” on patrol looked like this: he had a point man and one other soldier up front, then Chief as the squad leader, and a radio man and two other guys behind him.

All of a sudden, machine gun fire erupts and the whole team jumps in a nearby rice paddy. Chief immediately discovered that his radioman was dead (the second one he lost). At this point in his description, Chief rhetorically asks: “How do bullets go around people? My radioman was hit while he was directly behind me, and I wasn’t scratched.” Chief couldn’t figure out where the machine gun fire came from. There were others dead and wounded, so he called in medivac rescue, holding up the entire company. As helicopters came in for medical rescue and re-supply, a soldier jumps off a re-supply helicopter yelling, “Sergeant Bison! Sergeant Bison!” Chief yells at him to “get down,” and the guy says, “I’m your replacement.” And Chief has a completely new thought: I’m outta here!

Chief immediately removed his backpack, left it on the ground, grabbed a bandolier of ammo and his M16 rifle, and entered the helicopter. But his worries were not completely over. Would his helicopter take enemy fire when he was so close to the end of his war? Chief knew that until his chopper landed, he was not really safe. He hadn't been safe for 11 months and 24 days. As he waited for the sound and feel of chunks of metal hitting the skin of the helicopter during flight, he still felt fear. More fear than normal because he was so close. Freedom, it seemed, held its breath. Chief's fear finally evaporated as his helicopter made it back and prepared to land.

When he returned to base camp, Chief saw his duffel bag packed and a jeep waiting for him. And there was Top, who said, "I got your seven-day early out, and we're going to take you straight to Saigon and process you out." And for Chief, the feeling of doom and gloom finally began to lift.

At the processing center in Saigon, Chief's transfer paperwork is being handled by a Spec-4 (one rank below Chief, and a clerk rather than a combat soldier). The Spec-4 examines Chief's M16 rifle and states that the rifle's serial number does not match the weapon first issued to him one year ago upon his arrival in country. This is not Chief's first experience with army red tape. Chief explained that since his arrival in country, he had used several different primary weapons, including an M14, an AK-47, and an M16 with a sniper scope attached. The Spec-4 tells Chief: "Well, we can't process your transfer paperwork with the discrepancy in weapon numbers." Chief became furious and let that guy know just how mad he really was (oh, how I wish I had video of that conversation). A nearby officer heard the commotion and stepped in, solving the problem before this war-scarred Indian warrior created one last deadly battle...

Chief returned stateside after 11 months and 24 days in Vietnam with several medals, including a bronze star for meritorious service in combat. This phrase is quite common when awarding medals for bravery to NCOs and officers (both leaders) who display courage and leadership while guiding troops in battle. Although I was never in combat, I have studied war and combat for more than 30 years. I have learned that in most cases, soldiers like Chief performed many more acts of bravery under fire but without appropriate awards due to a variety of reasons (lack of sufficient witnesses is a common reason, along with the chaos and confusion in battle, terrain problems, and darkness, among others). The Chief I know very likely should have been awarded a silver star and possibly a DSC (distinguished service cross, one step below the Medal of Honor). But I've never known Chief to call attention to his own cause...never. When I told Chief that I believed he probably deserved a higher award than a bronze star, he said nothing. Silence. That reaction

provided some support for my belief. If Chief disagreed, he would have said so immediately. But because he never praises himself, his silence was, to me, a form of agreement.

Brave or Fearless?

After extensive conversations with Chief about his combat experiences, I concluded that he was brave rather than fearless. Chief told me that he was afraid plenty of times during combat. The fact that he always overcame that fear made him brave...courageous. A fearless person (very few actually exist) is not necessarily brave because they have no fear to overcome. During our years together in police work, he was often in major incidents that brought some level of real fear. But he ALWAYS overcame the fear and acted calmly, rationally, and courageously. I've never even heard of a situation that slowed down his incredible leadership skills.

Important Note: after several discussions with Chief about this "war" section, we decided to limit the combat stories to those contained in this section. We could have included many more descriptions of his combat experiences, but we chose to limit this section for two primary reasons: first, Chief spent one year in Vietnam and 28 years at the police department. My desire from the start was to primarily emphasize Chief's long career at the Burbank Police Department. And secondly, most of the things Chief saw and experienced in Vietnam were excessively harsh and violent, and possibly somewhat difficult for some readers to bear.

Chief received his discharge from the army in January 1969. After his discharge, Chief became disgusted by the terrible treatment that Vietnam vets received from so many Americans back home. He was so hurt by the very people he risked his life to defend that he threw all his medals in the trash. His father asked about the medals and Chief admitted he had thrown them away. This was so upsetting to Allan Bison that he arranged to have replacement medals sent without Chief's knowledge by writing to the Department of the Army in Washington.

CHAPTER 7

POST WAR WORK

1969-1972 - Burbank

After serving in Vietnam, Chief was given an honorable discharge from the military (called an “early out”) to attend college. He experienced almost no after-effects (post traumatic stress) from his combat experience. He started by taking 12 units at Pierce Community College in the San Fernando Valley. But three things happened in quick succession that derailed his aim of a college degree: 1) Chief noticed that he lacked adequate concentration (most likely due to his experience in war – a problem common among combat veterans); 2) he needed to work full time; and 3) the very awkward feeling of dislike and even hostility from everyone else. His psychology professor let the class know that Chief was a combat veteran who had just returned from Vietnam. Terrific. The treatment of returning Vietnam vets was abominable in America at that time (1969). As a result, Chief left full time school and went to work, taking one class at night.

Although he probably could have relied on his parents to pay his way, Chief was all man now and refused to allow others to support him.

He then started a painting business with a friend named Ron (“R & R Superior Painting”). The business was doing fine, but Ron told Chief that he wanted to leave the business and become a police officer. Realizing he could not continue the business alone, Chief decided to sell the business rather than take on a new partner. Chief completed about 30 units when he withdrew completely from college and returned to full time work.

Note: Chief has real regrets about not finishing college, and it violated one of his cardinal rules – finish what you start. His other regret? Doing almost everything in high school except applying himself academically: he chose drinking, fighting, fishing, and working instead. Could this be proof that Richard “Chief” Bison really is human after all? Well, maybe just a bit.

CHAPTER 8

DIANA ARRIVES – THE TRUE LOVE OF HIS LIFE

1972 – Lockheed Aircraft, Burbank

Chief began working at Lockheed in Burbank full time. About two months later, a very attractive young lady also came to work at Lockheed. It wasn't long before this vision of delight caught the warrior's attention. Diana was about four years younger, and when he first saw her, he told a buddy: "You see that pretty girl? I'm gonna marry her." Chief first told me that nugget of information in 1980 when I was a rookie, and I have never forgotten it.

Their boss was Diana's brother-in-law, and Diana was living with her sister and her sister's husband in Valencia. These family members were Mormon, and Diana briefly adopted Mormonism around this time. Her boss recommended Diana date one of the Mormon guys at work, but Diana mentioned that she preferred another guy named Rich Bison (who she really hoped would ask her out). Her boss strongly recommended against dating Rich, telling her to "stay away from him." Why? Simple. Chief smoked cigarettes, drank alcohol, and, needless to say, was decidedly not Mormon. When Diana would not agree to avoid him, the boss would eventually "relieve" Chief of his Lockheed job. Chief never had any doubts about the real reason for the "layoff."

But this great leader with the amazing people skills was actually a bit shy with ladies. So shy, in fact, that it took a full month to ask Diana out. For her part, Diana had done more than notice him and was still hoping during that month that he would ask her out. And finally, the shy, somewhat romantic warrior asked her out on their first date. And where did he take her? Dirt bike (motorcycle) riding! Chief was obviously oozing with lots of romance and gentlemanly charm.

Diana's Background (from her observations)

Diana comes from truly humble beginnings. She grew up in San Bernardino at the foothills of the mountains. Even though her father worked two jobs, they got by on fairly meager means. Diana recalls her home life as ideal. Her father raised his voice to her only once, when Diana was told by her mother she could not attend a party and she objected. That one single rebuke left Diana devastated. Diana was an obedient, compliant child who could be described as naïve.

Although entirely humble, Diana described herself as "fairly attractive with a good figure." She dated often in high school, and all her dates behaved in a proper, gentlemanly manner.

When Diana began work at Lockheed, she was possibly the most attractive lady in the place because she was asked out by “five different guys every single day!” (**Note:** Diana did not believe she was the most attractive woman in the place...doubtless Chief thought she was). Diana politely declined every offer to date, hoping instead that a newer employee named Richard Bison would ask her out. Looking back, Diana saw herself as naïve, simple, and innocent – an anomaly, like a circus attraction (I don’t think Diana truly understands men – but Chief and I certainly do). She did feel something entirely different in Chief’s presence – a rather common phenomenon as we have seen with everyone Chief met. When Chief didn’t get around to popping the question, Diana finally succumbed to the endless requests of another guy at work. Just before her date, Chief finally asks Diana out for the same day as the other guy! Diana was truly stuck – she wasn’t going to miss a date with Chief, and she was too kind to cancel her date with the other guy. So she lied to Chief, saying she had a babysitting commitment for that evening. Fortunately for her, shy as he was, Chief did not give up. He asked her if she was available during the day, and Diana gladly accepted. With white jeans and an angora sweater, she goes on her first date with Chief – dirt bike riding. Not exactly the best motorcycle riding attire, but I am sure that Chief didn’t mind a bit!

Chief was (and is) a truly caring, considerate man and Diana fell under his spell right away. Chief obviously was just as bewitched in Diana’s presence. There was one more thing Diana noticed from the start: Chief was a man. He was a self-contained man who was not affected by the whims and fancies of others. With Chief, you get the man you see. And with him, that was plenty to win over virtually everyone.

Let’s Get Married

Note to Reader: most of the remainder of this chapter includes family life and takes place over many years. Rather than try to fit pieces into the proper timeline, almost all is included here in this chapter.

Somehow, Chief never really asked Diana to marry him. Their courtship lasted a bit more than one year. One day, as they walked around Glendale, Chief said, “Well, I guess we should go look at the rings.” Both simply understood they were going to get married, and that happened in 1972. Chief believed that marrying Diana was the best decision in his life. Their only child, Heather, was born in 1975. **Note:** Chief’s decision to marry Diana and “look for rings” is just another example of his straightforward, practical way of life. Seen in another light, he might have been just a bit short of the mark in the romance department...at this stage, anyway. But Diana didn’t seem to mind.

I asked Diana if she noticed any signs in her new husband of post combat stress, such as excessive drinking, drugs, nightmares, anger, depression, or anxiety. She noticed none of these common post traumatic effects of his war experience. Diana noted that whatever difficulties he faced, Chief always “moved on” and did not dwell on past troubles. This ability to “move on” and not dwell on the past is clearly one of Chief’s most significant strengths – a trait we will see again as we move through his story and encounter one tragedy after another.

Oh, and about Chief being a smoker. He woke up one morning about eight months before his wedding and decided to quit smoking. Just like that, without Diana asking him to stop. He believed that Diana deserved that...and much more. Strangely enough, although he hadn’t smoked in eight months, Chief smoked one single cigarette on their wedding day, but never another one after that. Some kind of Indian ceremonial custom, perhaps?

Diana got along wonderfully with Chief’s parents. In fact, they seemed to prize her more than their warrior son! For her part, Diana adored her in-laws as well.

Never Let it be Said . . .

By way of nearly full disclosure, a few notes about their wedding. Chief and Diana “insisted” that some of the rather unusual details surrounding their wedding be, well, released to the reading public. So much for privacy, so here goes...

For starters, Diana’s maid of honor was late and barely made the start of the ceremony. But when the minister asked for Diana’s ring, the same tardy maid of honor couldn’t find it! The ceremony was stopped while the minister searched for the ring by walking alone down the aisle (away from the bride and groom) and into the room where the maid of honor had come from. When the minister found the ring, he yelled, “Found it,” from inside the room and applause could be heard from those in attendance.

The ceremony continued without any further mishaps, and after the reception the bride and groom left for Diana’s place. The plan was to spend the wedding night at her apartment and leave on a small trip to Vegas the next day. But the best laid plans of...well, they changed their minds, grabbed their luggage, and started to drive to Las Vegas right then and there. Before reaching Las Vegas, however, Chief felt tired and they stopped in beautiful downtown Barstow. They chose a motel in that delightful city – and what a motel! It was a cross between a drug dealer’s dive and a ghost room. Just when they thought nothing else could go wrong, the bed breaks in the middle of

the night. When they turned the lights on, they were treated to a horde of cockroaches fleeing in all directions and running for the hills!

Despite the inauspicious beginning, they were floating on the clouds for a few days in Vegas. The food and the shows were wonderful. Now, you're probably wondering...did they gamble? Diana is and always has been a good girl – she never gambled a cent. But Chief did...and proceeded to lose all their money! So after a few days they packed up and returned home. So much for their excellent Vegas wedding trip.

At this very point the Bisons started a family tradition – outside activities and camping. They grabbed their camping gear and headed for the beach to join friends (wait...aren't honeymoons supposed to be for the couple alone?). While at the beach, Diana was seriously sunburned. She awoke later that night and felt as if her lips, eyes, and ears were on fire. She swelled up like a balloon. Her arms and legs were burned to a crisp. Needless to say, there wasn't much close contact for the honeymooners over the next few days. (Can we blame Chief for this? He's the one who loves to be outside...).

From the onset of their marriage, Chief and Diana went camping at every opportunity. Chief, the master fisherman, taught Diana to fish. Without much money, camping gear was limited, so they simply threw down sleeping bags wherever they landed. On one occasion, they were sleeping next to a stream in the Mammoth Lakes area. Diana woke up the next morning first, pulled the end of the sleeping bag from her eyes and found herself face to "end" with the rear portion of a bull. Diana begins to whisper to Chief, "We're in a herd of cows..." Chief is now awake and tells her to get up carefully and move very slowly back to the truck (maybe that Barstow motel wasn't so bad after all).

On another occasion they fall asleep under a beautiful night full of stars, again with only sleeping bags (not quite sure how much privacy a couple can have with only sleeping bags, but...). Chief awakes first the next morning with the sensation of a heavy weight on his chest and finds that they are covered in six inches of snow. And that's the final straw. For Chief, money is no object. He decided to splurge and buy a tent.

The One and Only

About three years into their married life, daughter Heather is born (1975). But somehow, little Heather is not born with that great Indian yearning to be outside. She screams bloody murder in

the car en route to their camping destinations, and she hated sleeping in a tent and let everyone know it. The whole camping adventure experience was simply not her cup of tea. So the Bisons buy a used mini motor home, and Heather is happy. Eventually they “buy up” to a 30-foot motor home, and then a 40-footer. And for all of Heather’s childhood, the Bisons camped, hiked, fished, and explored as a family.

Diana to the Rescue

While vacationing in Montana, Chief and Diana were told by a ranger about an out-of-the-way water spot called Hebgen Lake. They decided to try it out (fishing, float tubing, and kayaking) even though it still had some ice on it when they launched. The fishing was terrific, and although they usually “caught and released,” they kept these for a fish fry with friends later that evening. And in the blink of an eye, things changed. Chief’s fishing line, hanging just over the kayak, became caught on a log and tipped him over into the freezing water! Chief’s kayak was now upside down and the great warrior began to experience hypothermia – the only time he ever felt cold! It became clear to both of them that Chief could not fix this particular problem on his own. Diana to the rescue! While Chief held onto the side of her kayak (and his own upturned kayak as well), Diana began to row furiously for shore. The total weight, which included Chief’s water-logged kayak, made her efforts very, very difficult.

Once she brought them to shore, Chief made some practical efforts to warm up – fast. He removed all his wet clothes and began alternating between jumping jacks and running to get his blood up to temperature. And just about then, a four-wheeler drove slowly by with a clearly bewildered male occupant who no doubt had never seen anything like this before (imagine the story he had to tell when he arrived home!). Chief finally dried out, and the fish fry and campfire stories with friends no doubt were quite entertaining. Chief always loves a good story.

One last memorable kayak story: during a different trip to a lake in Montana, Chief and Diana rowed their kayaks across the entire lake, had lunch on the opposite shore, and admired the beautiful scenery. A light breeze picked up, then wind, followed by a gale force blast, all in about five minutes. A lack of further suitable shorelines forced them to try to paddle back to their original starting point. The wind blew waves that washed completely over their heads! The possibility of one or both kayaks capsizing was very real. Their feeble rowing efforts resulted in a less-than-ideal math problem: three feet forward, two feet back. But two exhausted yet very happy campers finally made it back to camp.

Heather Grown Up

Heather later married a young man named Bart, and Chief and Diana loved him like their own son. The young couple moved first to Ohio, and later to Colorado. Although still working, Chief and Diana visited daughter and son-in-law twice a year for about three weeks each time. In rather quick succession, Heather and Bart had three girls – Alexis, Natalie, and Samantha. But it seemed that having children without her own mother around made Heather's homesickness even worse. Heather mentioned this to Bart, and he responded exactly the way a caring, selfless husband should – he moved them back to California. They lived only 18 miles away from Chief and Diana, and Heather (and her folks) were overjoyed. As Chief and Diana retired at the beginning of the 21st century, they took their grandkids traveling everywhere – Yosemite, Yellowstone, San Diego, Pismo Beach, Mammoth, Arizona, Kernville, and Colorado.

Note: Chief told me several times that he LOVED Bart as if he was his own son. He loved him and valued him beyond words.

CHAPTER 9

LAW ENFORCEMENT ON A WHIM

1973 – The Burbank Police Department

Although Chief had no desire to give law enforcement a look, he and his painting partner Ron put in interest cards at several departments (including his hometown of Burbank). Even though he “didn’t want to be a cop,” Chief tested with several departments. And as was his custom, he never did a single thing to prepare for any of the testing process. Despite the absence of preparation, at least three police departments were ready to hire him in short order. Next thing he knew, Chief was hired by the Burbank Police Department without ever having given a previous thought to police work. Burbank Police sped up the last part of the hiring process because Inglewood and Los Angeles Police Departments were ready to hire Chief very soon.

Burbank Police Chief Lorringer would have normally headed up the hiring “panel,” but he excused himself because Rich’s dad and Chief Lorringer were friends. The decision to hire Chief, however, still belonged to the police chief. Essentially, one chief (Lorringer), hired another Chief, Richard Bison!

Detective Bob Elias conducted the required background polygraph (lie detector) test (six years later, that same detective conducted my polygraph). Chief was asked many times about drug use in Vietnam, and he truthfully denied any involvement with illegal drugs. Since illegal drug use was common among military personnel in Vietnam, most investigators believed everyone participated. Chief experienced some guilt about using “bennies,” an amphetamine (Benzedrine) issued by medics to those in combat that would actually save lives. This caused what appeared to be deceptive answers, but Detective Elias understood and passed Chief in the polygraph stage.

Chief told me in our interviews that he had no initial interest in police work. But looking back after 28 years as a police officer, he could state categorically that he absolutely loved it!

CHAPTER 10

A NEW CAREER

1973 - Police Academy

At his police academy graduation, Chief was named the Outstanding Cadet of the class. While it may have been a weak and slipshod police academy, police academy instructors knew leadership and greatness when they saw it (Chief had been the class president and class captain). The Burbank cadets alone made for very tough competition for Outstanding Cadet - Chip Rombach, Will Berry, Wade Taylor, Larry Koch, and Cheryl Skinner to name a few. During a time of the military draft, it is interesting to note that Chief was the only cadet in that class from Burbank who had military experience.

Chief had a very dim view of the quality of the police academy. He found it generally very poorly run, so much so that he wrote up a critique of the academy for the Burbank Police Department to consider. Although he never received direct feedback on his assessment, that class was the last time our police department used that particular academy. Somebody up in police administration must have been listening very early on to the future cop/warrior.

CHAPTER 11

FIRST YEARS AS A COP

1973-1980 – Working the Streets of Burbank

As was the custom in the 1970s, Chief had already worked as a patrol officer for two months before he even started the police academy. After his academy graduation, Chief was trained by four different officers: Mike Hamilton, Ron Ratliff, Dick Kowatch, and Manny Garcia.

Cast a Giant Shadow

In a very short time, Chief succeeded in impressing everyone...without trying to impress anyone. He simply did his job, in his words “in a regular, ordinary way.” And yet it was anything but ordinary. In fact, Chief was able to “cast a shadow” everywhere he went and with everything he did. More accurately, he cast a giant shadow in law enforcement, and in all of life.

In nine short months after the police academy graduation, Chief was chosen to be a field training officer. This achievement was more than incredible – it was quite possibly unprecedented. Chief was still on probation as a “rookie,” and yet he was chosen to train brand new academy graduates. His skills, experience (as a combat veteran), and his leadership were obviously noticed by his supervisors.

Rangemaster – The Hills of Burbank

Before much longer, Chief filled the role of police rangemaster as a full-time assignment. The department simply could not find a suitable civilian employee for that role, and Chief was a weapons expert and a peerless shot with any type of weapon. He served the better part of four years as our rangemaster. Our police range has always been located up in the hills of the city - a truly ideal location for a police range. Chief did more than simply train officers in the use of firearms. He was often summoned to court to provide weapons expertise as an officer and later as a detective.

One of Chief's greatest sources of pride and accomplishment was developing our department's physical agility test for screening police applicants. He was given the responsibility and freedom to create this part of our testing process. Chief put a great deal of time into this project. The agility test took place entirely at the police range. He conferred with other departments, members of the city's administration, and attorneys. Lots of trials, testing, and practice runs took place. The final result was more that effective in measuring the agility of police applicants. It really became a model for other departments to follow.

Chief was never really focused on the flight path of his career, as some of his peers in fact were. He was a consummate team player and was happy to serve where needs existed. The department needed him at the range, and he was happy to lend his expertise and fill that role. Chief also realized the profound benefits from his position as rangemaster, since he actually managed an entire section of our department. This included training the entire department, preparing them for life threatening situations, budgeting, logistics, and acquiring supplies.

Rattlesnakes

In about 1975, Chief, I believe, set a record. A dubious one, to be sure, but a record nonetheless. Chief and his assistant (civilian employee "Al") were clearing brush up at the range when Chief was bitten on the finger by a rattlesnake. Without paramedics in those days, Chief was transported to Burbank Community Hospital by another officer in a patrol car. Apparently that other officer was in a state of semi-panic, because Chief had never been driven faster in his life.

At the emergency room, Chief was treated by Dr Cook. One important clue with respect to a treatment plan at this stage was that Chief had experienced no pain or other symptoms. And it was then that Chief heard these comforting words from the doctor: "I've never treated a poisonous snake bite before...you're my first case!" Sheesh. And Dr. Cook's lack of experience almost killed Chief. The good doctor gave Chief the poison snake serum even though Chief displayed no symptoms – apparently a very bad idea. Chief went home and began to develop symptoms – not snake bite symptoms, but a reaction to the unneeded serum. It wasn't long before he came down with hives and terrible pain. What a night! But at least Chief and Doctor Cook learned something important from this fiasco: no serum of any kind should be given to a patient with snake bite when no symptoms exist! Each and every time Chief ran into Dr. Cook from that point on, Dr. Cook expressed his deep regret for nearly killing this great Sioux warrior with the wrong medical remedy.

The Great Coyote Hunt

At about this time, residents on the "hill" section of Burbank were having a bad time with coyotes. The concern of those folks went far beyond the simple idea of coyotes wandering around their part of town. Some of their pet dogs and cats were disappearing, obviously prey that the coyotes considered quite tasty. They took their concerns to the police chief's office, and some imaginative, high-ranking police administrator had a brainstorm: why not send one of their own officers up in the hills to "cull" the herd? And since firearms could not be used for several obvious reasons, a bow and arrow seemed just right. Now, let's see...who on our department can handle a bow and arrow? Right...Chief, who else?

While this idea appeared splendid on paper, coyotes in the real world don't allow you to work that way. Another officer was assigned to be Chief's driver using, of all things, a loud VW dune buggy! So much for sneaking up on the skittish critters. But Chief gave it the Sioux warrior try anyway. While he did manage to bag a few coyotes during several nights, he knew that this simply was not going to work. But why not give it one more try, on one more night?

While driving around the "hill" area of Burbank, Chief and his driver kept a sharp lookout for the crafty critters. Then the great hunter saw a coyote moving from around a house and Chief yelled, "Stop!" Just as the dune buggy comes to a jerky stop, Chief leaves the vehicle and attaches a three-point arrow to his bow. Since he wasn't far from the prey, Chief only needed a "flat trajectory" shot (no arc needed). But it was really dark, and the coyote presented a difficult moving target. Chief's arrow missed the coyote, but hit a sprinkler on its way toward a house. And it didn't miss the house! The arrow hit the house with such force that a rather loud "thump" could be heard. To Chief's horror, he saw that his arrow penetrated about six inches into the house – through the stucco and probably stopped only when it hit a two-by-four in the framing. Chief needed to retrieve that arrow, and as he yanked it out of the outside of the house, a hole was left in the stucco about the size of a ten-inch dinner plate. The outside porch lights suddenly came on with a homeowner who was obviously seeking out the reason behind the sound of "something" hitting his house. As Chief froze momentarily, he was faced with three choices – all of them lousy. He could stay where he was and tell the emerging homeowner the truth – that he was an on-duty police officer hunting coyotes. Or he could tell the homeowner a "story" that was not exactly accurate. Or he could run away. With only a second to consider his course, Chief chose to run. But his driver had already pulled away about four houses up the street, so Chief was forced to run up the block towards the dune buggy and finally caught up with the car. As the dune buggy pulled away, both Chief and the driver wondered if they should tell anyone about this little glitch.

The next day Chief did tell the chief's office that the whole idea just wouldn't work. Trying to sneak up on coyotes in the dark with the noise of any vehicle was just plain silly. And, there were other "possible" problems...

Several days later, Chief saw the police chief at the station. As they hesitated before passing each other, the police chief says, "We took care of the hole in that house." It seems that the homeowner knew the police chief and called him to report the strange circumstances surrounding the damage to his house. So much for the great coyote hunt!

The Golf Course

Those that enjoy this biography will often read my firm affirmation that I have never heard of Chief making a mistake. But on the way to work one day, he almost made one. As Chief drove up in the hills of Burbank heading toward the police range, he stopped at the “lower gates” and noticed they were still locked. Normally his assistant “Al” arrived at the range first and unlocked the gates. Chief stopped his car and unlocked the two swinging gates. As he moved the right-side gate open, Chief saw a very large rattlesnake in the bushes. Realizing he needed to “dispatch” this dangerous creature, Chief grabbed a revolver from the car. But this was not his own gun. This handgun was given to him by a deputy district attorney who needed the gun tested. Chief loaded the revolver, took aim, and cancelled the snake’s ticket with one shot to the head. Just as Chief was likely enjoying the accuracy of his shot (for, after all, a snake’s head is a pretty small target at any distance), he heard screaming from several nearby golfers. It seems Chief forgot that one of the golf course’s “tee boxes” (where golfers tee off) was about 75 feet from where he stood as he shot the snake. And with this golf course located in a canyon, that shot probably sounded like a canon. All of the golfers hit the ground and screamed when they heard the shot, and Chief immediately realized he might have missed one little step – like looking around and warning peace-loving folks like the golfers.

Chief contacted the police dispatchers and told them about the shot in case the communications center was flooded with “shots fired” calls.

Just One Little Case of Wine

As rangemaster, Chief had often helped law enforcement personnel from agencies other than Burbank with firearms training. He provided quite a bit of this help to the California Highway Patrol. The CHP officers were so pleased and grateful that they bought a wonderful gift for Chief. It seems they had heard that Chief loved a glass of wine...or a bottle...or two. Perhaps without giving the matter sufficient thought, Chief accepted an expensive case of wine from them and loaded it in the trunk of his sergeant’s patrol car. He thought about driving up to the parking structure on the second level to transfer the wine into his personal car, but instead simply pulled into the normal parking spot for patrol sergeants on the ground level. Chief thought he would simply carry the case upstairs to his personal car. He opened the trunk, removed the case of wine, closed the trunk, and as he turned towards the stairs, he looked directly into the face of Captain Heinz! Heinz stared at Chief, and the stealthy Indian watched the captain’s eyes examine Chief’s case of wine. Heinz asked, “Do I want to know anything about this?” Chief replied, “Oh no, Captain, you don’t want to know...” Captain Heinz said, “Ok, Ok, good enough,” and he left! It seems that this captain, like everyone else, trusted Chief...no matter what.

March 1979 - Shopping in Glendale

On March 26, 1979, Chief had a day off and decided to grab some things at the Glendale Galleria – one of the bigger shopping malls around. Without Diana, Chief took four-year-old Heather along. While dad and daughter strolled through the mall, Chief noticed a man running toward an exit. Something didn't look right to him, and then Chief saw a security officer chasing the man yelling, "Stop, thief!" Chief watched the officer catch the bad guy and both fell to the ground outside of the mall doors...and the fight was on.

Unfortunately, the security guard was losing, and losing in a big way. The bad guy was on top punching the daylights out of the poor security officer. And Chief was stuck in indecision – but just for a second. He bent down, looked right into Heather's eyes, and said in a loud, authoritative voice: "You stay right here!" And then Chief rushed to rescue the security officer before the poor guy was really seriously hurt. Chief landed a left punch to the bad guy's face, and the blood started spraying. But the punch somehow didn't slow the thief down at all. So Chief put the guy in a choke hold and "rendered him" unconscious.

By this time, a crowd of about 50 people were gathered around watching – but not helping. Chief yelled for someone to call the police, and just about then, the thief regained consciousness. So Chief choked him out again! When the Glendale cops arrived, they had no idea "who was who in the zoo" and mistakenly began to go after the only warrior in the fight. Chief yelled, "Burbank P. D.," and the cops let go of Chief and arrested the thief.

As Chief stood up, he realized he couldn't see four-year-old Heather. He re-entered the mall through the same door and there was Heather, holding the hand of a helpful lady who was sensible enough to ensure that this little girl was safe.

When Chief told me about this story, I had a chance to read the letter of commendation he received from the head of mall security. Chief asked me if I remembered his gold Hamilton watch with a special turquoise band that he used to wear. I did remember the watch and band – and I remembered that it looked really great. Unfortunately for Chief, the band was broken during this fight and the watch was scratched up. Chief loved that watch and band.

Chief had the entire thing repaired, and everything came out right in the end. But I couldn't help wondering about his decision to leave little Heather alone in the mall during this fight. Chief was faced with a couple of choices, and both were crummy – but he did tell me that he just couldn't allow that officer to be badly hurt.

Field Training Officer

In about 1979, the department formed an official field training officer program (FTOs). Chief was chosen, along with eight other officers, to form this team. At that time we had three shifts – day shift, swing shift, and graveyard. Three FTOs were assigned to each shift. Some top-level officers served in that capacity - and a few average ones. Chief remembered Chip Rombach, Jim Bonar, Rick Burroughs, Scott Wilson, Doyle Holm, Larry Hoeschen, Wade Taylor and a few others that served as our first official field training officers.

The Very Different Rookie

During our many interviews, I asked Chief if he ever had problems or unusual circumstances involving any of the rookies he had trained over the years. Chief then told me a strange story about training a rookie that was, well...different from any other rookie he had ever trained. The rookie's name was Dave Bell, and he had been a lieutenant in the marine corps before joining our police department. Dave Bell knew that Chief had only been a sergeant in the army. Bell was cocky and occasionally resistant to Chief's instructions. Since a police department is a quasi-military atmosphere, resistance to the directions of a superior is virtually unheard of – making Bell's resistance more than strange.

Chief and Bell were working day shift and were sent to a house to investigate the reason for mail and newspapers accumulating on the front porch. Upon arriving at the front of the house, it was obvious to Chief from the flies buzzing inside of the windows that there was most likely a deceased homeowner inside. They made entry and saw a bloated, decomposing man slouched in a chair in the living room. Officer Frank Turner was also training a rookie, and they showed up at Chief's call for training and experience. Turner and his rookie came inside the living room and watched the progress of Chief and Bell.

At this point, things took a strange turn. Chief told Bell to put his gloves on so they both could move the corpse forward a bit and check his back area for any sign of suspicious circumstances (such as a knife in the back). Bell tells Chief that he doesn't have gloves. Somewhat annoyed, Chief reminds Bell that he had previously told him to always have two sets of gloves – leather and rubber. Bell repeats that he has no gloves, and Chief tells him that he must then help move the body without gloves. Bell tells Chief, "Let me borrow your gloves," and Chief refuses. Chief repeats his instructions to Bell, and Dave Bell refuses! Chief sternly repeats his orders and Bell finally complies. As the body is leaned forward, remnants inside the mouth of the corpse spill out onto Bell. Bell then angrily yells at Chief in a somewhat threatening manner.

At this point, it is obvious to Frank Turner that something even worse is about to happen between Chief and Bell. Turner tells his rookie: "Let's get outta here," and they leave! Turner has decided that he doesn't want to be a witness to whatever is about to happen (and he can imagine that Chief is about to throttle this uncooperative rookie).

At his earliest convenience, Chief drives Bell to the station and tells the watch commander that he wants Bell fired. Right now! Chief returns to his duties alone, and later sees Bell in the locker room at the end of the shift. Bell again yells at Chief, and tells Chief that he resigned as of the end of that day. While that outcome satisfied Chief, he must have wondered who handled Bell's background check and how an obviously terrible attitude could have been so completely missed.

1979-1981 – Sudden Sorrow

In about 1978, Chief had the chance to train a wonderful young man. Mike Maggoria was eager, respectful, and full of promise as a police officer. When I spoke with him about Mike in 2025, Chief had real difficulty getting through the entire story. Chief stopped several times and choked with tears as he described how much Mike meant to him. And then he said something that caught me by surprise. Chief absolutely believed that two trainees stood out as the best of the very big bunch that he trained over the years: Mike Maggoria and me (when he said I was in the top two, I was very surprised). During the training process, Chief developed close personal connections with Mike and me (but not so much with all the others). After training Mike for two months, Chief was certain that Mike's career had no real limits. Mike had shown the skills and abilities to be a truly outstanding police officer. But there was more...much more. Mike was a wonderful young man, and everyone loved him.

During the time Chief was training Mike, the police department issued a new uniform policy that required a nylon police jacket for cold weather. Chief never liked the nylon jackets, preferring his Eisenhower ("Ike") jacket instead. I remember Chief's "Ike" jacket – it really looked great with the standard uniform. But I don't remember anyone else having an "Ike" jacket other than Chief. Mike also loved Chief's "Ike" jacket and often mentioned how great it looked. Although only the nylon jackets were allowed, Chief ignored that directive and either used his "Ike" jacket or no jacket at all.

In 1981, Chief was promoted to detective. Chief had gotten to know Mike's parents, and he developed a wonderful relationship with the whole family. Mike's parents thanked Chief for doing such a wonderful job training their son. Since he would seldom be in uniform as a detective, and because of Mike's love for it, Chief gave Mike the "Ike" jacket. This gesture was priceless for Mike

– he was overwhelmed with gratitude. He loved Chief, and he loved that jacket. But Mike’s future was about to change...

Mike was diagnosed with leukemia, and he did not last long. When Mike died, most of the department went into mourning. Mike was loved, and he would be sorely missed. Mike’s parents called Chief and asked him to be one of the pallbearers at Mike’s funeral. Chief could not remember a greater honor and accepted at once. But one more thing would happen by way of surprise and honor. At the funeral, Mike’s parents returned the “Ike” jacket to Chief. (**Note:** As Chief described this part of the story, he broke into tears as he relived the tragedy once more. This was the first time I had heard about Chief’s relationship with Mike, his death, and the jacket).

Man With a Gun

On patrol one night, the dispatcher reports a man firing a gun in an alley in the “hill” area of the city. Chief arrives first, and two motorcycle officers come to the location to provide some backup until more patrol officers can get to the scene. Chief quietly leaves his patrol car and goes up to a house that was supposed to belong to the neighbors that called the police to report the problem. Chief knocks on the front door, and the door opens. And Chief finds himself staring at the dangerous end of a Smith and Wesson revolver pointed at his head! Chief’s reactions take place in separate fractions of about a two second period. He leans back and to his left, while simultaneously beginning to draw his handgun from its holster. As Chief leans back, he almost begins to fall off the porch. He then kicks at the suspect, striking the bad guy’s arm that was holding the gun. Fortunately, the force of the kick causes the guy’s gun to go flying. Chief keeps his balance and is able to completely draw his gun from its holster. With his free left hand, Chief grabs the bad guy’s shoulder and uses his own gun to whack the bad guy over the head. The guy went down in a semi-conscious heap while Chief radioed an “officer needs help – man with a gun” report. Both motor officers show up at once, followed by all of the remaining patrol officers. The bad guy with a major headache is taken to the hospital and Chief comes within a whisker of “buying the farm.”

Call the Coroner

At about this time, Chief handled a death investigation that was unlike any other in his entire time with the police department. Chief and Officer Manny Garcia were sent to check on the wellbeing of occupants at an apartment. When they arrived and slowly inspected the residence from the outside, Chief noticed lots of flies crowding around the inside of the windows. To him, this was a sure-fire sign of human decomposition inside.

Once they made entry, Chief and Manny saw a man and a woman semi-clothed on a bed in the bedroom. Neither showed any obvious signs of life, and that old familiar odor of “stale dead people” was present. Both agreed that the show was permanently over for these two, and Chief directed the dispatcher via radio to call the coroner’s office to pick up two bodies.

When Chief and Manny had been there about 10 minutes, things changed just a wee bit. As Chief turned towards the bodies, the male corpse slowly lifted his head and gazed in wonder at the sight of two police officers in his house. To make matters worse (or better), the female corpse began to slowly stir and move around. Chief and Manny took a step back in shock - and probably genuine fear. As Chief and Manny moved their gaze from the “corpses” to each other, Chief radioed the following update to the dispatcher: “Cancel the coroner’s office and send an ambulance!” Quite understandably, the dispatcher did not reply at once. I can just imagine what must have been going through the dispatcher’s mind. After a delay of several seconds, the dispatcher replied: “Confirm you want the coroner cancelled and an ambulance instead?” And Chief confirmed the change. At least as far as Chief was concerned, he would not need that last cup of coffee during the rest of his shift. His adrenaline was quite sufficient to keep him awake.

Helping the FBI

In about 1978, Chief narrowly escaped death...without realizing it at the time. Chief was on patrol at night when he watched a car blow a red light. When he was directly behind the violator, Chief “lit him up” (activated his red and blue lights) and radioed his stop to the dispatcher. Chief followed the policy of our police department by radioing his location and the violator’s license plate. And in this particular case the license plate was very, very important – it was a Massachusetts plate. Chief approached the car on the passenger side to ensure a higher level of officer safety. The car was driven by a male and there were no passengers. Chief noted no signs of alcohol or drug use. While the driver responded to his questions in a normal fashion, Chief did notice that the man occasionally glanced downward in the direction of his feet. The dispatcher radioed back that there was no information available on the license plate (this was fairly common in the 1970s and 1980s – out-of-state plates often provided us with no information). Chief carefully returned to his patrol vehicle and wrote out a citation for the red-light violation. The violator went on his way, and Chief resumed patrol.

About twenty minutes later, Chief was told to return to the station and see the Watch Commander immediately. When he met the Watch Commander, Chief was told to go downstairs and meet with

the dispatcher in the communication center. It was there he learned that the man he had ticketed for the red light was wanted by the FBI for a triple murder back in Massachusetts! The term we use today for a guy like that is “mass-murderer.” Although the dispatcher told Chief she had made a mistake, the problem likely had more to do with the inability of our California computer system to link properly with other states (or in this case, the federal government).

Chief’s stop of this murderer and our attempt to access the bad guy’s license plate alerted the FBI. Agents from that famous federal law enforcement organization came to our station and questioned Chief about his contact with one of their “10 Most Wanted” criminals. After meeting with Chief, the agents asked him to meet with more agents the next day to help hunt for the murderer.

The next day, Chief met with more FBI agents. But rather than don his uniform, Chief worked in plain clothes just as the agents do. The FBI had found what they believed to be the suspect’s address in Burbank, and possibly his vehicle parked behind the apartment building. They could not get a good look at the car to be sure they had the right one without exposing their presence to the suspect, so they asked Chief to try since he had seen the car the night before. Chief was able to verify that the car was the same one driven by the suspect, and a quick plan was formed to make the arrest. Chief remembers that the FBI knocked on the suspect’s front door, and then “smashed” the door open. The suspect, who was sitting at a table, was arrested without any trouble. His primary weapon, found in the apartment, was a sawed-off carbine rifle. He was taken to our jail and eventually transported to the federal facility in downtown Los Angeles while the FBI arranged for his extradition back to Massachusetts.

And the acute danger to Chief? The threat to his life? The FBI interviewed this bad guy and learned that the murderer had the sawed-off rifle on the floor of the car between his feet when stopped and cited by Chief the night before. Apparently, this guy was ready to shoot if Chief made an officer safety mistake like turning his back or searching him or his car without another officer present. But Chief just didn’t make those types of mistakes.

Acting Sergeant and Ride Alongs

Chief was often assigned to be acting sergeant (patrol field supervisor) during his days as an officer. His older brother Tom had asked to go on a ride along, and Chief arranged to take him on a night when he was working as acting sergeant. This particular night shift was a busy one – lots of calls, a short pursuit, and backing another officer on a DUI arrest. But the night wasn’t over, and the best (or worst) was yet to come.

An emergency call came via radio sending officers to a Jack-in-the-box restaurant because a man was threatening people with a knife. Chief (and ride along Tom) arrived first, and Chief pulled into an adjacent parking lot. Chief got out of the car, but he told Tom to stay put inside the patrol vehicle. Chief tried to get a peek at the suspect from around a wall, but was surprised when the suspect suddenly appeared with an eight-inch knife held at shoulder height. The suspect came straight at Chief so quickly that the Sioux warrior did not have time to draw his firearm. Chief pushed the suspect against the wall, and both went to the ground fighting when backup officers finally arrived. And all of this in full view of ride along Tom.

This violent suspect was handcuffed and taken to jail by some of the other officers. When Chief returned to his patrol vehicle, he saw that Tom's eyes had grown so large that they had almost popped out of his head. A very shaken Tom made only one statement to Chief: "Take me to the station. I don't know how you do this job..." And that was the end of that ride along (or any other) for brother Tom.

Diana also had a chance to ride along with Chief. Chief, as acting sergeant, was requested at a filthy house with five children...and no adults. The oldest child was about eight, and the youngest sibling was about 18 months. The kids had been left by their mother, who had gone to a liquor store. There was very little food in the house, no working toilet, and significant filth everywhere. Diana saw dirty diapers all around, and the baby crawling on the floor with a floor heater on. She was able to hold the baby until officers arrived. Chief directed the officers to take the kids into protective custody and arrest the mother if she returned.

But the night was not over. An emergency call notified officers that a man was standing on his front porch shooting a gun. Chief arrived first, left Diana in the patrol vehicle, and waited for backup. But before other officers could arrive, he heard a man's voice behind him: "I'm back here." Chief whirled around, only to discover he was facing a man holding a shotgun at "port arms" (not pointed at Chief, but still very dangerous). Wisely, the first thing Chief does is yell for Diana (sitting in the patrol car's front passenger seat) to "Get down!" As Chief draws his gun, he yells for the suspect to "drop the gun!" Fortunately, the suspect let the shotgun fall from his hands to the ground.

Nothing like an exciting ride along. Unfortunately, brother Tom missed some great stuff.

Chief left the station one night while working as the acting sergeant and was dispatched to a bar fight several blocks away. Chief arrived first and waited for two other officers to arrive. While

waiting, the front door swung open and a familiar man appeared – Larry Jackson. Jackson was a guy well known to all the Burbank cops as a heavy drinker and an inveterate fighter. Obviously intoxicated, Jackson came right at Chief in a very aggressive manner. Chief hit Jackson with a right-hand punch to the face, and Jackson was stunned. Stunned, but definitely not stopped, and the fight was on. Chief got Jackson in a choke hold but could not render him unconscious. The first backup officer arrives and tries to help Chief by using mace on Jackson. But instead of macing Jackson, the stinging mace lands in Chief's eyes! With Chief now out of the fight and struggling with the effects of the mace, Jackson begins to beat up the backup officer! More officers arrived and literally knocked Jackson out...and the fight was finally over.

A few months later, Chief was again the acting sergeant when officers were sent to Larry Jackson's apartment (which was very near the same bar). Chief arrives and sees Jackson standing outside his residence, holding a stick and threatening other officers. Jackson sees Chief and says, "Oh, Bison is here? Ok." And Jackson drops his stick and surrenders, adding, "I only respect Bison." Jackson had developed a certain level of respect for Chief for two reasons: Chief always treated him well, and only Chief could go toe-to-toe with Jackson in a fight!

CHAPTER 12

THE SAG CARD

Occasionally during my time with Chief, I heard him casually mention that he had a real SAG (Screen Actor's Guild) card. But he seemed to say it in a half joking manner, and I never asked him about it (that may be the only question I did not ask him). But during our 2025 interviews, Chief brought it up again and I finally asked him: Is it true? Do you really have a SAG card? And even though I have come to expect incredible things from him, his answer still surprised me.

Hollywood had indeed found out about Chief back in the 1970s. It seems that some of the television studios had used our police firearms range for some filming while Chief was rangemaster. While at the range, they asked Chief if he could fire certain weapons. They learned, to their good fortune, that Chief could handle many different weapons. In no time, Chief agreed to a nearly regular role as a firearms instructor on one particular television show called "Enos." And to fill that role, he needed a SAG card which the studios were glad to provide him with.

Now that Chief was a card-carrying member of SAG, more filming opportunities opened up. He helped out a good deal on the "Mannix" television show. Sometimes he noticed scenes that were unrealistic or technically incorrect, and Chief provided valuable suggestions to make scenes more true-to-life. And, like everyone else, the director almost always took his advice and made the changes Chief recommended.

Chief worked with several television stars of that day, including Mike Connors (Mannix) and Linda Carter (Wonder Woman). He also worked quite a bit with the Dukes of Hazard show.

Chief was asked to show Linda Carter how to hold and fire a shotgun on the Wonder Woman show. Before he was finished, a need arose in one scene for three clay pigeons to be shot in rapid succession. Chief used his shotgun to take out those clay pigeons for the shot and succeeded on the first try.

The television industry loved Chief just as much as everyone else did. But I really wondered why Chief had never told me about this significant Hollywood connection during our years together. When I asked him that very question in our interviews, he gave the standard Hollywood answer: "You never asked me." Sheesh.

CHAPTER 13

A NEW PARTNER

November 1, 1980 – Day One in a Patrol Car with Chief

I had just been hired as a police officer in 1980, and I had already had three and one half months with other field training officers. Clearly and candidly, I had been disappointed with my previous three FTOs. They were the three quietest guys on the department - I barely got a word out of any of them. While I may have been partially to blame, it was clear to me that I had not learned enough in three and one half months. I truly believed that I was behind in my training progression, and it seemed to me that I really needed a top shelf, active, enthusiastic training officer who had a gift for teaching.

On November 1, 1980, I began training with Chief. What a difference! After just one week, I enjoyed three big changes. First, I saw up close everything I had heard about Chief. I watched him do everything really well. As close to perfect, in fact, as could be conceived. Without question, Chief was simply better than everyone at just about everything. He moved my mind. He was a natural teacher and trainer.

Secondly, Chief treated me better than any man I have ever known (including my father and three brothers). While I didn't realize the full implications then (in 1980), he had planted a seed in the soil of my soul. That seed never left, and only changed when it blossomed into an impressive forest (or perhaps a garden courtyard, since I've become a Renaissance man). But either way, he moved my heart. Pretty strange words for a slightly crusty, somewhat cynical old cop, don't you think? But completely true, nonetheless. More plainly, it seemed that Chief had forgotten more about police work and leadership than most cops had ever known. And it was patently obvious that he loved not only law enforcement, but he also loved teaching. I was thrilled to be with him for one very short month. Much too short, in fact. More about that a bit later.

And lastly, he taught me how to be an effective police officer. He did this in two primary ways: he was the complete role model of the perfect cop, and he knew how to teach.

First Day in the Car with Chief – Believe it or Not

After roll call on my first day with Chief, we walked upstairs to the sergeant's station. The sergeant handed walkie-talkies and patrol car keys to us on that first day of November, 1980. We walked to our marked police car and Chief climbed into the driver's seat, while I sat in the passenger seat. And then it happened. I was stunned at the time it happened, and though I'm still a bit stunned 45 years later, I can't help smiling. As Chief settled into the driver's seat, he stuffed his walkie-talkie

under his seat. When he realized I was watching, he said these very words: "Listen David, when I began as a patrol officer in 1973 (seven years previously), we didn't have walkie-talkies (also called 'portable radios'). I learned to handle street police work while using only the car radio. Officer safety was a bit different then...if you couldn't get to your car radio, you couldn't ask for help or communicate with officers or dispatchers. But you, David...you keep that walkie-talkie on your Sam Brown (police belt) at all times." Throughout that month on patrol, Chief would occasionally tell me to "gimme your walkie-talkie" during a field event. But he always left his handheld radio under his seat. I suppose he was making the transition from the "stone age to the space age" very slowly (at least in terms of tech devices).

Chief always treated me like his beloved younger brother – from the very first day. EVERYONE respected him. He wouldn't let anyone mistreat me or give me a hard time in the slightest way. On one occasion at the station, a veteran officer walked by me as I wrote a police report, and said, "Hey rookie, are you sure you can spell?" Chief was just around the corner (out of sight) talking to the Watch Commander. Chief heard the comment and "straightened out" the crusty veteran at once – in front of me: "I don't let anyone talk to my partner that way...understand?" "Sure Rich," says the veteran cop, "I'm sorry." Lord, I loved this warrior.

Even field sergeants often allowed Chief to take over a scene when we arrived. Chief never asked to take over a chaotic field emergency, it just sort of...happened. I've never seen it happen with any other officer or detective – in fact, I've never even heard of that happening. Sergeants (supervisors) always handled field emergencies...but not always when Chief was around. And I never saw any supervisor handle a field emergency better than this great Sioux.

One day in that month of November, I was in the report writing room working on a report. Chief was patiently waiting for me to finish so we could hit the streets again. Suddenly a field emergency alert tone sounds, and the dispatcher announces a residential burglary in progress. Chief yells, "Let's go" and we run to our patrol car. Chief drove...FAST. Really fast. The dispatcher broadcast a somewhat vague, general description of the suspect. When we were half a block away from the scene, we saw a male walking away from the area where the burglary occurred. Chief said: "I wonder if that's our suspect?" As he turned our patrol car around to pursue this guy, the guy takes off running. We gave chase on foot but lost the guy. We then returned to the burglarized house and met with another officer, the patrol officer for that particular beat. This officer asked Chief if the rookie (me) would be taking the crime report. Chief told him no, that we weren't finished with the last report when we cleared the station to help with this field emergency. The officer then

made his mistake. He whined in the presence of neighbors about having to take the long report instead of allowing the rookie to take it and grow the kid's experience (training cars often grabbed reports to ensure rookies learned as much as possible). This was embarrassingly unprofessional and Chief was clearly vexed when he told the officer to knock off the whining (Chief said this in front of me and the neighborhood residents). On the way back to the station, Chief said: "Don't ever whine or complain like he did. Ever. That is plain unprofessional. Be thankful you have this job." Yet he never lectured or talked down to me. I would not have minded in the least, but he never did.

I asked Chief lots of questions...about almost everything. I'd never met anyone like him. He was fascinating. We talked briefly about the department's awards for bravery. Chief mentioned the highest award for bravery – the Medal of Valor (similar to the Medal of Honor in the military, but the military Medal of Honor is much, much grander). It seems that two other officers had received medals of valor for rescuing people from burning buildings. Chief told me that he did the same thing a while back, and he described the circumstances of that call. Chief responded to a report of a house fire, and he could see flames in the roof as he arrived. Neighbors reported that the resident (a woman) was trapped inside. Chief and some other officer entered the smokey, burning house, found an unconscious woman, and pulled her out. An ambulance came and took her to the hospital. When Chief returned to the station to clean up and change uniforms, he was verbally reprimanded by his patrol supervisor! He was told, "You are a cop, not a fire fighter - never do a fireman's job like that again." So much for bravery, duty, and the medal of valor.

Chief's entire shift in a patrol car can be explained in three ways (or his three aims each day): one, diligently handle his beat responsibilities and help other officers with theirs. If training a rookie, give him the best training possible at the same time. Two, fervently work to find bad guys...preferably real bad guys. And when he was not occupied with the first two, he sometimes worked on number three - play practical jokes. But chief only played those jokes (or, in some cases, "lessons") on officers he disrespected or disliked. He never intended unwarranted embarrassment and was not vindictive. When certain situations reached an impasse, and no other solution was available, Chief resorted to a "lesson." As we will see, Chief always had a reason for these lessons. And I don't believe he ever played practical jokes while training a rookie.

Practical Jokes

Before his promotion to detective, Chief played one of his famous practical jokes on one particular officer we will call "Archie" (not his real name). To this day, I still can't believe that Chief did it. But with the right sense of humor, and understanding the reasons behind the joke, its humor is compelling.

I was starting a patrol shift one early morning. As I was getting dressed in the locker room, Chief came in just after ending his graveyard shift and he was laughing. I asked him what happened, and he described the whole incident from the night before. Around one a.m., Chief was driving a plain unmarked (“zebra unit”) car with Bill Kreisher riding in the passenger seat as his partner. Chief arranged for a “meet” via radio with Archie in what was called “the industrial desert” (the industrial area near the airport). It was deathly quiet – huge employee parking lots were empty and Archie agreed to meet him in one of these lots. When the cars were side by side (driver door to driver door, facing in opposite directions), Chief engaged Archie in friendly conversation. As they talked, Chief turned to his right and looked at his partner, Bill Kreisher. Kreisher delivered a slight nod, and Chief slowly, noiselessly removed his revolver from his right hip (away from Archie’s view). As Kreisher focused on the weapon, Chief quietly emptied the six live rounds of ammunition from the gun and loaded it with six studio blanks. Chief again looked briefly at Kreisher, who nodded his approval, indicating that the gun had only blanks and was now safe. Chief kept the gun in his right hand on his lap and continued to chat with Archie. Suddenly, Chief yelled, “Archie, watch out!” Chief then pointed his handgun out of his driver’s window (about three feet from Archie’s open driver’s window) and fired all six blanks just over Archie’s car roof. Archie let out a feral scream and frantically squirmed, trying to get out of his car to avoid being shot in the back by the phantom “bad guy” that Chief was shooting at. When Chief and Kreisher began uproariously laughing, Archie knew he had been taken “around the block.” Archie drove his patrol car straight to the station and told the sergeant (Al Angele) that he was going home sick. The only thing missing from Archie’s terrified reaction was a video recording.

Before the shift ended, Chief was called to the station to meet with Sergeant Angele. Chief and Al Angele were very good friends, but Chief still wondered how badly he was going to be chewed out for this masterful joke on Archie. The conversation was surprisingly short. Sergeant Angele simply asked Chief, “Rich, would you please leave Archie alone?” And that was it! Most other guys would likely have been officially reprimanded and suspended.

Certainly, in today’s world, that joke puts you in the unemployment line. But Chief had magic in his Indian veins, and he was allowed a pass. When this story is told today, most folks view it as a rather cruel joke. But Chief had no respect for Archie, and he didn’t appreciate Archie’s “strutting.” Archie had been told to stay away from certain areas where Chief’s zebra (plain) unit would be looking for burglars. Chief wanted all marked patrol units to stay away to avoid spooking the bad guys. But Archie wouldn’t cooperate. Also, Chief was very irritated by Archie’s devious and manipulative ways of doing police work. It seems that Archie would write down a “found open

door” at the rear of the same business every night simply because the owners had not completely repaired the back door. This joke was Chief’s way of cutting him down to proper size. Chief could not abide officers trying to get ahead by cheating and “manipulating numbers.” Chief had already talked to Archie about all these issues, to no avail. And for Chief, that left only one way to convince Archie of the error of his ways.

Some time later, I asked Chief about the danger in playing all those practical jokes on Archie. Archie was about 6-1 and 215 pounds and very strong (and definitely a little crazy). I asked him if he wasn’t afraid of Archie. Chief responded immediately: “Afraid? Afraid of Archie? Are you kidding, I’m not afraid of him. “HE’S AFRAID OF ME!” I asked him why Archie would be afraid of Rich Bison. Chief said: “Because I’m an Indian...and Archie doesn’t know what I’ll do!” And with a slightly devilish grin, Chief walked away. And I believed EVERY word of it. Still do.

And then there was that practical “lesson” he provided for an officer we will call “Rod” (not his real name). Chief was working swing shift in 1979 or 1980 when he and some of the other experienced officers had a talk with Rod about officer safety. At that time, officers were taught to avoid regular, systematic behavior patterns that made them predictable. Cops made lots of enemies, and becoming predictable made it easy for bad guys with vengeance and assassination in mind to lie in wait for you. Rod was a newer officer but clearly cocky. Chief always despised cockiness. He spoke to Rod about avoiding the same restaurant each night for his dinner break, since this made him predictable, and therefore more vulnerable. Chief and the other guys were truly looking out for Rod’s best interests. But Rod stubbornly continued to take his dinner break every shift at the Copper Penny Restaurant. So Chief formed a plan that would bring the lesson closer to home.

The next night, Rod again went to the same restaurant. Chief and his partner, Dick Kowatch, drove furiously to a place in Burbank that sold crushed ice in large cardboard boxes. Chief loaded up his patrol car with boxes of ice and raced to the Copper Penny. Finding Rod’s patrol car, Chief opened the driver’s door (all patrol cars were keyed the same, so any patrol car key fit all the other patrol cars). Chief then emptied as many boxes of ice as possible in the front driver’s seat compartment - right up to the interior headliner. The back seat/passenger area was blocked off with plexiglass and steel grating to protect officers from in-custody suspects. Chief closed and locked the door, and drove just far enough away to avoid detection but still within view of the results.

Rod left the restaurant and approached his patrol car. He was not able to see the ice inside his car because of darkness. As Rod opened his driver’s door, mounds of ice fell out of the car and

down on his shoes. Rod was momentarily stunned. When he recovered his senses, he realized he had been taken “around the block” by his fellow officers. Using his walkie-talkie, Rod told the dispatcher to send a tow truck for his patrol car. But then the unexpected happened. The patrol sergeant came on the radio and stated to Rod, “Negative on the tow...clean it out yourself!” It seems that Chief had briefed the supervisor about the plan before hand. And because it was Chief, the supervisor had agreed to it!

Several patterns of note did emerge from Chief’s practical jokes. First, he usually played these “lessons” when he was assigned a partner – a two-man car. It’s impossible to be sure, but I have a hunch that he simply was making sure he had a witness. Secondly, he often included the supervisor’s blessing in advance. And lastly, and perhaps most importantly, he never played these jokes for purposes of cruelty or out of spite. He was trying to make an important point in one way when other ways failed.

While he was training me in 1980, I asked him if he’d seen enough blood and guts in Vietnam and with police work to last a lifetime. When he said that he had, I asked him if it ever bothered him. Chief said, “No,” but his follow up story absolutely stunned me. Chief and Diana had taken four-year-old daughter Heather to have her tonsils removed the year before. Chief volunteered to be in the surgery prep room with his daughter. When the nurse began inserting a needle in Heather’s arm, Chief became very, very woozy. The nurse noticed Chief turning a different color (green, perhaps?) and ordered him out of the room before he became a casualty. I asked Chief if he passed out, and he said, “No. But I was one short step from hitting the deck!” I could barely contain my laughter. But I learned something as well: seeing terrible things on the job is one thing (clinical?), but family is very, very different. Especially for this tender warrior.

Of all the things Chief did while a patrol officer between 1973 and 1981, one role stands out above the rest. On many occasions (too many to count), Chief was assigned the role of acting sergeant (supervisor). He never sought this role, as he never sought the role of platoon leader as a 19-year-old in Vietnam. But all of the department’s sergeants and lieutenants immediately realized his unparalleled leadership skills and his unmatched competence. As a result, he was always chosen to lead in this extremely important position when a patrol sergeant was not available. And Chief loved it.

December 1, 1980 – The End of My Time with Chief

As I prepared to spend my second and “final” training month with Chief back in 1980, he told me that he had some news. Chief mistakenly thought that I would be happy about this news, but it was not to be. He said, “David, you’re doing really well and I’m ‘signing you off’ for solo patrol as

of December first.” I was shocked...flabbergasted. This was not the outcome I wanted or believed was right. I had a grand total of only four and one half months with training officers. Rookies were supposed to have six months – generally two months each with three different training officers. Now it was Chief’s turn to be surprised.

“But Chief, I’m not ready to go out on my own (‘solo patrol’),” I said. And I continued my plea: “I’m really not ready. I’m not close. I’ve only been out of the academy for four and one half months. We’re supposed to have six months, and I need more time. Remember, I learned very little from my other training officers (I was taking a chance by essentially criticizing several senior officers, but I trusted Chief – and I was getting a bit desperate). Please...can’t you reconsider? I’m not ready.”

Chief listened with a bit of wonder, but patiently, nonetheless. Then he gave his reply: “David, you know I’ve trained a lot of guys. I know when a rookie is ready to take the next step and go it alone. And you are ready, believe me.” Chief had already given his assessment of me to the entire FTO team (and supervisors). And when Chief gave his evaluation, people listened. No one commanded more respect. This deal was done even before Chief discussed it with me. But I really, really struggled with his decision. I knew I was average - couldn’t Chief see that? Couldn’t he see I needed more training time? Chief was the best. But this time, finally, he was making a mistake. I just knew it. And I also knew none of the other rookies were being cut loose early.

You might be wondering why I was in such dread over an early start on solo patrol. When most guys were so anxious to get out on their own, why was I so bothered about an early release? To me, the reason was simple. If I made a big mistake while on my own, I could lose my job. All rookies were on probation for one full year after the academy, which left several months on my own while still on probation (a bit like working on the edge of a knife). But Chief told me that he had not made a mistake and insisted that I was quite ready for solo patrol.

Note: I have known Chief quite well for a good part of 45 years. Throughout my career, I would remind him of the one single mistake he ever made: releasing me prematurely to solo patrol. Chief’s response? “David, as I’ve told you before, I did not make a mistake releasing you early. And the proof that I was right is your career: officer, detective, sergeant, lieutenant, lots of awards for outstanding work...I was right.” How was I supposed to win this argument? All I could say was that every one of my accomplishments land in his account. Without him, I accomplish nothing... certainly nothing of importance. You see, he changed me, from average to...?

CHAPTER 14

JUVENILE BUREAU, VICE-NARCOTICS

1981-1987 - Promotion to Detective

Juvenile Bureau

Chief was promoted to detective in 1981, and his first assignment was the juvenile bureau. He seemed to understand this new job in mere moments. Most patrol officers newly assigned to the detective bureau need several months to figure things out. But not Chief.

And even though he was a simply terrific detective, he was made for working uniform patrol on the street – especially leading others in a supervisory role.

As a new detective, Chief's first supervisor was Barbara Cooper. Chief considered Barbara Cooper to be an outstanding supervisor. He initially worked with three other detectives – three quiet, not very talkative detectives. Actually, they barely spoke. I know, because all three took a turn training me in 1980 when I was a new officer right before I was assigned as a rookie to Chief in November.

Chief's first assignment in the juvenile bureau lasted about two years. One of his first big cases was much more important than anyone could have guessed, but not because of the seriousness of the case. This one would be important because of who the victim was...and what would follow with another, much bigger case.

A teenage girl had been the victim of date rape. She was either 15 or 16 years old, and the crime occurred at the suspect's residence in Burbank. But this was not just any run-of-the-mill teenager. She attended a party with several other teenagers, including the teenage suspect. Alcohol was a big part of this party, and the victim and suspect became intoxicated. The victim told Chief that she was drunk, and her memory of the incident was a bit hazy, but she reported that she did not give the suspect consent to have his way with her. She remembered that it occurred in a specific bedroom of the suspect's house, and that the bed was covered with a very specific bedspread pattern.

This was not a routine case involving teenagers getting drunk at a party. The victim in this case was the daughter of the deputy chief of the Los Angeles Sheriff's Department (number three in charge of the entire Sheriff's Department).

When Chief talked to the suspect, the young man made a partial admission to the crime, adding that they were both drunk. But Chief did not have this case nailed – not by a long shot. He diligently

interviewed many of the other party-goers. And then Chief had a brilliant idea: that bedspread, so well described by the teenage victim. He called the suspect's mother and told her he'd like to get the bedspread from the bedroom described by the victim. The mother agreed and brought the bedspread to Chief at the station. But only after taking the bedspread to the cleaners first!

Deputy District Attorney Steve Cooley (who later became the Los Angeles County Head D/A) came to the station and he and Chief examined the bedspread. The case was important to the district attorney's office as well because of the prominence of the victim's father. Despite being dry cleaned, both Chief and Steve Cooley noticed a huge stain on the bedspread. Both men looked at each other and had the same thought: Jackpot!

The case went to trial, and the suspect was found guilty of two charges, including statutory rape (unlawful sexual intercourse with a minor). The victim's parents (especially the LASD deputy chief) were highly impressed with Chief's diligent investigation. Chief had met with the father several times, and the victim's dad was very favorably impressed with Chief (as everyone always was). This high-ranking member of the Sheriff's Department told Chief that if he ever needed the help of the Los Angeles County Sheriff's Department, a simple call would guarantee him all the help he could use. And that day came much more quickly than Chief could have imagined.

Chief's next big case, more than any other, thundered across the Burbank landscape.

The Boy and the Suitcase – April 1982

In April 1982 Chief had been a detective for less than one full year when he worked the big case. In Chief's own words, "I took great pride in this case, but I ruffled a lot of feathers." That quote caught me by surprise during our interviews because I have never heard Chief say he had taken pride in any of his many accomplishments (other than designing the agility course for police applicants). But very real, palpable emotion permeated this one. When a father named Michael Corrigan reported his four-year-old son Jamie missing in April of 1982, the "adult" side of the detective bureau initially handled the case. When they made no progress, Chief was told to report to the scene (the Corrigan apartment) the next day. Chief took over the case and began by thoroughly interviewing Jamie's parents – Michael and Petranella Corrigan. Both parents said they had no idea where their young son was. At the end of that day, Chief returned to the juvenile bureau and told Barbara Cooper very plainly: "The father did it – I don't know how, but he did it (killed the boy)." Chief didn't know where the missing four-year-old was, but he didn't believe the boy was very far away from the family's apartment.

Chief directed evidence technicians to respond to the apartment and take photographs of literally everything: rooms, walls, ceilings, floors, furniture...everything in that apartment.

Chief came up with a plan – a plan that would require a great deal of help. The time had come to call in a favor. Chief's idea was to arrange for a massive police search for little Jamie, with the hope that this effort might pressure or frighten the father into revealing the child's whereabouts. So Chief called the same Deputy Chief at the Sheriff's Department and asked for help. The Deputy Chief asked only two questions: How many do you want, and where do you want them? Chief was given two platoons of academy cadets, along with plenty of LASD supervisors. Chief instructed them to thoroughly search every residence in the entire block of Grismer (a very long block with multi-unit apartment complexes). Chief wanted the entire neighborhood to know that hundreds of members of law enforcement were searching every bit of that block. He arranged for all of this to happen without first asking for permission from his long chain of supervisors. He did tell his immediate supervisor, Barbara Cooper, what he was doing, and she said, "Great Rich. Anything you need, just let me know." She always gave Chief total autonomy.

But Captain Gibson (the Burbank Police Captain of the detective bureau) found out and was angered because he hadn't given permission to use the assistance of outside agencies. Bus loads of sheriff's personnel arrived and they began with the west side of the street first. Chief gave them clear instructions about their mission. They were to knock on every door, search everything they possibly could, and tell every resident that hundreds of officers were searching for a missing four-year-old boy. If any resident refused the search, they were to be told that a search warrant would be obtained to force a search (which was simply a bluff).

After a bit more than two hours of searching, Chief was called from the command post (a closed down gas station nearby) to respond to the Corrigan apartment. A police searcher had been approached by the father of little Jamie. The father told the searcher that the police "needed to see something inside the apartment"... that "something was out of place."

Chief arrived back at the apartment and was told the following by Michael Corrigan: "I've been looking around, and there's a suitcase in that bedroom behind the door. I don't know where it came from." Chief asked if the suitcase belonged to the Corrigan family, and Michael Corrigan said that it did. Chief contacted the evidence technicians who had developed the photos of the apartment. When Chief studied the photos, he noticed that there was no suitcase in that same location the day before. And Chief can see that the father is "scared to death." Chief asked Mr.

Corrigan if he knew what was in the suitcase, and Corrigan said no. He gave Chief permission to open the suitcase, and Chief swiveled the suitcase around while leaving it flat on the ground. Chief then opened the suitcase...and there was little Jamie...dead. (**Note:** this part of the story was very difficult for Chief to describe. His words became spaced apart, and his voice cracked. It seemed as if he was enduring a slice of inner torture all over again. Chief later told me that this specific case, more than any other, still occasionally haunts him).

The Black Ants

The suitcase was not especially large, and Chief realized that it could not have been easy for the father to fit the child inside. And then Chief noticed them. Little black ants in the suitcase and on the body of the dead boy. Chief ordered a search for ants in the apartment, but none were found. Black ants were found only inside the suitcase, and on the child's body. And then it occurred to Chief: he had seen a type of water tank fenced off behind the apartment building the day before. While looking over the fence at this tank, Chief had seen black ants. He then climbed over the fence into the tank enclosure and looked at the far end. And there he saw "scuff marks" and blurred shoe marks. Something had been moved, and Chief (with true warrior hunting skills) believed the marks to be fresh.

Chief gave Michael Corrigan his Miranda rights and began a somewhat different type of interview. As Chief was nearing what he believed would be a confession, two adult detectives arrived at the scene and told Chief that they are taking over the case. At that critical stage! Now Chief is furious. Absolutely furious. He returned to the station and let Barbara Cooper know just how furious he was, in very colorful language! But Chief is a true professional, and he snapped out of his rage, telling Barbara that he would simply accept the decision. He knew that Barbara had nothing to do with the decision to send the case back to the "adult" detectives. But the sight of a murdered four-year-old boy in a suitcase makes a man...furious.

Chief then found out that Captain Gibson was "considering" disciplinary action against him for failing to get permission to obtain help from another agency (the LA Sheriff's Department). Now Chief was even more furious, and he let Barbara Cooper know just how much more angry he really was. She immediately went to Captain Gibson's office and went toe to toe with him in defense of Chief. She returned and told Chief not to worry about anything, that "everything was handled."

This case stands out as perhaps Chief's best police work. He handled many other situations and cases that were truly outstanding, but it seems unlikely the boy would have ever been found

without Chief's idea for a massive search to shake people up. Two elements of this case seem to make it his very best work. First, Chief's idea to have photographs taken of every square inch of that apartment was brilliant. Taking photos at that early stage of everything was a truly exceptional investigative step that I don't believe anyone else would have thought of in 1982 – certainly not in that detail. The original adult detectives had not thought of it. Secondly, Chief's decision to arrange a massive search in the neighborhood, and to let everyone know about it, was an idea very much ahead of its time. Nowadays this technique is commonly accepted sound practice to “move” people involved and make them uncomfortable – witnesses and suspects. But in 1982, it simply was not commonly used. The most important part of that technique is to ensure that everyone knows about a massive search, and that the police will leave no stone unturned until the entire truth is discovered. This makes key people very nervous, and nervous people make mistakes. And the fact that a four-year-old boy was involved elevates the significance of each decision because children, more than any other group of people, desperately need protecting.

The two adult detectives did resume control of the case. These “adult” detectives failed to get the confession from Corrigan, however, and Chief was furious for the third time because he believed that the father was ready to confess to him.

The Trial

The Corrigan case went to trial and Chief was the most significant witness for the prosecution. Chief hadn't been sure if it would matter, but he had directed the evidence technicians to collect about one dozen of those black ants in the water tank enclosure as well as on the body of Jaime. As Chief progressed through his testimony, the subject of the black ants arose. And it was the prosecutor (Deputy District Attorney) who brought up the topic. The prosecutor asked Chief the following question: “Detective Bison, could you say in your estimation that the ants you found on Jamie were the same kind as those that were found in the water tank enclosure?” At this point, as expected, the defense counsel strenuously objected, claiming that Chief was not an “ant/insect” expert and should therefore not be allowed to express an opinion on the matter.

After both attorneys argued the point and discussed it with the judge, another very unusual thing occurred. The prosecutor told Chief that he wanted him to testify about his “experience” with ants in an attempt to qualify him as an “ant expert” in court! So Chief explained that his experience with ants was extensive, starting with his childhood. Chief related that as a boy, he collected ants in his backyard. He used to keep ants in his tanks and aquariums, including both the black and red variety. Chief further explained that there were four or five varieties of black ants indigenous

to Southern California. And Chief clearly noticed that the judge was making quite an effort to suppress his laughter at the expense of the defense attorney. Chief added that he was often exposed to ants as a lifelong hunter and fisherman. When the defense attorney had heard enough, he accepted that Chief was an “ant expert!” This was the only light-hearted moment in an otherwise somber, grueling trial.

Michael Corrigan was eventually convicted of second-degree murder and sentenced to 15 years to life in prison. While serving that sentence, Corrigan’s attorneys appealed the verdict, and the case was eventually re-tried. The jury was deadlocked on retrial, and Michael Corrigan walked out a free man after serving several years when the district attorney’s office chose not to try the case a third time.

More Child Trauma

As difficult as it sounds, Chief was not finished with cases involving tragedy and small children. He was usually given the toughest cases for one obvious reason: supervisors needed the worst ones done right. This one, like all the big cases, would receive lots of attention from the media.

This case involved a two-year-old little girl, her mother, and mom’s live-in boyfriend. The boyfriend was Louis Frizzi, a guy well known to most of our cops for all the wrong reasons. He was often in trouble – invariably due to his own actions. At the time of this incident, Frizzi was on probation for first degree burglary.

The mother left the child at home with Frizzi for several hours, and when she returned, she saw that the little girl had bruises all over her body. Frizzi told her that he couldn’t stand the child’s crying and struck her in the head with a fist. The child was transported to a Burbank hospital and the police were called. A hospital doctor quickly noted severe head injuries and arranged for the child to be transported to Children’s Hospital in Los Angeles. Our officers took a report for attempted murder, and Frizzi was arrested.

The case was assigned to Chief, and he and his partner interrogated Frizzi for the crime. When Frizzi became surly and showed obvious disdain for the child, he pushed his luck just a bit too far. Chief rose to his feet, reached one hand across the table, and grabbed “this SOB” out of sheer fury. Frizzi’s eyes grew as wide as silver dollars and his callous attitude quickly disappeared. Before Chief can punch the guy into next week, Chief’s partner says, “Rich, hey, none of that,” and Chief releases his grasp. By the way Chief described the situation, I gathered that he was almost as furious with his partner as he was with Frizzi.

While Frizzi sat in jail over several days, the child, who was semi-comatose, slipped into a full-blown coma. She endured brain surgery as well as throat surgery to insert tubes for sustenance. Her condition worsened, however, and when the situation became hopeless, all tubes were removed and the child died.

Chief took part in several interviews with the media during this case. Some of his quotes are as follows: "Frizzi couldn't tolerate her crying. He was watching TV and the child was crying and Frizzy struck her in the head twice with a fist. The child had been through a lot (ensuing medical treatments). Frizzi also admitted to punching the little girl in the stomach earlier in the week. If Frizzi stands trial for murder, it will probably be for either manslaughter or second-degree murder."

Although Frizzi was convicted (I believe for manslaughter), no punishment was too severe in Chief's eyes.

Another Big Case: Suicide-Murder?

Yet another case handled by Chief in 1982 would capture the attention of the public. Our patrol officers received a call to check an empty house for sale that was possibly occupied. Patrol officers came to the house and looked through some windows. They could see two teenagers on the floor of the dining room – a 15-year-old boy and a 14-year-old girl. Apparently when the kids realized the police were there, the boy shot himself in the head with a .45 semi automatic pistol. What occurred immediately after that is almost unprecedented. The bullet traveled completely through the boy's head, killing him instantly, and then continued into the girl's head, killing her. Suicide first, then murder? Sounds a bit crazy, doesn't it? We've all heard of murder-suicide, but the other way around?

This case was assigned to Chief, although very little investigation was needed. Chief learned that they were boyfriend-girlfriend and had run away from their homes. Although they landed in Burbank, the kids attended Van Nuys High School. The school staff asked our department to send a representative to the high school to answer questions about the tragedy. Chief accepted the invitation and confidently believed he could answer their questions without difficulties. But it was not to be – the great warrior was about to be ambushed. The students, obviously badly affected by the incident, grilled Chief relentlessly. They accused our police officers of causing the tragedy, saying, "If the cops hadn't bothered them, they would be alive." After several declarations of that sort, Chief replied, "I'm sorry you see it that way, but you're wrong. Our officers simply conducted the investigation by standard, proper procedure." And with that, Chief left.

1983 - Vice-Narcotics

Chief was then transferred to vice-narcotics. His opinion of his two years in this unit is not a favorable one. While he made no mention of individual detectives on that team, he did tell me that the unit's aims and priorities were sometimes a bit questionable. Apparently, those priorities occasionally slipped a bit into the financial realm – working lots of overtime meant much more money. And detectives in that assignment typically work a great many hours. While Chief was never reluctant to work hard, he questioned the occasional idea of “sitting around all day doing nothing and then working into the evening at time and a half.” As I try to assess Chief's evaluation of this unit, one might conclude that his conscience was a bit more finely tuned and sensitive to right and wrong than some of his peers.

The Lone Warrior

One day, Chief was working the “day man” assignment in narcotics. Each detective took their turn doing the paperwork during the day – not a popular job. On this particular day, the rest of the team was scheduled to come in later in the afternoon. Chief was alone and bored and began to think of constructive ways of relieving his doldrums. He grabbed another detective, took the sneaky narcotics van, and began driving around Burbank looking for “trouble.” And, being a great warrior, he found some. He saw a guy who was most likely a lookout, and Chief drove up to him and asked: “Do you know any place I can buy some marijuana?” Since Chief had long hair and a beard and was driving a beat-up van, it's not hard to believe that this guy was completely fooled. The guy gives Chief the dope and Chief pays for it. And then, of course, Chief arrests him! Normally, any operation of this sort is a team effort for several reasons, not the least of which is officer safety. But Chief obviously believed that two cops were enough for something this basic.

In keeping with the finest tradition of narcotics cops, Chief immediately asks his arrestee if he can get more marijuana and in larger quantities (moving up the chain looking for bigger fish). The guy says he can (hoping, of course, to lighten his punishment if he gives up the next bigger fish), and hops into the van! This leads Chief to a much bigger dealer where Chief gets much more marijuana as well as various pills. So Chief arrests that guy as well. Unfortunately for Chief, his efforts to play the game at the next level higher stall right then and there. But still a pretty good haul for a bored cop just driving around looking for some action.

During our interviews at this stage, Diana added some important insight about Chief's assignment in vice-narcotics. These two years were very hard for Diana and daughter Heather. Chief often

worked very long hours and was often gone for entire days at a time. Diana experienced real fear during this time – so much so that Chief became uncomfortable with the assignment.

And then came the tipping point. But first we need to “see” Chief as he actually looked: like all male detectives in the narcotics unit in those days, Chief wore his hair long, and his beard longer. He looked like a wild mountain man. One day he drove to his daughter’s school to pick her up. When eight-year-old Heather entered the car and Chief pulled away, she told her dad that she was embarrassed to have him pick her up from school...looking the way he did.

That was the final straw – Chief asked for a transfer out of vice-narcotics. This is the first time we see Chief put his family before himself and his career. But it won’t be the last.

1985 – Back to the Range

For the next 18 months or so, Chief once again served as our rangemaster even though he was a detective by rank.

1986 – Back to the Juvenile Bureau

Chief was re-assigned to the Juvenile Bureau in 1986. And things would change for Chief...and for me. I was a school resource officer in the Juvenile Bureau when Chief came back to juvenile in 1986. And I was about to hit the jackpot...

CHAPTER 15

OLD PARTNER/NEW ROLE

1987 – 1989 – Burbank Detective Bureau

In the summer of 1987, I was promoted to detective - a position I coveted more than any other in my life. I stared at my detective badge for a solid week and often pinched myself to be sure that I wasn't dreaming. But with this "dream job" came a certain amount of apprehension. I am often a slow learner, and it took me much longer than several months to learn the ropes. In fact, it took about 18 months. Chief's break-in period as a new detective, on the other hand, was about 18 minutes. Somehow, I just had trouble figuring things out. While I may not have been very good at this new job, once again I was very, very lucky. Who should be in the office right next to mine on my first day but Chief! And as I often say, it's better to be lucky than good. Jackpot indeed!

This time, Chief trained me as a detective. I think I was more lost as a new detective than I was my first day in a patrol car as an officer in 1980. Our offices shared a thin wall, and I was in Chief's office every single day. Sometimes I was in his office getting his help several times in a day. I was a terrific example of average. I fully realized that God did not give me any real skill or talent in any area. Average, that's me. Except for four areas, and in these categories, I was definitely not average: math, science, music, and art. In these four areas, I was way below average. Sheesh.

One possible advantage of being average is vision. I could see clearly that Chief wasn't average in anything. He was simply the best in everything. The more amazing things he did, the more average I was. Oh brother. But I loved him all the more. I think back (without exaggeration) to that time with one very clear memory: with every new case I received, I studied it diligently. And I came up with zeros...nothing. So, without fail I walked into Chief's office with a case folder (or folders) and asked Chief if he would help me. And every time he responded the same way: "David, sure, come on in...whatcha got?" He treated each of my cases as if it was the one and only time I ever asked for help. He never showed the slightest sign of irritation, annoyance, or impatience. And as far as I could tell, he never told a soul that he was spoon feeding me month after month. All of that patience when he had a big caseload of his own to handle. After about eight months, I always entered his office with the same apologetic words: "Chief, I know I should get this stuff by now, but...well, I just don't want to make a mistake." He would always wave off my awkwardness and apologies and give me perfect advice and direction. Just like I was his beloved little brother. I would have died for this guy. In fact, I think he really enjoyed helping me...every day. For Chief, teaching, training and leading gave him the most pleasure. Even more than personal accomplishments on

his part. And if the success of those he taught gave him the most satisfaction and happiness, there is no doubt that I made him happier than anyone on earth because I had so much room to grow. Yes, he joyfully taught me everything.

Important Note: For the sake of the average reader, and certainly for those who have never worked as a police detective, a better explanation of the essence of the job of a detective is in order. Especially since I struggled so much to master it. The central aim of a detective is to arrive at the complete truth of an investigation. This objective includes two necessary elements. First, a detective must be proficient at gathering information – facts. I was sufficiently competent in this one area, although Chief was far better and more experienced. Secondly, a successful detective understands and is competent working what I call “the chess game.” This element is both critical and a bit difficult to describe, hence the use of the phrase “chess game.” Simply gathering information is not enough. And like a chess game, it requires strategy. Good detectives develop skill to determine what order specific information is gathered. Taking a step out of optimal order can ruin the outcome, just as it can in a chess game. Skilled detectives can look several steps down the road and employ the best strategy to reach a successful result. As an example, interviewing key players in the wrong order can lengthen the investigation unnecessarily, taint interviews, cause a suspect to flee, or suffer the loss of evidence.

Some cops are intuitively skilled at this element of detective work – when to do what. Chief was a natural at it; he completely understood the strategy of investigations the day after his detective promotion. But I did not enjoy this natural skill. While I understood the need for real strategy as an investigation unfolds, I also realized that I did not have this skill. I would have to learn it, and it would take the better part of 18 months. And it was Chief who realized this insufficiency at the start, and patiently brought me along until I was up to speed.

Dirty Shoulders

I didn't realize until I began to write this book that, in a sense, I stole from Chief during much of my time with him. When I was first promoted to detective, I took hours from him every week for more than a year with my constant requests for his help. It just never occurred to me then that while he was helping me, he wasn't working on his own cases. He was happy to give me that help, even if it meant losing time with his own work. And his shoulders became very dirty, because, for the longest time, he let me stand tall on his shoulders. I never even noticed his shoulders. If I had, I would have clearly seen the dirt from the bottom of my shoes. When I finally realized this sacrifice 35 years later, I felt terrible. But Chief never minded a bit.

July 14, 1987 – Senseless Murders

While Chief often worked cases involving children as victims, he also worked cases involving teenage criminals. In July of 1987, two 16-year-olds were drinking in a Burbank city park at night. They saw two homeless men (police call them “transients”) and decided to beat them up for fun. Both teenagers had experience with karate and used martial art techniques on the unsuspecting victims. Some witnesses to the attacks contacted police, and the boys were arrested the next day. Both victims were hospitalized and in comas.

When one of the victims died several days later, the boys, who confessed, were charged with murder. The second victim remained in a coma for several years, and finally died as well. The boys, now adults, were charged with his murder as well. (I was actually assigned to the second victim’s case upgrade to murder, and I attended the autopsy).

1988 – My First Murder Case

One day in 1988, I was assigned a murder case with six gang member suspects. This was my first homicide case. Chief helped me throughout that case and took no credit for a very successful outcome. At one point, I came into his office for help (as I always did), and Chief could see my frustration. I had five of the six suspects in custody, but there was one murderer still out there. Although I had him identified, I couldn’t find him. It seems this gang of six guys went to Izay Park in Burbank one night and had fun beating a homeless man to death. A familiar but tragic story. In a flurry of activity, I had the first five bad guys in custody. But there was that one last 19-year-old gang member still out there...

After several days of striking out, I came back to Chief for more help. He then tells me, “Let’s go, we’ll find him.” I remember two things about that moment very clearly: I was puzzled and I was excited. I had no idea how we were simply going to find this murderer, but then excitement came at once because I believed that somehow Chief could make it happen. We grabbed the keys and drove out of the station. It was only then that I asked Chief how we were going to find one guy amongst thousands of guys. You see, Chief didn’t always tell me all his thoughts and plans. Maybe he figured I could figure it out. But usually, being very average, I didn’t. His plan was simple: go to the park closest to this guy’s house somewhere in his city of residence (Highland Park) and ask anyone we could find about a “brindle” pit bull. Because a guy with our description might just walk his pit bull at a park. That’s about all we knew about his background – he owned a pit bull dog.

As I discussed this point of the investigation with Chief in the year 2025, my memory differed slightly from Chief's recollection. Since Chief always led, I'll defer to his version. We pulled into the parking lot of the park and Chief spots a maintenance employee cleaning the park rest room. As we approach the park employee to ask him about our suspect and his dog, Chief looks out across the large grass field and spots a guy emerging from some trees with a brindle pit bull on a leash.

Then came one of those "coincidences" in which only historical fact indulges us – fiction would never dare go down this road. I remember Chief saying at the time, "Dave, there's the guy, right there." How could this be? Although I had the absolute highest confidence in Chief's abilities, I knew he couldn't actually be perfect. Or could he? From that point on, I never entertained the slightest doubt that he was a wizard of the highest magnitude. I hesitate to use the word magical, but...

Just one more point about the arrest of our murder suspect. Chief and I always had a plan in cases like this. When approaching a dangerous suspect, two cops need a good plan. Both of us cannot draw our guns and at the same time grab a guy. And both of us cannot keep our guns holstered and grab the guy, since he might be armed. Our plan was simple and based on the best skill each of us possessed. Chief would draw his gun, since there wasn't a better shot in the world. I was fast, strong and agile, so I would approach the bad guy with my gun safely holstered. Each suspect has three choices when we approach and give orders at gunpoint: he can submit to our instructions, he can fight, or he can run. If he pulls a weapon, Chief will "cancel his ticket." If he runs, I'll get him because I can run fast and I can run all day long. If he fights, we have our worst situation. I'll stay with him in the fight until Chief decides it's safe to holster his gun and jump in to help me handcuff him.

In this case we had a complication – a pit bull dog who would probably protect his owner. Pit bulls are simply the scariest, most aggressive dogs for cops to handle. As we approached this guy, I told Chief to make sure to take out the pit bull if the dog showed any aggression. Pit bulls really bothered me. Chief assured me he would, and although pit bulls are scary, I knew Chief wouldn't miss. To my relief, our murder suspect fully complied with our orders. We handcuffed him and the dog offered no aggression.

Now we drive back to the station with our murder suspect in custody and book him. At my first opportunity, I tell everybody how Chief got us our murder suspect, starting with our supervisors and fellow detectives. I knew that if I didn't, Chief would never have taken any credit. I was on cloud nine – and Chief put me there.

Last Thought . . .

After booking the final suspect for this murder (the man, not the dog) and getting a confession (again from the man, not the dog), I sat down with Chief for a debrief. I said, "Chief, tell me without joking and without mystery. How on earth did you know this guy was going to be at that park? It wasn't coincidence, was it?" And Chief replied as follows: "Well, David, think of it this way. We weren't going to catch him sitting on our duffs here in the station. Cops very seldom nab criminals in the station. You have to get out on the street and make something happen. Understand?" Oh sure, I understood...I think. But I didn't really understand completely. It was entirely simple and logical, but Chief was trying to get a specific point across. Slowly, over time, I got the real point: detectives normally work at the police station, staring at police reports and computer screens. But successful, effective detectives get out where the action is. You can't make much happen, or stir up some dust, if you don't leave the station. Got it. Thanks Chief...again. But somehow, that song, "Do You Believe in Magic" kept going around in my head.

Chief Annoyed?

I handled a great many child molestation cases in my first few years as a detective alongside Chief in the juvenile bureau. During one particular molestation case, I almost annoyed Chief. Almost. I had interviewed an eight-year-old girl who had been molested by a family friend. I arrested the suspect, and he confessed his involvement to me in my office. During the trial, the defense attorney asked me if I had tape recorded my interview with the defendant and I said no. When he asked why I hadn't done so, I stated that I did not have access to a recording device. When he challenged my statements on the witness stand (since no recording existed), I asked the judge if I could confer with the prosecutor (detectives and prosecutors work together during the court process). I told the prosecutor that I often work with Detective Bison, and that our offices are divided by a thin wall. I described my office as follows: a bowl of candy sat on my desk, family photos were on display, and a zippered sweater hung on the coat rack. The prosecutor told me during a recess to call Chief and have him come to the courthouse to testify.

When I phoned Chief and told him that the prosecutor needed him in court, he was not exactly happy. "What does he need me for," Chief asks. When I explained the problem created by the defense attorney in questioning my veracity, Chief asked if I had thoroughly described my normal process. I told him that I tried, but the prosecutor wanted another witness to describe my process. Since Chief was very familiar with my investigative procedures, he was elected. But he just didn't seem happy about all this nonsense.

Chief arrived at court and the prosecutor put him on the stand. He then asked Chief to describe my usual procedures with respect to suspect interrogation. After that, he asked Chief to describe me and my office. Chief described it all this way: "Detective Gabriel never raises his voice and never uses profanity or threats. He offers everyone candy from his candy dish. He has family photos in his office, and he often wears his zippered sweater. In fact, his nickname (with respect to interrogation) is Mr. Rogers." Chief also explained that a very thin wall separated our offices, and he could almost always hear some level of murmured conversations I had with suspects. At this point, the defense attorney was obviously regretting his decision to challenge my testimony (especially when he heard the nickname Mr. Rogers applied to me!).

The jury easily convicted the child molester, and Chief, as always, provided me with invaluable help!

CHAPTER 16

THE RESCUE

October 13, 1989 – Olive Overpass, Burbank

Starting in 1989, Chief was training a new detective named Eric Rosoff. On one incredible day, while Chief and Eric were driving back to the station from lunch, a field emergency alert tone went out. The dispatcher let all officers know that a “jumper” was on the Olive overpass. Chief and Eric responded to this crisis in their plain car, and as was often the case, Chief arrived and took charge of the scene. He directed the communications center to have the CHP block traffic in both directions of the freeway and have our patrol officers stop traffic in both directions of the overpass. The jumper was a 17-year-old girl on the wrong side of the railing staring down at the freeway. They would later learn that she attended Burbank High School and was despondent over a breakup with her boyfriend. Chief parked his car, removed his badge and gun, and slowly, carefully, casually walked toward the girl as if he was an ordinary citizen. He talked with her for about 40 minutes, trying to inch a little closer to her with each passing minute without frightening her into jumping. When Chief was about three feet from her, he saw a “change” in her face. He said that he “almost saw the pulse in her neck,” and right then the girl let go of the railing with her hands.

In this split second in time, Chief frantically reached out to her and, with one hand, caught her around the upper arm. His grip instantly moved (slipped) to her arm, and then her wrist – and Chief made sure not to lose his grip on her wrist. One inch either way, and he watches a teenage girl fall to her death. The girl was now dangling freely, held only by Chief’s hand latched onto her wrist. Chief was quoted in the newspaper as follows: “Her arm actually slipped through my hand all the way down to her wrist. It was a lucky grab.”

At this point, Chief faced an unexpected surprise: the girl immediately began kicking and screaming in an attempt to free herself and complete her dreadful plan. Chief said she “was kicking and screaming, saying ‘let me go...I want to die.’” As Chief held her full weight with his arm wrapped over the railing, he was eventually helped by two other officers and the girl was pulled to safety. But Chief was injured and he knew it. When he returned to Eric Rosoff and their car, he simply said: “Drive me to the hospital.” He was in a great deal of pain, and he learned that he had broken three ribs and torn the rotator cuff in his shoulder.

One interesting fact about this incident that resulted in Chief saving another life (at the partial expense of his health): Chief essentially performed all the functions in this incident. He initially handled the supervisor duties by blocking traffic. But then he served as hostage negotiator himself, and then as rescuer! But absolutely nothing about this overall effort surprised me. It was simply vintage Chief.

CHAPTER 17

A VISIT FROM MARGARET THATCHER

February 1991 – Burbank Airport

President Ronald Reagan had been out of office for more than two years in 1991. During his eight years as president (1981-1989), he and British Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher got on famously as heads of state and allies. Margaret Thatcher had been out of office for one year and was invited to Reagan's 80th birthday celebration in Southern California. They had become more than allies – they were great friends. Reagan and Thatcher were still probably the two most famous people in the world. And, somehow, Chief became involved in at least part of it.

Before Thatcher arrived, the Burbank Police Chief (you remember, the other chief) came to see Chief Bison. It seems that the FBI had contacted our department asking for some help with Thatcher's arrival at the Burbank airport. They asked for one trained sniper and an observer for a particular rooftop at the airport. In 1991, Chief made up "all" of our snipers and weapons experts. Even though he was no longer our rangemaster, he kept suitable weapons in the armory of our old station – including a "tommy" gun (Thompson sub machine gun). From this arsenal, Chief selected a 30.06 rifle with a variable scope, but he admittedly hadn't used or checked any of the weapons in quite some time.

Margaret Thatcher was to be bundled out of the airport on the west side, and the FBI asked Chief for "high ground coverage." Chief (from a rooftop) and his observer had radios and were in contact with the FBI agents and the airport tower.

After Thatcher's arrival, Chief saw agents loading her into a car on the west side of the airport. And then a very strange and somewhat dangerous thing happened. Out of seemingly nowhere, a helicopter appeared and swooped down on the convoy of cars that were transporting the former prime minister of Great Britain. Chief sensed the possible threat this presented and tightened the strap of his rifle to prepare to protect the convoy. At the worst possible time, the strap breaks and the helicopter goes right by Chief's position. When the strap broke, it delayed his ability to fire if need be, for a few seconds at least. Via radio, Chief heard someone from the tower yell at the helicopter pilot to remove his aircraft from that area. The pilot acknowledged and the "threat" was diverted at the last second. Somehow, that pilot accidentally took the wrong course, but his actions amounted to more than a simple mistake. He was actually arrested!

CHAPTER 18

THE ATTACK – TRAGEDY NUMBER ONE

April 1991 – Panorama City

Note: this chapter comes almost entirely from Diana Bison. I was very reluctant to include any details of this tragedy in Chief's book. Diana discussed this issue thoroughly with daughter Heather, and both strongly believed that the details should be part of Chief's story. They believed that this biography is actually more than Chief's life – it is the Bison legacy. Since this incident was a major part of Bison family life, it must be included. In large part, the entire incident and beyond reflect the determination and resiliency of the entire family. They stood resolute concerning one important concept: this incident, no matter how traumatic, will not define them. So, very reluctantly, I agreed to include most of the details. But I did not discuss this tragedy with Chief during any of our interviews. I couldn't...it was entirely too painful.

In April 1991, Chief and I were working as detectives in the violent crime unit. I had finally learned some things about detective work and now only went to Chief for help a few times a month rather than several times a day. We were not paired up in the same office, but we still often worked together.

On April 10, 1991, after duty hours, Chief was called in to work from home on a stabbing case. I was not called on this particular investigation. Diana had finally gone to bed, but 15-year-old daughter Heather was allowed to stay up a little longer. When Chief was out late on investigations, Heather often stayed up to wait for her father. Before retiring, Diana told Heather not to stay up too long since the next day was a school day. Some time after falling asleep, Diana was awakened by a strange noise that turned out to be Heather screaming. Diana emerged from her bedroom and immediately faced a shotgun pointed at her head. She looked in the den and saw another intruder pointing a shotgun at Heather's head. When Heather saw an intruder pointing a shotgun at her mother, she pleaded: "Please don't hurt my mommy." The suspects ordered mother and daughter to lie face down on the living room floor and covered them with a blanket.

While one suspect (suspect number two) stayed with Diana and Heather, the other suspect (suspect number one) searched the house for money and other valuables. He took Chief's shotgun that he found under the bed. He looked up and saw a large mirror with the words "Burbank Police Department" stenciled on it. Suspect number one became enraged and yelled to Heather, "Is your dad a cop?" When Heather replied, "Yes," he began to scream and yell, "I hate cops, I hate cops!"

As mother and daughter cowered under the blanket, the same intruder yelled several threats: "Maybe we better stick around a little bit longer so we can blow him away. I can just see the headlines tomorrow, 'Cop's brains blown all over the sidewalk.' Or maybe we should blow you away so he can come home and see your brains before we blow him away." With his partner (suspect number two) still standing guard, irate suspect number one grabbed Heather and took her to her room. Diana was devastated at the thought of what was about to happen. Suspect number one held a pillow over Heather's face, but Diana could hear her daughter's muffled cries. Diana lifted up her head to try to help her daughter, but suspect number two shoved her head back down with the barrel of his shotgun. And then Heather was raped.

Suspect number two ordered Diana to undress, unzipped his pants, and appeared ready to rape her when suspect number one came into the living room. Instead, suspect number two made lewd comments to Diana and yanked her to her feet, but did not assault her.

When mother and daughter were reunited, one suspect put the gun to Diana's head and barked: "Ok, mom, are there any last words you want to say to your daughter?" Heather squeezed Diana's hand because they both knew they were about to die. While waiting for the sound of a gunshot, Diana thought about how awful this was going to be for her In-laws – the deaths of their entire family. Diana was hoping that they would shoot Heather first so that her daughter would not have to endure the pain and anxiety of hearing her mother's death and then wait for her own. Both suspects could be heard discussing the fact that they needed to leave soon and join their other partners who were circling the block.

All of a sudden, the suspects pulled the blanket off and told mother and daughter that this was their lucky day. They pushed the two victims into the bathroom, throwing Diana into the bathtub first and then Heather on top of her mother. A bucket of very cold water that had been sitting in the tub (used during a drought to save excess water) was then dumped on both victims. Diana and Heather were told not to move, and that someone would be watching.

Diana heard the front door close, and Heather whispered to her mother, "He raped me." As horrible as it was to hear, Diana already knew.

About six or seven minutes later, Chief arrived home, having just missed the intruders. Nothing ever gets by this great warrior, and tonight would be no different. Chief noticed that the front door was unlocked, and as he cautiously entered, he saw Diana's empty purse on the ground with

the contents spilled on the floor. Chief immediately called out for his wife, and Diana hesitated a few seconds, fearing that the next sound she heard would be gunshots (Chief versus two bad guys with shotguns, since she remembered the suspects talking about waiting for her husband to return so they could shoot him). Diana started screaming, "They're going to shoot you, we're in here." Both suspects had actually left the scene. This was 1991, a little too soon for the common use of cellphones, and the suspects had pulled the house phones out of the wall. Chief had to run to a neighbor's house to call the police – LAPD.

Both suspects were caught several days later and faced very serious charges because they had committed several other similar crimes. Diana and Heather testified and both suspects were convicted.

Diana added the following thoughts . . .

As time progressed, all three members of the Bison family experienced the same nightmare from a different perspective. As they pondered the entire tragedy, they focused primarily on one feature: they lived! But, without question, Chief and Diana suffered from crushing guilt. Chief's guilt centered around two points: he didn't protect his family (police officers are often described as protectors), and his chosen profession led to the rape of his daughter. And Diana was stricken by the fact that she was 10 feet from her daughter and could not protect her.

Yet from the very onset of this evil crime, 15-year-old Heather was only worried about her mother. Heather had to go every few months to get tested for AIDS and STDs – a terrible experience for a teenager. As far as Diana is concerned, Heather was the strongest and bravest 15-year-old girl in history. Any reasonable person in her position might agree.

I can only add that the entire family is strong and resolute based on another rather unusual fact. Unlike most families that experience tragedies due to horrible crimes, the Bisons stayed together. They did not split apart. And they grew even stronger.

Diana's Special Quote

"How do I (Diana) know without a shadow of a doubt there is a God? Rich was ready to come home that night after work ended when Eric Rosoff wanted to show him his new trailer. Rich didn't want to take the time to see it at that point, but as a good friend he agreed. That delayed him an hour or so. If that had not happened, this would be a different story."

Chief's Special Note

Just as the trial was about to begin, the defense attorney asked to speak to Chief outside the courtroom. When they were alone, the defense attorney assured Chief that he would not aggravate his family's pain by asking Diana and Heather many questions or challenging them on the witness stand. Chief had never even heard of such an assurance from a defense attorney. When the trial resumed, the defense attorney was true to his word. He asked Diana and Heather the bare minimum amount of questions, and never challenged any of their assertions. Amid pure misery, Chief was truly touched.

My Note

I have let Chief down on two occasions...to my everlasting shame. The first time I failed him occurred just after this tragedy. It is frankly just too painful to write about in detail, but suffice to say that this tragedy chewed me up and I was simply not there for him and his family. The very thought of such intense pain to Chief and his family left me almost paralyzed. The second time I failed him? I will cover that at the very end of this biography. But I can assure the reader that this particular failure will be with me until I die.

CHAPTER 19

HOMICIDE

1989 – 1993 – Burbank Detective Bureau

In 1989, I was assigned to the violent crimes unit (called “crimes against persons” as opposed to “crimes against property”). I finally started to grow and improve as a detective, and I was given this coveted position based solely on Chief’s efforts to prepare me. During my last two years as a detective (1991-1993), instead of frequently seeking the help of others, to my great surprise, they actually sought my help! That “turn around” was truly mind boggling, and it was almost completely due to all that Chief had done for me.

The Accidental Joke - Soupy Sales

Chief had never played a practical joke (or “lesson”) on me. I think he felt sorry for me and never even considered it. During our interviews (2025) I asked Chief about that, and he adamantly insisted he never played those jokes on those who didn’t deserve them. He never found me guilty of those despicable cop sins: lazy, disrespectful, deceitful, cocky, selfish, or cheating. So, claims the great warrior, he would never have done such a thing to a decent guy like me.

Then I reminded him of “soupy sales,” and he leaned back and roared with laughter as he did in 1991 when it happened. But he insisted in this 2025 interview, as he did when it happened 34 years ago, that “soupy sales” was not intentional – it was purely accidental. Since he has never lied to me, I suppose it was just an accident. But I’ll let you judge.

In about December 1991, Chief and I were working violent crimes. That included missing persons and lots of death investigations. Chief was given a missing persons case involving a man about 50 years old. Since a missing adult does not constitute a crime, we rarely investigated them unless there were suspicious circumstances. In this case, Chief saw nothing unusual – just a middle-aged guy who went missing. About three or four days later, we were told about a vehicle left in a restaurant parking lot for several days. When patrol officers learned from the registration that it belonged to Chief’s missing person, we responded to the scene from the station.

When we arrived, we knew something was wrong when we were still about 10 feet from the car. We could see lots of big black flies inside the vehicle, and we found the doors were locked. All of the windows were up except one, and that one was only slightly open. About five feet from the car, we were greeted by

an old acquaintance – the terrible odor of decomposing flesh. And there he was. Chief's missing person was no longer missing – he was curled up in the back seat of his car. Thoroughly and completely expired. Every death that occurs outside of a hospital (and a few inside hospitals) require a police investigation to determine the cause and manner of death. Police officers, and homicide detectives in particular, must look for any suspicious circumstances that could mean an unlawful homicide (murder or manslaughter, as opposed to suicide, accidental, or justifiable homicide).

That specific aim is “muddied-up” a bit when the body begins to decompose. As decomposition increases, the chances of determining cause of death decrease. Our dead guy had been in the back seat of his car for several days. So, when the coroner's personnel took the dead guy out of the car, the corpse didn't exactly come out perfectly whole (think of a freshly baked cake that changes over time to a very runny pudding...did that analogy help?). Needless to say, this was not a favorite part of our job.

We knew the dead guy was an alcoholic, so we made a preliminary guess that he got drunk, parked in the restaurant parking lot rather than try to make it home, crawled into the car's backseat, and fell asleep. And he simply never woke up.

We were told by the coroner's office that the autopsy would take place on the following Saturday at about ten in the morning. Our police department's dinner-dance was that Saturday evening, and I told Chief that I would attend the autopsy in the morning and see him later at the dinner-dance. Chief thanked me and said he would see me then.

Before I describe the autopsy, I must point out that Chief had more experience than I did with homicides. I had attended many autopsies myself, but never one like this. Chief had.

When I entered the coroner's office, I “gowned up” and entered the primary room looking for the dead guy. We called him “soupy sales” because of his “loose,” decomposed condition. The main room of the coroner's office holds about 10 bodies, each with a toe tag bearing a name and case number. I look at 10 different toe tags, but no soupy sales. I look in a few smaller adjoining rooms and checked more tags, but still nothing. Finally, an employee helps me with my search. He told me that my guy is “through the door, down the hall, turn right and look for the door with the word ‘Decomposition’ written on it.” To most guys in my position, that word should have set off alarm bells. But for some reason, I missed the true significance of the word (think single room, closed off, with a single entry/exit door that is always closed).

When I found the door, I opened it and took one step inside just as I inhaled. The shock of the odor caused an unconscious reaction: I did an about face and started walking out! As I let the door close, my brain finally started to work. While outside in the hallway, I realized that I had no choice but to do another about face and try entering a second time. I grabbed the door handle, hesitated about three seconds, took a deep breath, held it, and re-entered the room. I see that the pathologist had already begun the autopsy. I had attended a few of this doctor's autopsies before, and she greeted me as follows: "Hey, there you are. I thought you weren't going to make it." At this point, I'm forced to take another breath, and I almost pass out from the sickening smell. I explained my tardiness by mentioning that I never knew this decomposition room existed. No one (including Chief) had ever told me about it. I immediately begin a conversation with myself: "David, you can't leave. This is your job. You must stay and get through this. Wait till I see Chief and ask him about this!" About halfway through the autopsy, the doctor says she is pretty sure the guy died of a diseased liver from a lifetime of alcohol abuse. She says, therefore, that there's no reason I need to stay. She says she knows the odor is horrible – even she has trouble with it after 22 years! I thanked her and almost flew out of the door. Wait till I see Chief about this one!

Later that night my wife and I drive to the dinner-dance, with one little nagging companion: I still have some of the terrible smell inside my nostrils. Yuk! We enter the banquet hall and we see Chief sitting with Diana at a table. We walk up to them and Chief greets me in the ordinary, normal way. I told him I attended the autopsy of soupy sales earlier that day. Chief asks me how it went, and if it showed anything different than what we expected (something related to alcohol abuse). I tell him that the pathologist preliminarily believed that alcohol abuse led to a bad liver, so apparently there was nothing suspicious about the death. Then I told Chief, "Hey Chief, the autopsy took place in the decomposition room – a place I never knew existed." It immediately dawned on the great warrior that it would have to be conducted in that room. And that he never warned me about it. Chief broke into gales of laughter as he realized what really happened to me. I reacted with a curious but decided absence of appreciation for his humor, and Chief laughed all the more!

One can't help managing at least a smile when Chief laughs that way, and I did in fact finally see some humor in it. Then I half-heartedly accused Chief of intentionally "setting me up" with a dirty trick by "failing" to tell me about the decomp room. As Chief's laughing dies down, he insists over and over that he simply forgot...everything. He forgot that the soupy sales autopsy would be in the worst room in Los Angeles County. And he forgot to tell me the room even existed. Sheesh. I believed him...I suppose. But as I thought about it, I realized that if I worked homicide long enough, the decomposition room and I must eventually meet again. It's all part of the job.

1992 Holiday Inn

I worked in that same unit for about 18 months before Chief joined the unit. We paired up many times on big cases, but none was bigger than one particular murder.

One night in 1992, several members of the violent crimes unit were called in some time after midnight for a murder investigation at the Holiday Inn just down the street from the station. Chief got there first, and he began discussing the case with our unit supervisor, Sergeant Doyle Holm. Doyle and Chief were fairly close friends. Doyle tells Chief: "Rich, I'm going to assign this one to you. And I'm going to assign Reese (not his real name) to be your partner." Chief stared at Doyle and replied, "No, I'm not working with Reese. Give me Dave Gabriel instead." With a slight amount of aggravation, Doyle asked: "Well, what am I going to do with Reese?" So Chief gave Doyle a few ideas, including a suggestion that Doyle take Reese himself and follow up on a few minor leads (that was "code" for "keep Reese away from me"). When I arrived, I was told that it was Chief's case and I would be his partner (number two man). I was thrilled...again. I would have been happy to dig ditches with Chief.

Chief and I faced a "who-done-it." We had a dead Asian man in his mid thirties near the ground floor elevator inside the hotel. He was lying in a pool of his own blood, having been shot once through the forehead. We noticed two other things right away: he had been carrying several shirts from the cleaners that were now on the floor. And we saw a nearly perfect shoe print in the blood that did not match the victim's shoes. We noticed that the shoe pattern was unusual, and we later determined that the pattern was from a Florsheim dress shoe. Chief also noticed distinctive stitching in the shoe pattern.

We learned that a Jaguar parked in the hotel parking lot probably belonged to our victim. Using the victim's keys, we began to search the car's interior looking for any helpful information. The progress of this homicide investigation depended on how much we could learn about our victim – and the faster the better. As we were searching the car, we learned from hotel staff that our victim was possibly friends with a man in room 635 of the hotel. Chief sent me up to that room to try and obtain more information while he continued searching the vehicle.

I knocked on the door of room 635 (at 2:30 a.m.) and after several seconds it was answered by an older man named Lonnie Elder. After I identified myself, Mr. Elder invited me into his room in a cooperative manner. I noticed at once that Lonnie Elder lived permanently in this hotel room – it was full of all his worldly goods. I explained that we were investigating a homicide, and I asked Mr.

Elder if he knew a guy who drove a blue Jaguar. He said that he didn't think so. I believed that he was answering truthfully at the time. I realized that Mr. Elder appeared a bit bewildered, primarily due to several factors: I had awakened him out of a sound sleep, he was an older man, and the word "homicide" obviously shook him up a bit. I didn't see much of a connection at that moment between Mr. Elder and our victim because of one very obvious difference: our victim was an Asian man in his thirties and Mr. Elder was a black man in his early sixties. It just didn't seem to fit.

I went back down to the parking lot just in time to see Chief open the car's glove box. Chief asked me if I learned anything from the guy in room 635. I told him no, just as Chief removed a Holiday Inn key with the number 635 printed on it! My eyes probably got as big as silver dollars, and I told Chief I was going back to re-interview Lonnie Elder in room 635. I could feel Chief's eyes following me back to the elevator.

Once I was back in Lonnie Elder's room, I asked him the questions once more. I added that our victim was of apparent Asian descent, and that he had a room key for 635 in his car. Mr. Elder still seemed a bit confused, so I asked him to come downstairs with me to take a look at our victim. With one look at the dead man, Mr. Elder recognized him at once and gave a name that matched the vehicle registration of the Jaguar. We learned from Mr. Elder that our victim was Filipino and that he often picked up prostitutes in Hollywood. The victim had "fallen" for one particular prostitute with the street name of "Heather."

We eventually identified Heather, who was in fact a known street prostitute in the Hollywood area. Her "pimp" was known by his street name, "Shadow." And another man was often with Shadow and Heather – known on the street as "Monacia," whose real name was James Hamilton. Hamilton had previously done 15 years for a previous murder, so we knew we were dealing with some very dangerous people.

Heather admitted to us that our victim met her often and was trying to get her out of the prostitution business. He had fallen for her and wanted a permanent, legitimate relationship with Heather. We also learned from Heather that Shadow was furious about this attempt to "steal" his street worker. Eventually, Shadow and Hamilton went to meet our victim at the Holiday Inn to confront him about his attempts to win Heather away from them. While Heather sat in Shadow's car in the hotel parking lot, Hamilton shot our victim in the head. Heather told us that she heard the shot but saw nothing. She did notice when the two males returned to the car that they had stolen the victim's gold chain necklace.

Several days later, we had Shadow in custody and we were looking for Hamilton. We believed that while Shadow was at the crime scene and definitely involved in the crime, the suspect who actually shot the victim was James Hamilton. We discovered the location of Hamilton's ex-girlfriend, and we learned that he sometimes hung out at her place in Hollywood. We set up a surveillance there with Chief and I in one unmarked car, and several other Burbank detective units nearby.

At one point, Chief saw a guy coming from the area of the ex-girlfriend's house that was close to the description of James Hamilton. He walked by us and entered a liquor store. We notified our other units via radio that we possibly had our suspect in view. While the man was in the store, Chief backed our car into a different parking space so we would be ready to follow him more quickly.

As the man came out of the store, Chief said, "I think that's him." The man walked toward the ramp of a train platform, and we radioed for our backup units to converge there. Chief then said to me: "Go get him. Don't let him get on that train. I'll cover you from behind." I left the car and raced after the man we believed to be our murder suspect. He headed up the ramp of the platform and I was nearly on top of him – but with my gun holstered. I knew Chief was hurriedly following with his gun out and pointed at our suspect. I remember thinking two things: our suspect was probably armed (and very dangerous), and I sure hope Chief can shoot accurately while running. My entire focus was on the suspect's hands – I needed to secure his hands. I was more concerned about his right hand, since most people are right-handed. If he was going to shoot me, it would likely be with his right hand.

I reached our suspect at the top of the ramp – but he still had no idea anyone was chasing him. As I grabbed him, I yelled, "Burbank Police! You're under arrest!" I took him down to the ground and secured his empty right hand. Just as I did, Chief arrived, holstered his gun, and helped me handcuff him.

But we still weren't certain that he was the James Hamilton we were after. And then we both simultaneously looked at his shoes. The man was wearing Florsheim dress shoes with the exact same tread pattern that we had seen in the victim's blood at the scene of our crime. His shoes even had the same distinctive stitching left by the suspect on the bloody floor. Jackpot!

Unbeknownst to us, when Chief ran after me with his gun drawn, he attracted the attention of two LAPD patrol officers in a marked car at the same intersection. They had no idea that the man in

plain clothes who was pointing a gun was a detective from another police department. Burbank Detective Roger Mason was near Chief and noticed that the LAPD officers were about to draw their guns on Chief! Roger waved his badge at the patrol officers and yelled, "Burbank police - we're working a homicide!" And then a strange, almost unthinkable thing happened: the LAPD officers acknowledged Roger's information and drove off! They didn't even bother to offer help! So much for LAPD – we were not impressed.

Now we had three in custody for the Holiday Inn murder: Shadow, James Hamilton, and Heather. Both Chief and I at once formed an obvious plan: with the D/A's approval, we made Heather our star witness (rather than work to try her as a co-principal in the crime). She turned out to be a very important witness for the prosecution.

But the case was still going to be tough to prove to 12 jurors. Our best witness was a street prostitute and we had no eyewitnesses. Chief was transferred to traffic division just as the trial got underway, so Roger Mason and I worked with the D/A throughout the trial. There was one rather bizarre distraction in our trial. Our case was tried in downtown Los Angeles rather than in Pasadena Superior Court (which was our normal trial location). At the exact time we began our trial, O.J. Simpson was being tried in the same building, two floors below us. The news media's entire arsenal was there – hundreds of reporters, and all for O.J. Simpson. No one paid any attention to us!

The Chicken

One of the sticky points of our case involved Heather's planned testimony. She told us that she heard the shot that killed the victim even though she was seated in a closed car in the hotel parking lot. Since that would be her anticipated testimony, the defense claimed that it would be impossible to hear the shot under those circumstances. So Roger Mason devised an experiment that involved our reserve rangemaster, Duane Wolfer. Roger bought a whole raw chicken for the experiment. With the help of some police volunteers, Roger and Duane took the chicken to the Holiday Inn at the same time of night as the murder. They told the hotel staff about the experiment in advance. They had a female volunteer sit in a closed car in the very same parking space that the killers had used. Duane used the same caliber gun to replicate the actual event (but obviously with blanks). The female in the car was told to report a gunshot if she heard one. Duane then fired one shot at the chicken from the same distance we believed existed between the shooter and the victim (less than 12 inches). The female in the car reported that she did in fact hear the gunshot, ostensibly proving that it was entirely possible for Heather to have heard the actual shot on the night of the crime. And they video recorded the entire experiment!

Later in court, the defense argued to exclude the chicken experiment due to a lack of appropriate expertise on the part of Roger and Duane. But the judge, J.D. Smith, ruled in favor of the prosecution and Roger was allowed to testify about the entire chicken affair. To this day, I wonder if Judge Smith ruled in our favor because of legal factors or because of his favorable relationship with Chief (the judge knew this was Chief's case, and I heard Chief call him "J.D." – more about that later).

Both suspects were convicted and sentenced to prison for a very long time.

Important Note: I used the word "we" quite often in describing this murder investigation. But don't let me mislead you: this was entirely Chief's case. He made all of the important decisions and investigative chess moves. I merely tagged along and loved every minute of my time with him. I had a front row seat watching the best.

Although Chief doesn't remember it today, he indirectly paid me possibly my greatest career compliment at about this time in 1992. He was discussing major crime investigations with some other detectives when he made the following statement: "David Gabriel is the best technical detective I've ever worked with." One of the other detectives later told me about that statement, and I walked on the clouds for months. And if it was indeed true, it was only true because of all that Chief had done for me.

In April 1993, I was promoted to sergeant, and I was assigned to patrol as a field supervisor (standard procedure). Chief remained in the traffic unit investigating traffic accidents and traffic crimes. I'm sure that there was no one in traffic who bothered him so often with a hundred questions the way I had. But somehow, I don't believe he found the same real satisfaction in another partner – not because I was inherently such an amazing cop. But because Chief had made me so much better. Chief loved teaching law enforcement, and I had so much to learn. He watched me succeed, promote, and shine. And inside, Chief was smiling more than if he had accomplished all of this himself.

CHAPTER 20

LITTLE CHIEF AND THE JUDGES

1993 – Little Chief at Home

At about this time, Chief and Diana had a get-together at their house and my wife and I were included. After we ate, we were all sitting in a large circle in the living room chatting away. Chief's parents were there as well. Diana announced she was heading for the kitchen, and someone mentioned a desire to see their dog. Diana said that she would bring their springer spaniel in to greet everyone. The dog's name: Chief, of course. Then, a very strange thing happened. Well, considering the great Sioux warrior, maybe not so very strange.

As Diana let the dog into the living room, she said with a sly smile, "Watch this." The dog went directly to where Chief was sitting and shivered with excitement. There must have been 10 or 12 people in that room, but the dog completely ignored everyone else, including Diana. He just stood inches from Chief, with his tail wagging furiously. I suggested the dog's loyalty must be due to the fact that Chief fed him. Diana corrected me, declaring that Chief never fed the dog – only Diana fed him. Then I tried really hard to coax the dog to me – whistling, chirping, and calling him by name. The dog finally looked left in my direction for about one half of a second and then resumed his worship of Chief. Sheesh. I did learn later that Chief often took the dog out hunting and training. Like everyone else, the dog loved him.

Diana told me that the dog seemed to know when Chief was close to home after work. But Chief returned home from work at different times almost every day based on his caseload. Usually about five minutes before Chief's car entered the driveway, the dog would go to the living room window and whine in anticipation of his master's arrival. Diana found this behavior remarkable, and I agree, since Chief did not come home at the same time every day. The dog always seemed to get it right.

Note: my wife and I finally got a dog in 2004, and named him Chief. I loved that dog...

The Judges

(**Note to reader:** What you are about to read about the judges is very, very unusual. In fact, I've never even heard of one such case, let alone more. And Chief had three...virtually impossible unless, of course, you are the last, true Chief).

When Chief and I worked together as detectives chasing bad guys, we often found ourselves meeting with judges to have search warrants reviewed and signed. And, as always, Chief was friends with everyone. Even the judges. Chief knew at least three judges in a way not known to cops: Alan Kalkin, Ron Cohen, and J.D. Smith. And Chief called them all by their first names! Now this simply blew me away. Chief was a product of the army and a police department. He knew and honored respect for authority as well as anyone. I knew Chief was an amazing leader and nearly everyone became his friend in ten minutes flat. But judges? First name basis?

Judge Alan Kalkin

On many occasions, Chief and I met with Judge Kalkin with arrest warrants and search warrants. When Chief first arrived at the Burbank Police Department in 1973, Alan Kalkin was simply an assistant city prosecutor. Chief filed many of his cases with Kalkin, who quickly developed a deep fondness for this Sioux warrior. While Chief was a combat veteran from Vietnam, Alan Kalkin was a combat veteran from the Korean war. Alan Kalkin eventually became a judge, and Chief simply continued to call him Alan – but not in open court.

Judge Ron Cohen

Judge Ron Cohen was a superior court judge who happened to live in Burbank. Chief first began working with him when Ron Cohen was a deputy district attorney, and, as always, Cohen took an immediate liking to Chief. Ron Cohen was a very talented judge who handled a great many murder trials. He was also a supervisory superior court judge. On one particular murder case, Chief and I were preparing a search warrant at night and needed a judge's signature. Chief suggested we contact "Ron" who was located in Burbank. I asked him who Ron was, and I learned for the first time about Chief's friend, Judge Ron Cohen. We arrived at Judge Cohen's house around 8:30 p.m., and when the door opened, Chief says: "Hi Ron, how are you?" Judge Cohen greeted Chief in the same informal way and welcomed us in. The judge was obviously quite pleased to see his friend Rich Bison again.

I started wondering if Chief called all the judges in Los Angeles County by their first name!

Note: Turns out, Chief and Ron Cohen went to the same high school, but obviously did not hang out together considering their obviously different high school priorities. The truly interesting difference in their lives is rather simple: Ron Cohen applied himself, worked hard, earned excellent grades, eventually went to law school and later became a supervisory judge. And Chief traded all of that for fighting, drinking, hunting, fishing, and working. Still, somehow, Ron Cohen had the highest opinion of Chief. Didn't everybody?

Judge J. D. Smith

When Chief and I were helping the prosecutor try the Holiday Inn murder case in downtown Los Angeles, we were not in our comfort zone. We normally tried our serious cases in Pasadena Superior Court. At least we had no media distractions in Los Angeles – all of the media was focused on the O.J. Simpson case in the same building.

The judge in our case was J.D. Smith. During a break in our case, as the judge called for a recess, he yelled out: “Hey Rich, come on over here (to the bench).” I whipped my head around just in time to hear Chief’s reply: “Hi J.D., great to see you again.” Just when I thought Chief’s informal relationship with Kalkin and Cohen might have been due to the connection of the city of Burbank, the situation changed. How does Chief know this Los Angeles superior court judge by first name? So I had to ask him. It seems that Chief came across Smith’s path when Smith was a Los Angeles police officer, and again when Smith was a Deputy District Attorney. But they spent very little time in each other’s company. And typical of this marvelous Indian, Chief was impressive and unforgettable to Smith. All of these talented judges saw Chief on their level – and truly enjoyed his company.

Note: you might be wondering why I combined both Little Chief and the judges together. Simply put, the dog, however much loved, sits at one end of the spectrum. The judges stand tall at the other end. From top to bottom, Chief was, and is, loved and respected by virtually everyone.

April 1993

I was promoted to sergeant and left the detective position forever. Once again, without Chief’s help, guidance, and training, this promotion does not happen. Although he was made to be a sergeant, Chief chose not to pursue promotions for the sake of his family. Patrol sergeants often work nights, weekends, and holidays. With Diana working normal hours and daughter Heather in school, Chief remained a detective to be with his family every available moment.

In one way, the Burbank Police Department lost it’s finest and most competent leader/supervisor when Chief decided not to promote. Remember, he served as an acting sergeant in many assignments and probably more often than anyone else.

Before I left the detective bureau to start a new life as a patrol sergeant, I chatted with Chief about our years together. He made two observations I will never forget. First, he said, “David, it’s much

more important to enjoy the people you're working with than the work itself. I'd rather dig ditches with guys I like than do my favorite work with guys I don't." And I've always believed he is right about that. Secondly, he gave me wonderful leadership advice: "David, always remember how important your role is as a supervisor and leader. Set the best example you possibly can of what a Burbank police officer is supposed to be. One officer on a team, or one soldier in a platoon, can mess up and the leader can still hold the team together. But if the leader messes up, the whole team or platoon can fail." I have never forgotten that point.

When I expressed concern about my new job, and my slow learning curve, Chief simply said, "David, this department promoted the right guy. You'll do great!" And I almost started to believe him...

Recreation – Off Duty and On

Chief arranged a great deal of recreation for those working at the police department. He planned countless camping trips and vacations with a great many families. And occasionally, he arranged barbecues on duty – around department BBQ grills outside the back doors of our new building (1995).

But it was the camping trips that became famous. And there was one game in particular that Chief liked to play around the campfire with newer campers (including my wife and me). The game was called "My Aunt Tillie," and like most rookie campers, I fell for it hook, line, and sinker. As we sat in a circle around the campfire, Chief explained the simple game to the uninformed. It involved only an easy, catchy little song. Chief would start singing the "My Aunt Tillie" song by standing and doing a stylish soft rock dance. "This is how it goes," says Chief: "My Aunt Tillie, she died last night, she died last night, she died last night, my Aunt Tillie, she died last night, she diiiiiiied" (and that last word has to be thoroughly drawn out). And for a great Sioux warrior, Chief's swish dancing wasn't bad at all. Then the next person would give it a try. But this is where the trick of the game came into play. If you sang the song while doing a dance without starting with the words "this is how it goes," your version was wrong. And Chief told you that you got it wrong, but neglected to say why it was wrong. Some of the more experienced campers knew the trick of the game and started with the magic words, causing Chief to give his approval. But dopes like me didn't catch on at all, until a few rounds done "improperly" caused Chief to show some mercy by betraying the secret words. Of course, his mercy was mixed with a healthy dose of laughter.

But while Chief loved being outdoors, at least one of his adventures turned out...below average. Chief put a motorcycle (dirt bike) trip together with some of the guys from the department. At one

point, the guys headed back to camp and Chief wasn't far behind. When he decided to turn his bike around, he slowed to almost a complete stop. Chief put his left foot on a log at a near dead stop, with his left hand still on the handlebar under the clutch lever. The motorcycle dipped left, and the left handlebar was compressed against the log. The clutch lever was forced against Chief's left gloved hand, literally cutting off the tip of his left ring finger.

With the tip of his finger torn off, the injured finger bled like crazy. One of the guys returned and helped wrap his finger as best he could. And the tip of his finger? It was saved, of course. The guys placed it in a water bottle, ostensibly to be sewn back on when medical help could be obtained. **(Note:** somehow cops are ever hopeful about the abilities of surgeons to reattach pieces of torn fingers...think Officer Alvarez, chapter one).

Chief finally caught up with Diana. When Diana reached for a drink from Chief's water bottle, Chief yelled, "No! Not that one...my finger is in there!" One of the guys offered to go with Chief to a hospital, and while Chief agreed, he insisted on driving the two and one half hours to their destination himself. Eventually Chief was seen by a plastic surgeon, who used skin from one of Chief's legs to recreate the finger. While this escapade was not exactly vintage Chief, the fact that he did the driving and paid no attention to the pain is still pretty impressive.

CHAPTER 21

ON TO TRAFFIC DIVISION

1994-1997 – Burbank Traffic Division

Chief stayed in traffic division for three years. These three years were not a source of enjoyment – in fact, Chief was not very happy at all. The reason for this dissatisfaction did not involve the actual work. As you might remember, Chief is always happiest when he enjoys the people he works with. The lieutenant in traffic did not like Chief, and Chief had the same feelings toward him. Actually, this lieutenant was disliked by most of the employees of the department (and he hated me). He was known for being self-focused, and he enjoyed watching the discomfort of others as a result of his mental and emotional mistreatment. Although Chief got along splendidly with everyone else in traffic (as he almost always did with others), his difficult relationship with this lieutenant made this three-year period seem much longer than it actually was.

One more thing that made it a trying three years: an unsolved homicide case. Whether it was murder or simply a fatal hit and run traffic accident, a high school student was dead and his girlfriend was injured. This case proved to be the most significant disappointment of Chief's career. It all happened on "graduation night" for Hoover High School students from the City of Glendale. The Castaways is a restaurant up in the hills of Burbank, and it features a great view on clear nights. This ideal location had two parking lots – one at the restaurant and the other a short walk downhill. Near the end of the night, one young couple left the restaurant and began to walk down the hill to the lower parking lot. The rest of the story is a bit hazy and came from some of the other students who only saw portions of it. Another car was seen driving down from the upper lot at a high rate of speed and towards the couple walking. The car struck the couple and drove away. This terrible event killed the boy and injured the girl. Several of the student witnesses firmly claimed that it appeared the car intentionally struck the couple. If true, this would make it murder and not a traffic accident. Either way, for family and friends, this was a real tragedy.

As the investigator, Chief faced several difficulties and one advantage. Since the attendance at the Castaways was entirely made up of the graduates from Hoover High School, Chief knew (to a virtual certainty) that the driver of the suspect vehicle was one of the graduates. But many difficulties left him with quite a challenge. To start with, Chief was not called out from home when the collision occurred. He didn't learn about it until he arrived at work at his normal time the next morning. As a result, all the evidence was gone, and all the potential witnesses had left.

The description of the incident – or lack of description – created another problem. The collision occurred at night and the car was driving away from the restaurant, making an accurate depiction almost impossible.

And finally, while Chief knew the suspect had to be a graduating student, he was still left with about 300 students in the suspect pool – a huge number. Chief came up with a very good idea: he created a 10-point screening questionnaire and, using more personnel from traffic division, went to Hoover High to begin interviews. Chief and his assistants spent two days at the high school interviewing as many of that huge number of attendees as possible.

Chief whittled the list of solid suspects down to five, and heavy suspicion landed on one of those five. But that is as far as he got. Chief absolutely knew that one student was lying, but he simply did not have sufficient real evidence to make an arrest. Chief was forced to suspend the case. For those who have never worked as a police detective, “suspending” a homicide case might not seem earth shaking. But for those of us who have been detectives and suspended a homicide (especially one in which the victim is a high school student), the pain and disappointment are very real. The exact same thing happened to me.

When Chief left the traffic bureau to work his final assignment in personnel and training before retirement, he left with one true regret. He failed to solve a case involving a dead student. While this proves that Chief is human after all, it remained the only real regret in his career, and, as far as I know, his only “failure.”

While working traffic, Chief also qualified to ride a police motorcycle (in uniform), having successfully completed the rather difficult two-week motorcycle training course. All of our “motor” (motorcycle) officers worked traffic only, although they often helped patrol officers as well.

Never being one to enjoy sitting inside staring at a computer, Chief would occasionally put on his uniform, grab his motor gear, and ride around the city. He loved being outside. This represented something beyond unusual – it was virtually unprecedented. Detectives simply didn’t put on a uniform, hit the street, and look for trouble...or opportunities to help others in the field. No one had ever heard of this before – ever. But if we keep score, this is not the first time Chief “blazed a trail.” This is simply another example of Chief being a different person from all the rest of us.

CHAPTER 22

FAREWELL TO FATHER - THE SECOND TRAGEDY

1995

Chief's father Allan died in 1995, and the end of that ordeal proved to be a terrible part of this story. Allan became sick and lapsed into a coma with Creutzfeldt-Jakob Disease (CJD, or mad cow disease in humans). He was kept alive with a breathing machine and tubes for water and food. In fact, he was being kept alive artificially. The Bison extended family discussed Allan's true prognosis with doctors, and they were given very limited options. All agreed that Allan would not want to live in this state, but they left the final decision of family preference up to Chief.

Doctors explained that Allan would live only a few days (certainly less than five) when removed from machines and tubes.

After a few days of gut-wrenching thought, Chief made the decision to remove all artificial life support. But Allan was not gone in a few days. He breathed on his own, but he no longer had access to food or water. By day ten, Allan was still alive. Chief was tortured by the circumstances, and the fact that he himself had been the primary decision maker. Day after day passed and his father was still alive – with no food or water. Allan finally died on day 14. It was brutal. During that 14-day period, I saw real intense pain and sorrow on Chief's face. Chief and I visited his dad during that period, and I can attest to one clear fact: Chief was tortured by the ordeal. The death of his father might not necessarily amount to a horrible tragedy, but the 14-day period of waiting certainly did.

Chief has truly missed his dad. He valued his father. All the more so after he lost him. And as the years have passed and Chief has carefully contemplated his father's life, he has come to one clear conclusion: Chief's father Allan was a truly great man. Not in the length of his achievements, but in the depth of his goodness. He was a man to be admired and emulated; a man whom other people could learn much from.

Chief's mother (Martha) was a very good role model. She was not Indian – her heritage was German. She was responsible and devoted to her family. But Chief's deeper relationship was with his father. In many ways they were alike, very much like the great Sac and Fox Indian Jim Thorpe and his father.

CHAPTER 23

BROTHER TOM - TRAGEDY NUMBER THREE

1997 – On The Telephone

I wondered about the relationship between his dad Allan and Tom, Chief's older brother. I learned from Chief that Tom was a "troublemaker." He didn't finish high school but later received his high school certificate via the GED process. In an attempt to straighten out his life, Tom joined the US Army. After leaving the army, Tom went on to be quite successful in at least one way – he became a millionaire. Tom began selling greeting cards through a Hallmark affiliate. He was good-looking and could be quite charming, and he became a very good salesman. Eventually, Tom owned his own large decal company.

But Tom had problems – alcohol, among others. He ran into business problems that included a business deal gone bad.

Tom drank even more after the business failure, and his life simply became a mess. On a night in 1997, an intoxicated Tom phoned Chief and said he was going to kill himself. He told Chief he had a gun to his head, and Chief used all the crisis skills he knew to try to talk Tom out of suicide. As it became clear that Tom could not be dissuaded, Chief arranged for Diana to use a neighbor's phone to call the law enforcement agency responsible for Tom's city (Tom was not aware of this call to law enforcement). As he continued to talk to Tom, Chief heard knocks at Tom's door over the phone and a muffled announcement from police officers. Tom obviously heard the officers at his door and yelled at Chief in anger. The next sound was a gunshot and Chief never exchanged another word with his brother.

Tom's effort to kill himself was not entirely successful – he was badly wounded and would never regain consciousness. Tom ultimately succumbed to his injury just after his 59th birthday. At the memorial service, Tom's widow blamed Chief for the way he handled the phone call. She insisted that bringing law enforcement into the situation brought about Tom's ultimate decision to pull the trigger.

Chief had two phones going at the same time – one with the Watch Commander of the sheriff's department where Tom lived. After the shot was fired, a field supervisor spoke to Chief over the phone and let him know that Tom had in fact shot himself. Chief asked only one meaningful question: were any of the first responders hurt? When he learned that no one else was hurt, Chief

sighed in relief and took his wife and daughter to Camarillo to tell his mother the terrible news. Tom's aim was off a bit that night. Although he was rendered unconscious by the bullet, he remained alive but comatose. Tom was breathing with the help of a machine, with tubes for life's essentials to keep him alive.

While Tom lay in a hospital bed, Chief and his family (including his mother) arrived. They met Tom's wife and two daughters. Tom's wife asked Chief if he wanted to see his brother, and Chief replied, "No!" She then asked Chief's mother if she wanted to see Tom, and she also replied, "No!" Tom's wife was very angry with the reaction of Chief's mother, and forever made her mother-in-law feel guilty about refusing to see her own son (which infuriated Chief). Chief told Tom's wife that he didn't want his mother to see her son in that condition. From that point on, Chief was an "outcast" and rejected by his brother's family.

Tom died about one week later, never having regained consciousness.

As Chief thought about all the people that were going to suffer from this tragedy (including Tom's kids), he did not shed a single tear. Empathy for Tom slipped away when Chief considered the fact that Tom's choice would bring terrible suffering for so many others. A type of anger replaces deep sadness (certainly for most cops) when we realize the deep harm and hurt one human can cause family and friends. The most difficult part of this tragedy for Chief was telling his mother and watching her suffer.

Knowing that I had extensive training and experience in hostage negotiations and crisis (suicide) intervention, Chief later asked me my opinion about his decision to call the police. I told him unequivocally that he had no other choice. I also told him that if he had not notified law enforcement and Tom had killed himself, Chief would have been blamed (or at least criticized) for his failure to bring in outside help. The bottom line was clear: Chief had two choices, and both were terrible. He was literally "between the bark and the sap." This was truly a no-win situation.

At Tom's memorial service, Tom's wife (and other family and friends) spoke very critically to others in attendance about Chief. There was harsh criticism of Chief's decision to call the police to Tom's house. I was there...it was enormously awkward and I was flat out mad.

For Chief, a man with as much intestinal fortitude as any man, the family tragedies now numbered three. His father dies a drawn-out death, his wife and daughter are attacked, and he is on the

phone with his brother when Tom shoots himself. I had been around tragedies, chaos, and lots of death. I had become accustomed to it all. I have learned to handle it all in a somewhat detached, managerial fashion. But I could not handle Chief's tragedies in the same way. They still bother me. I simply couldn't cope well knowing the pain and difficulty Chief faced not once, not twice, but three times. The very worst tragedy for me was the attack of Chief's wife and daughter. I simply could not handle that one, and my inability meant that I failed Chief – in a major way. This failure remains one of my deepest regrets.

CHAPTER 24

PERSONNEL AND TRAINING

1997 – Administration Division

From 1997 to 2002, Chief worked his last assignment at the Burbank Police Department. While he no longer investigated crimes, he performed an equally important function – he investigated the backgrounds of those who applied to be police employees. Chief and I overlapped for about one year in this unit, but not in the conventional way. I was the department's internal affairs investigator (as a sergeant), as well as the defensive tactics supervisor. My office was located in the personnel and training section, and I supervised that unit in a part time capacity.

While dramatic events were absent in this unit, one incident comes to mind that connected Chief and I once again but in a somewhat unusual way. Chief came to work on a Monday after a weekend of hiking and camping. He told me he was uncomfortable and showed me why – he had a fair amount of poison ivy outbreak on his legs. But the next day was much worse. Chief's legs were covered with the worst outbreak of poison ivy I had ever seen. The itching was driving him crazy, and he told me that he would have to take three sick days to close out the week because he couldn't wear long pants until it cleared up. Chief did not want to burn three sick days, but he couldn't come to work in shorts because of our department policy on proper detective attire.

That put the ball in my court. I immediately gave Chief permission to come to work for the rest of the week in shorts, and we simply agreed that Chief would only work out of the office rather than in the field. Chief expressed a bit of concern for me since he knew I was allowing an employee to violate a departmental policy. I told him not to give it another thought, because I could easily defend this "violation" to the Chief of Police himself. Chief wore shorts for three days, and I hope he realized that he imparted some level of common-sense leadership to his beloved younger brother.

Chief was now only about two months from retirement. It looked like he was going to leave the department with a remarkable record – he had never been sick. For any of us mortals, this would be hard to explain...but not for Chief. He attributed his robust health to his lineage – real manly warriors simply don't get sick. And then the unthinkable happened: Chief came down with the flu and he was very sick for a solid week. So much for a remarkable record, and so much for Superman – he was human (but just barely) after all.

During our interviews I asked Chief which officers he thought were really good at their jobs. I asked him to limit his evaluations to those he had actually worked with. Chief came up with very few names...in fact, he had to give long thought to this question. He finally gave several names, but I noted a slight absence of enthusiasm as he provided the names. This list surprised me a bit – with some of the names on the list, and some that were left off.

My Note: There is much I would like to say in response to Chief's selection of good officers – and, by omission, those he thought were not so great. I'm truly very tempted...but this is Chief's story, not mine.

CHAPTER 25

DIANA'S HEARTBREAK – THE FOURTH TRAGEDY

2001 - Home

Up to this point, Chief had endured three life tragedies (not counting the horrors of one year in Vietnam). But the pain and misery that come around in life were not yet finished with him. There are many people and many things that Chief has loved. But his Diana was at the top of all the lists – he has always been totally devoted to her. He is what I call a “one-woman man.” But his one true love received a terrible diagnosis: Diana had cancer. And she had the one type of cancer dreaded by all women – breast cancer. Tragedy number four had arrived. Many of the employees at the police department wondered just how many tragedies this family would be forced to endure.

The very thought of breast cancer actually made those of us at the department especially troubled. In the 1990s, three of our sergeants lost their wives to breast cancer, and all three women were in their 30s.

Diana's cancer was first suspected in February of 2001. A lumpectomy was performed in March, but doctors discovered that that procedure did not completely remove the cancer. In April, doctors at the City of Hope (undoubtedly the finest cancer center on the west coast) performed a mastectomy.

That was a little more than 25 years ago, and, so far, Diana is cancer free. Finally, with the fourth and final tragedy, the end is not sorrow and misery, but joy. But this joy comes with a cautionary note: Diana would need regular testing to ensure the cancer does not reappear. And with each test, Chief would watch and wait and hope. And, no doubt, Chief celebrates this miracle every single day.

CHAPTER 26

RETIREMENT AND CHIEF'S MOTHER

2003 – Anywhere and Everywhere

Looking back at his police career, we find even more very interesting facts. For one, he was never sick. Well, almost never. Chief contracted a bad case of the flu in his last two months before retirement. I was astonished because I had never even heard of Chief being sick. And I think I know why. Chief was only about half Indian by DNA, but as far as everyone was concerned (him included), he was all Indian. There was just something a bit magical about his heritage — as if he had special powers. Or an extra-large soul. I always thought of him as indestructible.

A second interesting element involves a very sensitive subject. After the attack on his wife and daughter, Chief could easily have left the department on a medical retirement (severe job-related mental anguish). I don't know if he ever considered it (as most of us would), but I never heard him speak about it.

And one last part that deserves the written word: Chief was a man born to lead and supervise. He loved that role. But his love for his family transcended that “calling” to lead in police work. While he watched many others receive promotions to sergeant and above who were often less competent than himself, he never groused about it. I never saw or heard one iota of bitterness. But you can be sure of one thing: bitterness and frustration plagued many other cops. Failing to gain coveted promotions was a source of difficulty for many others. Somehow, Chief was above it all. I just don't know how...

Final Note Looking Back

In the Gospel of John (Bible – New Testament), John the Apostle makes an interesting statement about the life of Jesus in the book's summary: “And there are also many other things which Jesus did, which if they were written in detail, I suppose that even the world itself would not contain the books that would be written” (John 21:25). The hyperbole in this statement is completely acceptable to biblical scholars because John is obviously using that description to focus our attention on the enormous amount of tangible good Jesus had accomplished. In a similar way, if I was determined to list all of Chief's accomplishments in the army and the police department, I might very well need more than one whole volume. But my intention from the start was to give the reader a good sample of the many things Chief has done – incredible, frightening, risky, awe-inspiring things. And Chief

has been in complete agreement with me on one point – he did not want the story “overdone.” Candidly speaking, Chief has felt awkward about this entire project because he simply does not see anything amazing about his life. In light of that reluctance, I’m fortunate that he allowed me to forge ahead with this book at all. His natural humility has made his accomplishments all the more amazing to me.

Throughout his retirement years, Chief and Diana traveled a great deal. Much of that travel occurred while riding on a three-wheeled (“trike”) Harley Davidson motorcycle. About one week a month, the retired couple used that three-wheeler to travel to many places, including Mammoth, San Diego, Pismo Beach, Moro Bay, Palm Springs, Kernville, Nevada, Oregon, Arizona, Washington state, and the Canadian border.

Some of their travel included trips via plane to other countries. One common denominator served to connect all of these trips: Chief is always happier outside doing things than sitting around the house doing anything.

2010 – Chief’s Mother

Chief’s mom suffered deteriorating health in her last two years. Diana visited her mother-in-law regularly when she was placed in a convalescent hospital. Chief’s mom did not know her own son or any of her family at the end. In her last year of life, she had apparently given up. Chief decided to visit her on one particular day near the end. Shortly after leaving the facility, he learned that she had died two hours after he left. The year was 2010, and she was 94 years old.

CHAPTER 27

ILLNESS

2003 – 2024 – Sick Warrior

After his retirement, Chief began to develop various medical problems over time. One of those medical problems was MGUS, a pre-cancerous condition that can lead to full-blown, life-threatening cancer. But so far, in the year 2025, cancer has not appeared.

Chief did experience a host of orthopedic problems as well: both shoulders (remember the rotator cuff he tore rescuing the girl), knees, hips, back, and more. All of this resulted in primarily two things: reduction in mobility and pain. Lots of pain. Chief has a very high pain tolerance. The only time I ever heard him complain of pain was right after one of his shoulder surgeries – and from what I've heard, he was in good company. Substantial post surgical pain is very common when they cut into your shoulder.

July 2024

The most significant medical problem came in the summer of 2024, when he was 77 years old. He noticed pain in his right shoulder and initially believed it came from his past shoulder injuries and surgeries. But the pain became worse and far exceeded any pain he had ever experienced. In fact, he was in absolute agony. Diana took him to the emergency room, and after several tests, they were ready to release him without a solid diagnosis. Diana stepped up and confronted the physicians, demanding more tests and more doctors. She plainly told them that something very serious was wrong with her husband and she was not taking him anywhere until they found the problem. More doctors and tests then revealed a massive infection in his right shoulder area. Once again, we find more evidence that doctors are just practicing medicine...they haven't got it down yet.

Since this problem was clearly life threatening, Chief underwent surgery to remove the infection. But as is often the case in similar situations, this led to all kinds of successive problems: kidney failure, back surgery, and brain surgery, to name a few. The problems that followed resembled a snowball going downhill. For the next three weeks, Chief's residence was the hospital's critical care unit (and surgical center). Daughter Heather was with her mom virtually every day as they both kept a vigil over a very sick warrior. Heather was a huge help to her parents during this entire illness.

More surgery followed and Chief was finally released to a post-operative care facility. That facility became his new residence for a further three weeks. Chief had just been released from the care facility when I called him out of the blue – the first time we had spoken in many, many years.

Last note about hospitals

Both the hospital's critical care unit and the rehabilitation facility shared a common view of Chief: virtually all of the staff fell in love with him. He became their favorite patient (probably of all time). Certainly, as we have seen, that is nothing new with Chief.

CHAPTER 28

PARTNER RETURNS

2024 – Lancaster - The Disciple Reappears

Which brings us to October 2024. Chief and I had sort of lost contact with each other over the last 15 years. When I heard from a friend that he was in ICU and in critical condition in October 2024, I practically fell to the ground. The despair and pain I felt are hard to describe. I was also consumed with guilt – and I knew the guilt was completely deserved. I had neglected the man who had done more for me than all other men combined. And I was without excuse. In this sense, I had let him down again. The only small saving grace was a plan I had developed in about 2012 that I mentioned to no one. I formed a lofty, possibly fanciful idea of writing a biography about the one perfect, true Sioux warrior I called “Chief.” But I procrastinated year after year, and although I made notes on the story line and projected topics, I simply left it at that. Strange, because procrastination has never been one of my shortcomings.

I found what I thought was an old phone number and called “Chief.” When I heard his voice just after his release from the hospital, I almost didn’t recognize him. His voice was almost unrecognizable. This could not be Chief. Chief was indestructible...bigger than life...immortal. In all fairness, Chief was still very, very sick...weak, and in enormous pain. The greatest Indian in America with a very high tolerance for pain was in agony. My mind flashed back to the evil attack against Diana and Heather, and I almost retreated into the same horrifying shell once again. Bad things that involve Chief make me an emotional mess. As I talked to Chief, I could clearly hear joy in his voice at hearing my voice. Joy from a man in physical agony. I resolved then and there that my crazy idea to write a book must become reality and see the light of day.

My wife and I drove up to the Bison house to reunite with them, and to explore my idea of a book about his life.

The first thing I did was give Chief the big surprise. I told him that I had been hoping to write his life’s story for many years – I even had thought of a title many years ago: “The Last Chief.” I had given a great deal of thought to this title and wondered if it adequately described a man I truly believed to be without peer. I believe the title is perfect – perhaps the only perfect thing about this book. Perfect because when Chief was made, the proverbial mold was broken - never to be used again. Strangely enough, Chief has mentioned often throughout months of interviews that he

doesn't really believe there is anything special about his life and career. And perhaps that innate humility is precisely why there will never be another Chief. It seems that, nowadays, everyone is very interested in blowing their own trumpet. Chief does not own a trumpet. A bow and arrow, maybe, but not a horn.

Then Chief made a statement that he would periodically repeat over 18 months of interviews. He couldn't believe I wanted to write his life story, for two reasons: first, it meant a huge amount of work for me, and he felt quite awkward thinking of me working for months on the project. Secondly, he didn't believe his life warranted a written account. Chief's inherent humility would cause him to reiterate these feelings many times. Without question, his unpretentious character made me love and admire him all the more.

A few months later I drove to Chief's home and introduced him to my 15-year-old granddaughter, Cora. Cora had heard many of my police stories and knew that I considered Chief absolutely indispensable in my own career. I had always reminded Cora that Chief was the greatest all around cop I had ever seen or heard about. And, without doubt, the greatest leader I had ever been around. Cora and I spent about one hour talking with Chief and listening to him describe Vietnam, police work, and a few big cases.

When we finished and I drove away from the curb of Chief's house, I asked Cora what she thought of Chief. She carefully collected her thoughts for several seconds and said with absolute awe, "Amazing!"

February 2025 – Illness Returns

But Chief's medical woes were far from over. The infection came roaring back, and he landed in the hospital again. Over the next several weeks, Chief faced more surgery, along with sepsis and Covid. Sometimes during this long second stay, Chief didn't know where he was or who his loved ones were.

Heather to the Rescue

Heather was a huge help again to both her mom and Dad during this second illness and Chief's second stay in the hospital. She came every day and stayed with Chief for four to five hours each day. When asked about the whole situation, she replied with clipped, succinct Bison logic: "I'm looking after Mom while she looks after Dad." Heather had to put her job on hold during this time,

and all were thankful that she has a forgiving boss. Heather kept everyone updated on Chief's daily status through Facebook, texts, and phone calls. I texted often with Heather during this time, and her heartache and sorrow were palpable. Had I known the load she was under, I might have texted her less often. But I was more than a little concerned – candidly, I didn't think Chief would make it out of the hospital. For a brief time, I forgot that he was indestructible.

Things got even worse for all of them when both Chief and Diana contracted COVID. Diana was very, very sick and confined to bed for two weeks, and Heather stayed with her dad all day, every day, and into each night. Heather put her entire life on hold for three weeks. The difference between both of her dad's long hospital stays? During most of this second stay, Heather pulled guard/nurse duty with her dad alone. Diana was more than very sick – she was terribly worried and frustrated because she couldn't be there with Chief. Diana thanked the Lord every day for Heather and all her care for her parents. While Heather is close to both parents, she and Diana are best friends.

And yet...there's Heather's dad, the man I call Chief. Heather's thoughts during her marathon guard/nurse duty on behalf of her father may well have drifted back to an essay she wrote at 21 years of age for a college class. It was a "timed writing" test that asked about the person you most admire. And Heather chose her dad. Some of the quotes from that paper are as follows: "The person I admire most is my dad. Almost every little kid thinks that their parents know everything. When I used to ask my dad questions, he always had the right answer. Even now (21 years old), he still has the answers to all my questions and 99 percent of the time he is right. There isn't anyone on this earth I respect, admire, and love more than my dad." And when I read that last line to Diana, she applauded! It seems just about everyone feels that way about Chief.

There were times when Chief didn't know who Heather was. Chief finally made it home, and the long rehabilitation process was upon them again. Chief once again suffered from intense pain and severe itching. He saw lots of doctors concerning his infections, pain, itching, and a host of other things...including the concerns of his oncologist.

July 2025

The big question Chief now faced was the possibility of cancer. A bone marrow test was performed, as well as skin cancer tests. The results: all negative for cancer. Those results frankly surprised all of us. But what a pleasant surprise.

CHAPTER 29

FINAL THOUGHTS

The Charge - A Reasonable Accusation

The casual reader of this biography will likely claim some amount of bias on the part of the author. Bias that is misplaced and in favor of Richard “Chief” Bison. They will come to this conclusion based on three primary points.

First, they will undoubtedly see me as “star-struck” in evaluating and assessing Chief. They will see a writer who loves this Sioux warrior, and by this love, paints an all too perfect, excessively rosy picture. They will not believe I am capable of writing an objective life story about Chief. In short, I will be found wanting as a serious, truth-seeking historian.

Secondly, they will not trust my account because Chief’s life story is frankly just too hard to believe. A man simply doesn’t do all those things so perfectly with almost no training, education, etc. In other words, they don’t really believe that guys like Chief exist in the real world...at least not in today’s world. They believe that everyone has flaws, and those flaws bubble up to the surface if you wait long enough.

Thirdly, Chief had no great teachers, trainers, or mentors to bring out the best in him the way I did. He didn’t have a master guiding him at key points in his development. His father even refused to allow older brother Tom to teach him to fish. Virtually all that Chief learned, he learned on his own. He occasionally told me that he watched others that were senior to him or were leaders and tried to learn from them. But I believe he was born with more leadership traits and skills than most everyone. Yet the absence of mentors makes the case for an unrealistic account more credible.

My Defense

I truly hope my response is worded carefully and respectfully...but when it comes to Chief, those that would doubt the objectivity of this account are just plain wrong. And I believe I can make the case that my descriptions of Chief are in fact accurate. So here is my defense of the accuracy of this account.

First, in terms of talent, skill, brains, and natural ability, I am indeed quite average. But I have worked very hard to grow and improve in so many ways. Being objective has always been a prize aim of mine. I believe others have noticed this as well. Now, all of us must admit that no one is objective. As a stand-alone word, it clearly implies perfection. While I realize I am not perfectly objective, I believe I am closer to the mark than many others.

In 1995, I had been a patrol sergeant only two years when the police chief's office asked me to become our department's "first ever" internal affairs investigator (we were shamefully slow in developing that necessary part of our department). They told me that I was the "complete package" for this assignment – that no other sergeant (of the 18 we had) fit the bill as well as I did. They carefully pointed out that this assignment was not mandatory – I had the right of refusal. While I was flattered by the praise, I absolutely hated the idea of investigating my own officers. But then they explained it this way: no other single position (other than police chief) was more important in representing the integrity of the entire department than internal affairs. A department that could not be trusted to objectively investigate its own could simply not be trusted at all. I was told that honesty and objectivity were essential requirements of this new job, as well as advanced skill in investigations. In addition, since no such position had ever existed at our department, the choice of the first person in that role was critical (and a bit scary) for everyone. I would have to blaze my own trail. When they told me that the department needed me, I told them I would be happy to take the position (while holding my nose). Without all that Chief did for me, none of this happens.

When I was later promoted to lieutenant and worked other assignments, the chief's office continued to occasionally ask me to handle a particularly nasty internal investigation even though we had an internal affairs investigator already in place (my successors). I was told again that they "needed this one done right." And they reiterated their belief that I represented the highest level of integrity and objectivity.

As I write these words, I've been retired for 19 years. I have continued to strive to be objective in assessing and evaluating both people and problems of all kinds. It is this commitment to objectivity that I have applied to every part of this biography. The fact remains that all who know me have described me as objective.

Second, I served as more than a witness to many of Chief's achievements mentioned in this book. From my first day sharing a patrol car with him in 1980, I have made careful mental notes of everything about him. I am certain that no one outside of his family asked him more questions,

about himself and many other topics. During our interviews, Chief himself often told me that he was astonished at my ability to remember so many things about him. Although I did not know it at the time, I have been preparing an account of his life since 1980.

Third, Chief's work record stands for itself. His combat experience and awards are a well documented fact, with photos included in this biography. His military record proves that he fought and survived the TET offensive in Vietnam. His police record is also well documented, including a photo of him just before his rescue of the 15-year-old girl on the overpass, and the subsequent injuries he received from that effort. He trained many officers and conducted lots of background investigations by the time his career came to an end. And one important fact cannot be overstated: Chief took a very average cop (me) and made something very, very successful. This is clear proof that Chief's teaching and training skills are absolutely exceptional. You have to be exceptional to move my needle.

Chief's time at the police department clearly shows tragedies as well, including the attack of his wife and daughter when he was called from home to the station one night to handle a major violent crime. Yet nothing stopped him. Nothing.

Fourth, his wife Diana has attested to many of the facts in this biography. Normally this would hold little objective value, but Diana is different. Diana Bison is a thoroughly level-headed, conscientious person who assesses people and situations with requisite skill. She may not be as talented in those areas as her husband, but who is? She has had a ringside seat watching Chief since 1970. I ensured that she was present when I conducted all those interviews with Chief because I trust her completely. In some cases, Diana corrected either Chief or me to ensure the record was accurate according to her memory (and between the three of us, her memory is, in some ways, probably the best). Diana, more than most people I know, simply speaks the truth without exaggeration.

Note on Diana's Observations: Diana was very clear about one point with respect to her assessment of Chief. Diana has been married to Chief for 54 years, and from the first year to the time of this writing, Chief has been sought out for advice and guidance by virtually every friend, neighbor, and family member they have had. All have quickly seen Chief's leadership, common sense, and sound judgment. Diana and Chief's mother both agree that Chief was born to lead and inspire confidence in others.

Fifth, in my 45 years associating with the people of the Burbank Police Department, I have never heard a single unfavorable word against Chief. What I often heard was silence. Most people were

in awe of Chief – the type of awe that leaves one without words. The silence was also due in part to a begrudging respect from some who clearly realized that Chief was in a league above the rest of us. At a bare minimum, virtually everyone realized that Chief is different. Chief clearly represented a threat (or at least stiff competition) to the careers of many others on our department. When Chief chose not to promote past detective, many colleagues breathed a sigh of relief.

Sixth, there is the matter of the many differences between Chief and me. It was Chief who first noticed, and pointed out to all observers, that he and I are almost polar opposites in some ways. Most of our differences center around personality and lifestyle, not in essentials like professionalism, integrity, and concern for others. Nevertheless, our differences were obvious to those who watched us work as partners. I think other folks saw us as an unusual partnership (possibly an odd couple?). Consider several examples: Chief loves a glass (or more) of wine. I can't stand the taste of wine. In fact, I haven't even tasted an alcoholic beverage since New Year's Eve, 1976. While Chief's language would not be described as colorful, he does occasionally use words that are a bit unfit for children. My family (and those at the department) have never heard one word of profanity come from my lips. Chief is comfortable in his beliefs that are more consistent with his Indian heritage. I have been a devout Christian since 1985.

I bring these differences (and more) to the reader's attention only to point out an absence of lifestyle sympathy. By themselves, these differences prove nothing either way about the case of bias in favor of Chief. I only bring them to your attention because, along with the first five reasons listed, they possibly add something interesting to my total defense. Police partners with little in common sometimes struggle to work well together. Often, they just don't like each other and sometimes don't completely trust each other. Chief and I never struggled for a single second. We have always worked wonderfully well together, from the first minute. This fact is due entirely to Chief's talent with leadership and people skills. It has nothing to do with me for the simple reason that Chief was always the leader of our partnership, and, as such, was primarily responsible for the success or failure of that relationship.

And finally, there is still one fact that I believe is the most compelling when considering my defense. This fact should shout loudly to readers of Chief's incredible story. ME. No one at our department took the slightest interest in helping me, working with my meager skills, and growing me other than Chief. And the results speak for themselves. Through my first seven years, I was the very definition of average. Chief only had four weeks with me during those first seven years (when I

started in 1980). But Chief worked closely with me from 1987 through 1989, and, according to my promotions, awards, and commendations, I became an outstanding member of the department. And Chief never said a word to anyone about anything he did for me. If there is any doubt about my many accomplishments (thanks to Chief), come take a look at the large bin of awards under my name. Sometimes when I take a look at each award, I can almost see a small caricature of the great Sioux warrior just above my name or photo. Many others were quite surprised when I rose from mediocrity to excellence (including Police Chief Dave Newsham, who told me so). But none were more surprised than me. Yet somehow, none of this surprised Chief in the least. He wasn't even surprised when, as a lieutenant, I was chosen to train all of our new sergeants and lieutenants in leadership! Chief wasn't surprised, but I certainly was.

It is true that few other witnesses exist to verify the claims in this book, but the reason for that actually stems from one of Chief's finest qualities. He simply does not call attention to himself. Because of his innate humility, I often learned about him only by asking him question after question since 1980. I am only fortunate that he never minded answering all my questions. I've seen plenty of guys frequently speaking of their skills and accomplishments (not ladies - they are far too sensible and dignified). I've been around Chief more than any other single police department employee, and I've never heard him speak about a single talent or accomplishment that he possessed. That kind of guy just doesn't leave many witnesses.

Final Thought . . .

The Year: 1997

When was the last time you were aware of a person who truly recognized another person (or people) who helped them achieve a significant accomplishment? Some years ago, Mr. Rogers (yes, that Mr. Fred Rogers) received an Emmy award for a lifetime of achievements comforting and teaching little kids on his long running television show. He gave a brief acceptance speech to express his thanks. And then he did something no one in that position had ever done. He presented the following invitation to the audience, summarized as follows:

Fred Rogers: All of us have had wonderful people helping us get where we are, and become who we are, including me. Some of the people who have helped me are here tonight. Some are far away. And some are in heaven. Would you silently take ten seconds with me now to think of those people who have cared about you and helped you?

The camera then scanned the faces of many well-known people in the audience, and many were so touched by this concept that they had tears in their eyes. And to almost everyone there, it was a new concept. The idea should not have been new, but it was...and still is.

Chief is that man to me. I have said many times in this biography that I am quite average at best. That is the truth. And yet, despite being so very average, I have a large bin full of awards, accomplishments, and achievements gained in my 27 years as a police officer – much more than most in this occupation. The plain truth is that my bin does not exist without Chief – or if it did exist, it's nearly empty. From my first day, Chief was the Burbank Police Department. He was the quintessential police officer, and, as such, the ultimate role model.

The Change

There was one key point in time, as I look back, where I grew from an average cop into a really good (dare I say, excellent) cop. That point occurred in 1987 when I was promoted to detective - my dream job. But I was truly lost, and I knew it. For the next 18 months, Chief took me under his wing and made me into the cop I became. That 18-month period should convince even hardened skeptics that I was really in need of help. And Chief loved the whole process. I believe he loved me as much as the opportunity to do what he loved: teach police work and train others while working to do the job just a little bit better. But Chief didn't do all this training solely because he loved it. He did it because the citizens of Burbank deserved it, as he occasionally reminded me over the years. And don't forget, Chief never once mentioned the help he gave me to a living soul. In fact, I believe he took steps to hide it to preserve my dignity. To describe that as "rare" is an understatement. The mold for Chief? Broken...never to be used again.

My final final thought: I did nothing to help Chief all those years. How do you help a man who is the best at everything? And he did everything to help me...and change me. So I now say thank you, with all my heart, to Richard "Chief" Bison...the Very Last Chief.

First Note to Reader: make a "game" of counting how many times in this book Chief saved a life. And don't forget to count the lives I saved. And I saved plenty – four that I'm certain of, but likely many more. Without Chief, most likely I save none.

Second Note to reader: make another "game" of counting how many times in this biography Chief had a brush with death. Where he could have or should have been killed. You may be surprised at the number. (Some game, huh Chief?)

January 2026
Addendum

The Words of The Last Chief:

Well, I thought that as long as I'm alive during the writing of this biography, it would be appropriate to thank all of those that have made this life an 'E' ticket adventure.

First, I don't have any words that can describe my true thanks to David Gabriel for thinking my life might be worth documenting. The amount of time, effort and love that has gone into this writing is far beyond my comprehension. Dave was the best rookie cop I ever trained. He was the best partner you could ever wish for. Towards the beginning of this biography, he asked me to name memorable cops I had worked with. Well, I intentionally left one officer's name out, feeling that he should be mentioned at a more appropriate time. Well, that officer, detective, sergeant, and lieutenant is David Gabriel. I can't tell you how proud I am of his career. It humbles me to think I had a little to do with this.

Now moving on, I would like to thank my lovely wife Diana for affording me the true pleasure of giving me 54 years and counting of true love and more adventures than I would have ever dreamed of. And to Heather for being the wonderful daughter and mother she has become. To Barton for being a wonderful son-in-law, and to Wacky, Nanny and Umpa Lumpa. Thank you all for being the best granddaughters a man could ever dream of having...such memories! I want to thank all my friends for contributing to a life of wonderful memories.

I want to give a special thank you to our best friends, who have given me and my family such wonderful memories and adventures. You know you are thought of as family. So, a big thank you, Kerry, Carol (Munchkin and Gizmo Schilf).

In conclusion, I believe life is but a memory and I am so thankful to all of you.

*With true love,
Richard Allan Bison (The Last Chief).
11/4/2025*

EPILOGUE

End of Watch – February 2026

Just days before this book was completed, Chief faced another difficult surgery. The artificial right hip that had been inserted many years ago was acting up and needed a major change. A significant amount of infection was involved before the surgery, and doctors warned Chief that this necessary operation could possibly be a bit complicated.

Chief's surgery took place on February 10, 2026. The problems encountered by the surgeons required desperate measures – they were forced to break his femur in three places to replace the artificial hip. More than seven hours later the operation was over, and Chief was wheeled into ICU because of his weakened condition and the complications of surgery.

Things quickly deteriorated and Chief's overall health was in serious jeopardy. Sepsis, kidney failure, and heart problems were part of it, but his dangerously low blood pressure might have been the worst part of his condition. The medical staff did a great deal to address the problems, and then decided to intubate him. But before they did, he managed to tell some of the medical team that his favorite partner from the past had written a book about him!

Overnight, Chief “flatlined” (also known as “coded”), but the medical team was able to resuscitate him. Over the next 20 hours, Chief's condition was monitored closely, and it was clear that he was struggling to live.

At seven minutes before midnight on February 12, Chief died. He was 78. The Last Chief was gone. As the news slowly trickled out, the passing of the Last Chief brought immense hurt, overwhelming sadness, and a significant hole in the lives of those he touched. His death was impossible. Unthinkable. Chief was indestructible. It wasn't real. Can something (like time) be reversed? A man like Chief brings crazy thoughts to mind.

Larger than life? No one fit that description better. I now remember the inner drive that enabled Chief to move forward after so many personal tragedies. Life requires us to move forward...or give up. Give up? That idea was never in the lexicon of the Last Chief.